

A romantic scene featuring a woman with blonde hair lying down, her face partially in shadow. A man's hand is gently resting on her forehead. The lighting is warm and intimate, with a strong light source from the upper left creating a soft glow on the woman's hair and the man's arm. The overall mood is tender and sensual.

KENNY WRIGHT
TRAINING
TO LOVE IT 2

A Wife Watching Romance

ONE

"Another beer?" Lucas Hughes asked beside me.

"Yeah, sure."

He pointed to the cooler next to the patio door. "They're right over there. Get me one, too. Thanks, bud."

Asshole, I thought. I did want a beer though, so I went ahead and fetched it.

It was the Saturday before Labor Day, and we were at a barbecue at the Hughes's home. They had a nice, big backyard with a pool and a patio and a built-in grill. Even though it was early September, the DC heat and humidity were in full effect—which meant that the pool was in full effect.

The gathering wasn't large, but it was crowded enough that I didn't know everyone. This was the norm for me at these gatherings, where Erin was in her element, chatty and buoyant. Most were from the neighborhood, families with kids in the moms' club that Haley Hughes and Erin were in. The older children splashed in the pool. The younger ones toddled about on the lawn, including my own daughter, Mary, while Haley watched them.

I stooped down and retrieved two beers from the cooler. I could hear Martin and the Hughes boy, Andy, whooping inside.

"Here you are, man," I said, handing Lucas a longneck bottle of some microbrew that I didn't recognize.

"Thanks. Cheers." We knocked bottles and took our swigs. I swallowed deeply.

"Hey, you okay?" Lucas asked. "You seem...I don't know. Off or something."

I stared at him. I always wrote Lucas off as a jackass, so it surprised me when he showed this kind of empathy.

"Just got a lot on my mind," I said.

That was an understatement if there ever was one. It had been a week since my wife, Erin, had had sex with another man—her personal trainer, AJ. It was the culmination of my wife-sharing fantasy—*our* wife-sharing fantasy, I reminded myself. Erin was just as into the indiscretion as I was.

The Monday following her return had been surreal. I had to go back to work, of course, and it had been so strange to walk into an office where no one had a clue that my life had just been changed forever.

Erin had a boyfriend—or *boy-toy*, or *fuck buddy*, or whatever she wanted to call him. I wasn't the only man to know how good she felt with her legs wrapped around my back, or how she tasted when she kissed, or the way she moaned when she came.

And the thing was, I loved that fact.

Lucas interrupted my thoughts. "Work?"

"Hm? Oh, yeah. Work." It wasn't even a lie. On top of the life-changing event of last weekend, I had this big problem at work.

"I heard you got some big promotion," he said.

"Yeah. I'm now the commercial real estate manager of our southeast region."

"Congrats, man."

"Thanks. And it's going fine, mostly. But I've got this one office, out in New Orleans, that's underperforming now. And they used to be one of the best offices in the region."

"Huh." Lucas scratched his cheek. "Was the guy over there in line for your new job?"

"Probably. But I thought about that. I mean, it seems pretty convenient that this high performing office starts putting up bad numbers right after I take over as boss, but I don't think he's fixing the numbers or anything."

Lucas nodded. "Maybe not that, exactly, but he may have talked to his guys to not put in the same effort as before. To try just a little less. Fuck the new guy and all."

I hadn't thought of that angle. Seemed so wrong that Brian Benoit was sabotaging the company for personal gain, but I suppose it was possible.

Before I could answer, though, Lucas clapped me on the back, looking toward the patio doors. "Finally, your wife's here."

Erin stepped out into the sun, looking amazing. It was tank top weather, and she was taking full advantage. Hers was pale pink, and I could make out the halter tie of her bikini tied behind her neck. Her Daisy Dukes revealed just how good three months of intense training could make her legs. In a pair of aviators and her hair pulled back in a tight ponytail, she looked cool in a way that I hadn't noticed before.

Erin had always been pretty in an approachable, girl-next-door kind of way: average height, well-proportioned curves, striking green eyes beneath a sweep of dark hair. But her training regimen had sharpened that beauty, and all the time under the sun had given her a rich, golden tan.

But when she smiled at me, she was my wife of eight years again.

While I'd shepherded the kids over to the Hughes's party, she'd gone out to pick up her friend, Jo, from the airport. Jo followed her out into the sun, ever the wildcat in a pair of skintight white shorts and a baby-tee that looked sinful on her full tits.

I'd always been attracted to Jo, although things had always been platonic between us. Her blond hair, curly and barely contained, reflected her personality perfectly, and until recently, it had always been Jo's stories that had shocked us, not our own.

"That's Jo?" Lucas said. "Damn, dude, she's almost as hot as Erin." And then: "You've hit that, right?"

"What? No, of course not."

"Shame." He might as well have called me a pussy. Lucas had a knack for reminding me why I didn't like him in

as few words as possible.

"Hey, Jo," I said, breaking away from him to give my wife's old friend a hug. "How was your flight?"

"Boring. And over, thank fucking God."

"Jo," Erin warned, glancing at the kids, who were thankfully out of earshot.

"Sorry. I need to get into mature adult mode."

"You can be whoever you'd like to be," Lucas said. "Hi, I'm Lucas. Welcome to my home."

"Hi, Lucas. Nice pool," Jo said, shaking his hand. I felt my gut tighten possessively, even though I had no right.

"Did you bring your suit? You're welcome to take a dip," Lucas said suggestively.

"Maybe later," Jo said with a twinkle in her eyes.

Erin cut in. "Come on, Jo, let me introduce you to Lucas's *wife*, my good friend, Haley."

A few hours in and with the heat bearing down on us, Erin was playing with the kids in the sprinkler, having stripped down to her cute, yet mom-appropriate, bikini. Lucas was in there as well, holding the sprinkler in his hands and spraying the giggling group (my wife included).

Jo sidled up to me with a bottle of beer for each of us.

"You better watch out for that guy," she said.

Lucas seemed to be directing a lot of the water at Erin, who looked great, her wet skin glistening.

"Yeah?"

"Yeah." She left it at that, although she studied me as she took a swig of her beer.

"What?"

"So how are you doing?" she asked.

"What do you mean?"

Jo tipped her head to the side. "I don't know. What do you think I mean?"

We stared each other down, Jo's half-smile, my nervous one. Could she hear my beating heart, because I sure as hell could. I didn't know what to say. I tried to think back to the

last time she'd visited, when AJ was just Erin's personal trainer.

She knew. She had to know.

"This is all crazy, isn't it?"

Jo's eyes lit up. "So it's true!" She smiled, taking a long, exaggerated breath. "And no, I don't think it's crazy at all. Actually, I'm kind of jealous."

My heart raced.

"She told you?"

Jo realized that she'd spilled the beans. She glanced at me, studying me before speaking. "I figured it out. She's not a great liar. But...I think she needed someone to talk to about it, you know?"

Maybe I was naive, but I always thought that this fantasy would remain a secret between me and Erin. But now Jo knew. How could I ever have a normal conversation with her again? I took a deep breath and tried to find that normalcy. "And you knew all about it, right? With that old boyfriend?"

Okay, so maybe a new normal.

"Erin tell you that, did she?" Jo chuckled.

I'd forgotten that I'd eavesdropped on that conversation, so long ago. I wasn't supposed to know that Jo used to have a boyfriend who liked watching her have sex with other men. But I did know, and I couldn't stop thinking about it.

Jo went on. "Eh, that's not exactly the same. I mean, that was fun in a...you know, a physical way. I'm a self-confessed exhibitionist, so having one guy watch me as I'm with another is right up my alley. But what you and Erin have is totally different. You've got this bond that just seems to get stronger every time I see it."

It was nice to hear that observation from an outside observer. It helped stymie that feeling of *what the fuck are we doing* panic that seemed to follow me around lately. "Thanks," I said.

"It's scaring the shit out of you," Jo said.

That Jo, she's a perceptive one. I nodded.

"Of course it is," she said. "But that's a good thing. If it didn't, then that'd be the real problem." We watched Erin pick Mary up and swing her around, our daughter giggling. "Think about it like a muscle. The whole point of lifting weights is to break down the muscle. You put all this tension on your biceps, or your abs, or whatever, and at first, everything burns, right? But in the end, that muscle is stronger for it."

"A training metaphor? You've been talking to Erin, haven't you?"

Jo laughed. "Not exactly, but she *has* been talking a lot about exercise lately. I guess that's where my brain goes when I'm thinking about her."

"So you think we'll be stronger because she's fu—" I stopped, glancing at the kids. "Because she's with someone else?"

"Isn't that what I just said?" She took a swig of beer. "Relax a little, Tom. Enjoy the ride for once."

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After the barbecue, we all packed up and headed home, wiped out. The kids went down early, having eaten enough junk food that trying to feed them dinner would have been pointless.

I prepared a light salad. Erin cracked open a bottle of wine. The three of us sat on the back porch, enjoying the last of the summer evenings before autumn took hold.

The conversation was as light as the meal, all three of us ignoring the AJ-shaped elephant on the porch. That discussion would probably come before the end of the long weekend, but not tonight.

Towards the end of the meal, Jo announced, "You know, I fucking hate the summer humidity here, but this is pretty

much perfect.”

The tree swing was still. I could see a college football game on through the windows of the neighbor to our right, although I couldn’t see the score. After the bustle of the day, things were finally calm.

“Yeah, pretty perfect,” Erin agreed.

“You’ve got a nice life, sister.” Jo swirled her wine around, then finished it off with one swallow. “Sure I can’t convince you to come out with me tonight?”

“Next time you visit, I’ll be up for it, but not today. I’m beat.”

Jo shrugged. “Suit yourself.”

“Besides, you’ve got a mission, and I’d only get in the way,” Erin added.

“Nah, you’d make it even more fun.”

“What are you two talking about?” I asked.

Erin stood and started clearing dishes. “I’ll tell you about it later.”

Erin and I cleaned up as Jo slipped upstairs to take a shower. “She knows,” I said as I dried out the wooden salad bowl.

Erin paused wiping the counter down, looking sheepish. “She figured it out.” Then, when she heard the excuse for what it was, she added, “I’m sorry. I should have told you.”

“You should have.” But what would I have done differently? “I guess I just always thought that this would stay between the two of us.”

She looked up at me, forcing a smile. “Kind of hard to keep something like this just between us. It inherently involves others.”

I couldn’t help myself from smiling with her.

Erin crossed over to me and wrapped me in her arms. Instinctively, I hugged her back. I breathed her in, smelling her sunblock and the day’s exertion beneath. No one else smelled as good as Erin to me. Pheromones, I suppose. I wanted to hug her forever.

Erin looked up at me, her green eyes luminous. Her irises were edged with darker green, giving her the stare of a wild cat. "You know, I never intended to tell another soul, but...I'm glad she knows. It's been good, having someone to talk to about it."

"You've got me?"

Erin shook her head. "Not you. You're too close. I needed someone to give me an outside perspective."

"To give you a sanity check."

Erin laughed. "Kind of, although Jo's not the most sane of my friends."

"You said it, not me."

Erin hugged me tightly. "I love you, Tom. And she loves us. You know we can trust her."

"I know." And it made sense. She'd had sex with another man—her personal trainer—for the first time in well over a decade. We'd gone from a "conventional" marriage to a more open one. That was a lot of change for anyone, and she needed a friend to talk to. Hell, thinking about it like that, I could have used someone, too, although there was no way in hell I was going to confess this kink to anyone I knew. I could just see how that conversation could go:

I get off on sharing my wife with other men.

Seriously? Doesn't it make you angry? Jealous?

Sure, but also really turned on.

What are you, some kind of wimp?

I stopped it there. Erin was studying me. "I think it's good," I said. "Wish I had a friend like that."

"You could always tell Lucas." We shared a laugh. "Or AJ. He *is* a bartender part time."

"You could always talk to me, too." Jo's voice startled us from our moment. I hadn't realized how close I'd moved to Erin until she was practically in my arms.

"Good shower?" Erin said, going back to the dishes.

"Amazing."

I finally took in what Jo was wearing. *She* looked amazing. Skin-tight jeans. A low-cut black blouse. Her cleavage in full effect. "Wow, Jo, you clean up good," I said.

"Oh, this? Think AJ will like it?"

Her long, curly blond hair spilled around her shoulders, as wild as her personality. She was going after AJ?

"Just one other thing," Erin said. She pulled off her rings, the wedding band and diamond engagement one, and passed them along to her friend. "That'll make you irresistible to him."

"You don't think he'll recognize them, do you?" she asked.

"Are you kidding me? He's not the kind of guy who pays much attention to jewelry. He'll see that you're married and move in. You'll see."

Erin and Jo hugged. "Wish me luck."

"How about, *have fun*, instead. And make sure you drink plenty of liquids."

"This isn't my first rodeo, babe." Jo smiled at me. "See ya, Tom."

When she was gone, I turned to Erin. "You sent her off to AJ?"

"Perceptive. I knew there was a reason I married you."

"Why?"

"Jo wanted to know what he was like. I told her the best way to find out was to try him herself."

I stared at her. Was this the same woman who used to blush at Jo's stories? "That doesn't make you jealous?"

"No. Why should it? It's not like we're exclusive or anything. I know where I stand with him."

"Which is?"

Erin could have been glib, but she took her time before answering. "Let's talk about this. What should he be? A one-time moment of insanity, or...?"

My heart jumped at the open-ended question. To stop now wasn't an option. "Or. Let's go with that."

“So you’re okay with me seeing him again?” She pressed herself against me, gently touching my shoulder. I stared down at her lips, moist and parted.

“As long as I get to hear about it.”

“You always will,” she said. She kissed up my neck. “Every booty call.” Up my jaw. “Every hook-up.” To my ear. “Every time we sneak away and he makes me go down on him.”

My blood sang through my veins, making things dizzy. I was agreeing to let my wife start an affair. And I’d never been harder.

“Is that what you want?” she asked.

“Is it what you want?” I asked back. “Because if it is, then yes. Definitely.”

She drew back with the look of satisfaction.

“Great, because I was thinking about tomorrow night, and how we should take advantage of Jo being here, and free babysitting.”

“I’m not following. You want to go out on a date?”

“With AJ.”

My breath caught.

“And I’d like you to watch.”

I licked my lips.

“Interested?” she asked.

Was I ever. “How?”

“I’m still working out those details. I’ll let you know what I figure out tomorrow.” She held out her hand. “Now, want to take a shower with me?”

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We were in a new phase now, and it scared and thrilled me that I didn’t know where it led. I paused just inside the door, watching her as she shimmied out of her yoga pants and shirt. She wore a white workout thong and no bra. Her ass was a fucking work of art—plush, heart-shaped, yet

tighter than it had ever been. But it was the small Ironman tattoo on her left shoulder that drew my attention—a red M with a dot over the top, no wider than a couple of inches. It represented so much more than the race she'd run.

Erin was looking over that shoulder. "You just going to stand there?"

The water cut on. She pushed her thong off and she stepped inside. I hastily took off my clothes, already hard.

Erin wet her hair, letting the water cascade down her body. Her trim body was lightly tanned from all the outdoor training. I could just make out the shape of her racerback bra in the faint tan lines.

I pressed myself against her, kissing her shoulder.

She half-turned to me, reaching back to curl a hand around my shaft. "Mmm, this for me? Or are you thinking about tomorrow night?"

Momentarily, I'd forgotten about her meet-up tomorrow night. With the reminder, my erection grew. Erin squeezed it, giving it a few wet strokes.

She turned to me, touching my chest as she flattened her body to mine. I could feel her hard nipples against my skin. "I'm excited, too," she whispered.

"Have you missed seeing him?" I asked, my voice hoarse.

"Yes, although this past week has been good, too. I needed it." She kissed my chin. "*We* needed it."

I dipped low and kissed her passionately, my tongue meeting hers. She spoke the truth. We'd spent the days since her return from Annapolis fucking each other silly. Thursday was the only day we took a break, too exhausted from the nights before. I think that we were both trying our hardest to reassure the other of our love.

I walked my hands down her back, grabbing her ass as we kissed. Her hand found my cock again, beating me off. She broke the kiss and looked up at me. "Aj is excited, too."

My heart rate spiked. "You've been talking?"

“There have been some texts.” She lowered herself to her knees, her eyes never leaving mine. “He told me he couldn’t wait for me to do this again.”

With that, she took my cock into her mouth, bobbing swiftly along my length. I groaned, my balls stirring. My fuse would be short tonight.

“I bet he can’t wait.”

She pulled back and cleared her throat. “He couldn’t seem to get enough of it the last time. But then again, I couldn’t get enough of it, either.”

She rose, kissing my stomach and chest. I started to protest when she turned away from me and grabbed her loofah. “Let’s get clean before we run out of hot water.”

I sighed. When had Erin gotten so good at teasing me? I knew better than to protest, though. That would only lead to more resistance and denial. She’d trained me well.

“Lucas looked pretty good,” she said as I ran the sponge down her back. I nearly choked. Of all the people to tease me with, Lucas was one of the guys that I’d always considered off limits. Apparently Erin didn’t. “We should have gone to more pool parties earlier in the summer.”

I could see her watching me out of the corner of her eye. She was looking for a reaction. I didn’t give it to her. “You two looked like you were having fun out there. He seemed to like getting you all wet.”

Erin laughed. “You think?”

I guided the sponge around her, soaping up her tits and down her flat stomach. “Did he make you all wet?”

With my free hand, I sought out her pussy. My fingers glided across her bare mound, shaved cleanly just for AJ. The supple skin marveled me every time. My fingers glided lower, across her clit, across her smooth lips. She was wet and slippery. The notion that Lucas had contributed even a tiny amount to that was as infuriating as it was arousing.

“He has, yes,” Erin said, her breathing coming in fits and starts. “He can be quite charming when he’s trying.”

I ground my molars, jabbing my fingers deep inside her. Erin groaned, stiffening against me. "You're jealous."

"I don't like him."

She undulated against me, pressing one hand against the wall out in front of her. The other returned to my cock, which was as hard as ever. "He's cocky, that's for sure." She squeezed me. "And according to Haley, he's got a really nice *cock*, too."

I jerked like I'd been struck. Erin squeezed down on my shaft enough that it hurt, shocking me out of my imminent climax.

"You're not going to come, are you? I thought you didn't like Lucas?"

I blinked, getting myself under control. Erin turned to me, smiling triumphantly. I was busted. "I don't. He's an asshole, and you know it."

Erin nodded. "He is." She somehow agreed without agreeing with the insult.

"Let's talk about tomorrow night," I said. "What're you thinking?"

Erin looked at me, eyes glittering. For a moment, I didn't think she'd drop this Lucas thing. Then, she reached up, grabbed the shower head off its cradle, and handed it to me. "Make me come and I'll tell you all about it."

I took the shower head and lowered myself to my knees. We'd done this a lot in the past few months, too, although not since her triathlon. I set the shower head to pulse, but kept it at my side as I dipped in and teased her with my mouth and tongue. She spread her fingers into my hair as she cooed above me.

"Tomorrow night, I want to fuck AJ again," she said between sighs. "And I want you to be there, to watch."

I flicked her clit one last time before sitting back and stroking her pussy with pulsing water. Her body shuddered at the hard-pounding spray. I pulled it away before the sensation became too much, once again swooping in with

my mouth. There was a balance to this kind of play, and after all the practice I'd had, I was intimately aware of where the balance lay.

In many ways, the same went for our game—with the teases, with the extramarital play, with AJ. We were still feeling out that balance, but with each passing day, we were getting closer to it.

"But baby, I want you to know that when I'm with him, I'm with *him*."

"Okay," I said, uncertain what she was saying. My stomach squirmed.

"I may say things with him that I don't really mean, just to turn him on. I may act differently with him, too."

"Like how?"

She shook her head. I gave her a few pulses of the spray, like an interrogator seeking leverage. Erin moaned, pressing herself against the shower wall as her head lolled to the side. But she didn't give. Instead, she said, "But like always, I want you to trust me. Okay?"

"Okay."

"Now make me come."

I shuddered at the order, then obeyed.

I drew one of her legs over my shoulder, opening her bald cunt to me. For a moment, I just stopped to admire the beauty. She'd shaved herself for another man, not me, and I loved that that had happened.

She grabbed the back of my head and pulled me into her, smothering me between her honed thighs. I stopped admiring and went to work. With my left hand on her ass and the pulsating shower head clutched in my other, I called on every trick I'd learned over the last few months, and some I had been too skittish to try until now.

I skated my tongue across the buttery-smooth expanse of her pussy, teasing her lips, dipping my tongue into the slippery recesses of her before sliding up over her clit. I knew just how she liked it: chaotic swirls matched with just

enough suction to feel it. Then, I'd fade back, rake the shower head across the sensitive spots, and return with my mouth.

This time, though, as I danced down her slit and speared my tongue deep, I attacked with the shower head at the same time. Her body reacted like I'd struck her. "Ah, God," she groaned, slapping the shower wall wetly. I switched, tonguing her clit as I walked the shower spray up her thighs. She fought for air, her breath ragged. I guided the throbbing water pulse against her pussy, then walked it lower—across her pussy, her perineum, right against her anus.

Her fingers tightened in my hair. Her strained moans filled my ears, rising above the hiss of the shower. I didn't look up. I didn't need to. She was almost there, past the point of no return. I kept the shower head pointed against her ass as I focused my lips and tongue on her clit. My jaw hurt. I forced that down, flapping my tongue faster and faster.

"Oh, yes. Oh, yes!" she moaned above me. Her cries spurred me on. I covered her pussy with my mouth, sucking gently, my tongue never relenting. "Oh, yes!"

The leg over my shoulder tightened, crushing my head against her pelvis. She smothered me with soft skin and toned muscle. Her fingers held me against her as she thrashed, biting down on her scream. I dropped the shower head as I fought to breathe, but didn't fight to get away from her until she was finished with me.

At last she released me, bonelessly sliding down the tiled wall. I slumped back, too, my chest heaving, her sweet girl-come on my lips.

"You do that so well," she sighed. "I love how good that feels."

I stood, my hard cock bouncing before her, and set the shower head back to spray, back on the cradle. Erin reached up and took my erection in her hand, giving it a couple of strokes. "Come on, let's stop wasting water and get into

bed.” She kissed me and stepped out of the shower. “I want you to fuck me the way you hope AJ will tomorrow night.”

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TWO

Jo was back the next day, although she must have been out late. Sleep didn't come swiftly for me, and I don't remember hearing her return.

Her outing with AJ must have been successful then.

The thought of the attractive blonde crawling out of AJ's bed and getting dressed in the dark was almost as hot as thinking about Erin doing the same. It hit the same quivering emotions, too.

Why was that? Jo was a free spirit. Always had been. AJ wasn't her first one-night stand. But at the same time, the idea felt so erotically wrong. Jo litigated in a courtroom, winning judge and jury over with her quick wit and beauty. Yet behind closed doors, she was wild.

Was that naive to think? Sure. Didn't change how sexy the dichotomy felt.

I woke to an empty bed, although that certainly wasn't new. For a disorienting moment, I thought she was still training—that everything was still in front of us, the triathlon, the sex with AJ, the new phase of our life.

The fog of sleep faded. I heard Jo laugh out loud downstairs, and remembered my place in the world.

I dragged myself downstairs. It was just past seven, but miraculously the kids were still asleep. The barbecue must have really tired them out.

Just before I rounded the corner into the kitchen, though, something Jo said gave me pause.

"My God, babe, I feel like he turned me inside out."

Erin laughed. "So you approve?"

"You landed yourself a winner. I've had some... experience with guys—"

"You think?"

Jo ignored her. "And this one is special. He's fit. He's got a huge fucking cock. And the way he fucks... God! He's somehow aggressive without just being a machine about it."

Erin laughed. "Right? It's like he...controls me."

"Yes! Usually that sort of thing just makes me crack up. But with your AJ, I was too busy screaming."

"Yeah, pretty much," Erin agreed.

"But damn, girl. Tattoos? An earring? I didn't know you had a thing for bad boys. That's usually my MO."

"I didn't, either. There's just something about AJ that..."

"Makes you wet?"

"Classy, Jo. Very classy."

Jo's boisterous laugh eclipsed Erin's. "God, Erin, I'm feeling a little used this visit."

"And that's different how?"

"Ha. Ha. Not funny, lady."

"When did you get in, anyway?"

"Four. And there wasn't much sleep going on before that. I'm so beat."

"You still up for watching the kids tonight?"

"Yeah, I can, no problem. Just need a nap." She was quiet a moment. Jo asked, "You think he'll be okay... watching?"

That *he* was *me*.

"Yeah, I do. But if he can't handle it...that'll be good to know, too."

I heard Mary call out for us upstairs. I slipped away, going to fetch her from her room. I felt bad about eavesdropping, but not enough to say anything about it.

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I don't know how I got through that day. I couldn't stop thinking about what was in store for later that night, yet when I thought about it, time seemed to grow slower.

I tried keeping myself distracted with work. I went over the accounting numbers for all the regional branches once again, this time with Lucas's sabotage theory in mind. Maybe I wasn't focused enough, but I didn't see any shenanigans—just the same sagging numbers, beginning around the time that I came on board.

At last, our early dinner arrived. I made a stir fry. Erin put together a salad. Jo opened a bottle of wine. Jo caught us up on her life over dinner. Her real reason for flying out here was a client meeting Tuesday morning. She talked a little about them, filled us in on a guy she'd been seeing that was going nowhere, and then we transitioned into the latest media storm in national politics. I participated, although I paid more attention to keeping the kids entertained. Mostly, I was thinking of tonight, and what was in store for me.

After dinner, *Auntie* Josephine suggested a movie and the kids jumped at the opportunity. As they rolled out into the den, Erin grabbed me and held me back.

"Ready for some fun?" She was the same, bright-eyed woman I'd always known, but I saw the vivacious side of her peek out around the edges.

"Yes," I said, simply, not trusting myself to say more.

"Do you know where the boat launch is? Where I did my river swims?"

I did, but had never been there myself. I thought of the photos I'd seen of them, though, of Erin in a bikini, standing beside a shirtless AJ. That was before they'd become lovers. Before we'd entered this unfamiliar stage in our lives.

"I can find it. GPS."

Erin nodded. "Good. Go there now. Park in Lot B. It's a bit of a hike to the boathouse from there, but I don't want him to see your car."

My heart started to beat faster as I saw where this was going. "Isn't the park closed?"

“Yes, but you should still be able to get in. They just put a cone across the entrance. You could probably drive around it.”

“Okay.”

“I want you to go into the boathouse and wait. Make sure you stay hidden.”

“Hidden from what?” I knew, of course, but it seemed like a question I needed to ask.

Erin grinned. “From me.” She kissed me on the cheek. “And my boy-toy.” My stomach sank. “Now go!”

*

My heart was in my throat the whole drive out to that park. It wasn't far, just a half hour away, but it was far enough that the overdeveloped suburbs gave way to a more open space, to roads that wound through the dark, to more stars in the sky.

The park where AJ's small group had trained for their triathlon was closed, although just as Erin had said, only a cone kept visitors out.

I drove past the main parking lot, Lot A, which served the river. The lights were still on, bathing the park in pale yellow and making the trees seem even darker around. Tucked at the edge of that illumination was the boathouse, where the rowing skulls were housed out of the elements.

Lot B was further down the road, smaller and just as empty. I parked, took a deep breath, and stepped out.

The night air was warm-going-on-hot, a hint of the day's humidity refusing to burn off. Seemed fitting, I thought as I hiked back along the road. Out of the lamp light, nature pressed in all around me—the sound of crickets and running water, the damp smell of the river, just out of sight, the moon's pale light filtering through the thick trees. I wasn't much of an outdoor guy, but times like this made me want to try it.

When I rounded the bend and laid eyes on the boathouse, all thought of campfires and trips to REI fled. I was back in my moment of frenetic uncertainty. Was this really my life, that I had been sent out here by my wife to watch her have sex with another man?

I skirted the parking lot, afraid that Erin and AJ would pull in at any moment. Following the shadows took me to the water's edge, where the river ran dark and wide. There was the floating dock where Erin and her triathlon friends had hung out on Saturday mornings. It was funny to think of them like that now, like a memory of a summer fling. They'd been innocent to the point of naïveté—we'd all been innocent. Would that group ever reform again?

Circling, circling, I made my way to the squat shack about fifty feet away from shore. The boathouse had no doors, and while all the long skulls inside were chained up, I couldn't help but think how little security that offered. A pair of bolt cutters and a car with a rack would have been all it would take. But we weren't in the city anymore. The community here had more trust than that.

Trust. The word brought me back to thoughts of Erin and what we were doing here. I trusted her. I *had* to trust her. It was what made this all work. She may have arranged this evening, but she'd done it for us, together. She may be about to have sex with another man, but she'd set it up so that I could watch. How would this story end? I didn't know, but I took comfort in the fact that Erin and I would explore it together.

And maybe I was naive, but I couldn't wait to find out what came next.

*

I waited in the boathouse for what felt like forever—but in reality was closer to a half hour. I read the news on my phone, checked my email—I had one waiting from Brian

Benoit that I'd been avoiding. I shot him a quick reply that he needed to calm down and keep trying it my way. It felt good to have a little control over something.

As soon as I heard the crunch of tires outside, though, that sense of control slipped away. Headlights flashed across the interior walls of the boathouse. My heart convulsed. I crept to the window.

At first, I couldn't see beyond the bright headlamps, spaced widely on an aggressive grill. I thought of a hammerhead shark looking for prey in dark waters. They swung to a stop in the parking space closest to the boathouse, no more than thirty feet away.

Under the parking lot's floods, the car took form—an orange Camaro, sleek yet powerful. The perfect car for a guy like AJ.

I stood a few paces back from the window, in the shadowy recesses of the boathouse. I held my breath. I could hear my heartbeat. For the longest time, the car just sat there, taunting me. What was going on inside? I watched for rocking, but saw none.

At last, the passenger side door opened. A pair of legs emerged, shiny and bare save the tall heels she wore. My wife's legs. I leaned in to get a better look. She pulled herself out of the car, drawing a gasp from me. She was naked.

At first, I thought that my eyes were playing tricks on me—that she must have been wearing a skintight dress the color of her warmly tanned skin. But I saw her nipples, high and soft brown, and if I looked closely, I could see the slit of her cleanly shaven pussy. She glanced at the boathouse, seeking me in the shadows. I almost stepped forward, but then AJ emerged from the driver's side. I faded back against the wall.

Unlike Erin, AJ was clothed, although I didn't miss the way he zipped his jeans up before circling around the car. The action and all it implied landed like a lash.

“Naughty girl,” AJ said. His New Jersey accent seemed thicker than normal, laden with swagger. “You kiss your husband with that mouth?”

“I suck his cock, too,” Erin replied. Her dark hair was pulled back into a long ponytail. When she turned away from me, it whipped around her, alive and playful. She strutted around the front of the car, stroking the shiny paint job. If she were ashamed of her nudity, I didn’t see it in her body language.

“You ever suck it in a moving vehicle?”

“Now that would be a first.”

They met at the grill of the car. AJ pulled her against him forcefully, then ran his fingers over her lips. “I like being your first with things. Ever fucked on the hood of a Camaro?”

“Not yet.”

They kissed, deep and hard.

Maybe it was because I hadn’t seen them together. Maybe it was because I wasn’t prepared for the way Erin just gave herself to him. But as their lips met and they devoured each other, the air fled my lungs like a kick. If I hadn’t been leaning against the wall, I don’t know that I could have remained standing.

Thing was, I couldn’t look away. I couldn’t stop staring, even as they tilted their heads and deepened the kiss. AJ grabbed Erin’s ass. Erin tugged at AJ’s t-shirt, pulling it up to reveal his six-pack.

AJ pulled back enough to let her peel the t-shirt over his head. His upper body—worthy of a personal trainer—sent a wave of insecurity for me. With muscles that looked chiseled from granite, with arms as thick as my thighs, how could I compete with that? He had a large tattoo inked across his left shoulder—a dragon, aggressive and tribal.

Before his shirt was even completely off, Erin was sinking to her knees. Her back was turned to me, her head blocking the view, but I didn’t need to see to know what she

was doing. If anything, the fact that I *couldn't* see made it sexier. Instead, I was forced to stare at her own triathlon tattoo—the one she'd gotten with her training group...at AJ's suggestion—and the way her elbows flashed around her as she worked open his pants.

"Can't get enough of it, can you?" AJ said as he placed a hand on the top of her head.

Erin replied by yanking his jeans down around his ankles and freeing his cock. Again, I couldn't see. Again, it didn't matter. She shifted, reaching up to take hold of him before she ducked her head in. AJ rocked his head back and growled at the night sky—a wolf howling in pleasure.

"That's it, baby suck me until it's nice and hard."

Erin's long ponytail flicked impatiently across her bare back as she bobbed along him. I reached down, adjusting my erection so that it wasn't as tight in my pants. I thought about jerking off. I didn't.

AJ seemed to regain control. He looked down at her, touching her head again. "There's nothing sexier than a woman on her knees."

I winced. The Erin I knew wouldn't stand for that kind of misogyny. Surprisingly, she didn't protest. If anything, she seemed to suck him faster.

"Touch yourself," AJ ordered. "Get yourself nice and wet for me."

Erin's free hand moved down between her legs. Her hips jerked as she made contact with her pussy. She pulled off and said, "Already nice and wet for you."

"Then get up here."

She fished something out of his pocket before rising, dragging her naked body along him before their mouths met again. That wave of nausea rushed through me as I watched the exchange—funny that that should do it when I was perfectly fine watching her go down on him.

She pulled free of the kiss, shifting until she was between AJ and the car. I saw what was in her hand—a

condom wrapper. Still resting against the wall, I leaned forward in anticipation. She tore it open and fished out the circle of rubber.

I didn't realize I'd been holding my breath until my vision began to dim. Even then, I could only manage short, shallow gasps. I'm not one to dwell on another man's anatomy, but all the insecurities that AJ's physical fitness dredged up paled in comparison to what I felt as I watched Erin roll the condom onto his huge erection. He could have been a porn star, he certainly had the cock for it. It bowed inward like a scimitar with a fat, circumcised head and a pair of heavy, cleanly shaven balls.

AJ picked Erin up like she weighed nothing, placing her on the hood of his car. She braced an arm behind her, her ponytail off her shoulder, and looked up at him.

I had a great angle on the two of them—from the side, their eyes locked, her legs splayed around AJ's strong torso. She used her free hand to guide him against her mound. He grabbed her hips and pushed forward. Erin convulsed—and so did I. My stomach churned. My head spun. My cock raged.

Erin held AJ's eyes as long as she could—two, three, four thick strokes into her—before she tossed her head back and let herself go to the rocking sensation.

AJ *took* my wife. I'd never fully understood that expression until I watched the way he fucked Erin. He manhandled her, practically holding her body aloft as he slapped his hips forward, drawing him against her with each thrust. Erin rested her feet against his lower back, her tall heels pressing lengthwise, meeting at a point at the top of his ass. Her thighs flexed each time he thrust, encouraging him to fuck her harder. I don't know that he even felt them.

Erin's palm slipped on the Camaro's hood. She fell onto her back, stretching naked before her lover. AJ didn't slow. He didn't even pause. He adjusted to the new angle a moment later, pulling her sweaty body until her ass hung off

car. He set a knee on the bumper, changing angles, driving deeper.

Erin thrashed beneath him. My mouth had gone dry long ago, but I was still surprised when I went to swallow and discovered my throat parched.

Aj groped one of Erin's tits, teasing her nipple harder than I would have felt comfortable with. Erin cried out, pain mixing with pleasure.

"You like it rough, don't you?"

"No."

"Liar." Aj grunted. "Liars need to be punished."

He twisted her nipple. Erin squealed, arching her back and pressing her breast harder into Aj's hand.

"Let's see. How do we punish you, my slut?"

The loving husband inside of me bristled at the insult directed at my wife. The man with the wife-watching fantasy groaned.

Aj pulled his cock out of Erin. She protested with a cry. "Don't stop!"

"Don't worry. We're not done yet." He slapped his erection against her mound, teasing her clit before ramming back into her. "Has your husband ever spanked you?"

She hesitated before answering. "No, we don't do that." Then, a quick moment later, she corrected: "I don't do that."

Aj withdrew from her again. He pulled her to her feet, spun her around, and bent her over his car. "Time for a new first."

Grabbing her plush, toned ass cheek, he gave her a swift spank. Erin cried out, surprise eclipsing pleasure.

"You've got a very spankable ass, babe. I'm surprised you haven't done it before." Before Erin could form a witty response, though, he re-entered her from behind. All she could manage was a quick moan.

Aj spanked her again. I waited for the protest, or the laugh, or some response other than what I got—a

begrudging moan, delivered through clenched teeth. She was into this?!

The car rocked with their fucking. Their cries echoed out through the empty parking lot. My heart beat wildly as I listened, my cock throbbing. The sounds of spanking and Erin's sharp cries drowned everything out.

Erin hunched forward, hanging her head between her shoulders even as she raised her ass up against AJ's onslaught. He gave her one last, meaty slap, this time clinging to her red cheek, pounding her furiously.

Erin came, her scream seething out between her clenched teeth. AJ was right there, tossing his head back and roaring.

Somehow, I remained perfectly still. I didn't even touch myself, although I desperately needed relief. I could feel my sweat gather under my clothing. I thought about the nice, cold shower that I was going to take back home.

Erin's laugh broke me free from the revelry. When had I stopped paying attention to them? I looked up. Erin was leaning on the hood of the car again. AJ pulled his condom off and flung it into the grass—real classy.

"Good thing this park doesn't allow camping," she said. "You just alerted everyone from miles around what we were doing."

"Not like you were very quiet," AJ said.

Erin reached out and caressed his shoulder. "And you love how you make me scream."

The affection surprised me, tickling me with jealousy.

She said, "Come on, let's get out of here before the park police show up. I don't know how I'd explain *that* to my husband."

"My place for some more fun, then?"

I swear she looked in my direction, if only for a second. To ask permission? To taunt me? "I like the sound of more fun."

AJ pulled his pants on without bothering with his boxers. "We never made it to the dock," he laughed.

"Next time," Erin said.

Next time. The word haunted me, long after the Camaro had pulled away and it was safe to leave. I wandered out of my hiding place and started off to Lot B. I passed the condom, lying limp yet full in the grass. It nearly took my breath away.

We were in new territory, and I couldn't wait to explore it more.

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THREE

When I got home, the house was dark. I can't remember the last time I'd come home late at night to an empty bed. The air felt thick, my pulsing heartbeat filling the quiet. *That happened. That happened. Jesus, that happened.*

I didn't need to close my eyes to see them together. To hear the slaps that AJ had delivered to Erin's ass. To remember just how...submissive she'd been with him.

My cock was hard as I undressed, brushed my teeth, and washed my face. I crawled under the covers and checked my phone. Nothing. No messages. No texts. We hadn't discussed this part—the after. I quivered, uncertainty choking the air around me.

I thought about texting, then stopped. There was something pathetic about that. I thought about jerking off, but stopped again. There was something pathetic about that, too.

Before I could figure out what the hell to do, Erin slipped into the room. She was back in her clothes—a short, loose dress—and her hair was tied back. She looked at me, her green irises luminous.

"You're back early," I said. "I thought that you were going back to AJ's?"

"Are you disappointed that I didn't?" she asked.

I was, I realized. Before I had a chance to unpack that, though, she reached down and pulled her dress over her head. She was naked beneath. My breath caught as I scanned her near-perfect body.

"Not anymore," I said.

She crawled into bed, pulling the sheet away from me as our mouths met. She tasted differently. Was that him mixed in with her spit? Was that his come? It revolted me even as she reached between my legs and found me hard.

"I loved knowing that you were watching," she said. "I could almost feel your eyes on me when he fucked me. That was so sexy."

We kissed again, her hand pushing into my boxers. I stroked her lower back and caressed her ass.

"You're different with him," I said in between kisses.

Erin's eyes flashed down at me. "I am." She pushed her butt against my hand. "Did you like watching him spank me?"

"We've never done that... I didn't know you liked that."

"I didn't either."

She pulled my boxers down as we rearranged ourselves on the bed. I pulled my t-shirt off. She straddled me, pressed my cock against her pussy, and settled onto me. She was wetter than ever. Looser than ever. Because of AJ. Because of another man.

I groaned. Erin gasped. "I felt that," she said. "So you liked watching?"

"Yes," I said, my voice tight. "It's still so surreal though."

"For me, too," Erin admitted.

"You have a boyfriend."

"A boy-toy," she corrected, not for the first time.

"A lover."

Erin laughed. "Have you been reading nineteenth-century romance novels again?"

I reached up and touched her face, tracing the smile lines around her mouth, and the way it pushed her cheekbones up. The smile was infectious.

"He's just a little fun," Erin said. "You...this...that's what's real. Okay?"

We kissed. "Okay."

*

Somehow, sleep came. I had some crazy dreams, too. I was back in the boathouse, watching AJ fuck Erin on his car,

but this time I wasn't alone. Haley and Lucas Hughes were there, whispering to one another as they watched. Brian Benoit was there, too, watching just as intently. He seemed to notice me at the same time that I noticed him. "Must be nice to have arm candy like that on tap," he said with a grin.

I woke up before Erin—a rarity—who was out cold. She didn't even stir as I got out of bed, rubbing sleep from my eyes. I left her alone and headed downstairs in nothing but my boxers and a t-shirt. In my daze, I completely forgot about our guest. I was reminded a moment later, however, when I walked into the kitchen to find Jo standing at the coffeemaker in a similar state of undress.

Erin had some sexy friends, but in my opinion, Jo was the sexiest. That was made even more evident by her choice of sleepwear: a tight cami top and little pink shorts that didn't quite cover the cheeks of her ass.

I considered backing away and going for a robe when Jo caught me out of the corner of her eye.

"Morning, Tom. Spying on me?"

"No, I..." I was so busted. "That coffee smells good."

"Mmm hmm. I love coffee."

I licked my lips and tried hard not to stare at her ass.

"I don't mind you looking," Jo said, turning with her mug in hand. My eyes dipped to her breasts, encased in the thin material of the cami top. Her nipples pushed little points dangerously close to the hemline. "So long as you don't mind me looking..."

I realized that I was only in pair of boxer-briefs. Worse, I'd begun to stiffen.

"Um..." I needed to change the subject. "Kids still asleep?"

Jo's eyes lit up. "Yes. Erin still asleep?"

"Yeah."

She set her coffee mug on the counter top, pushed off it, and took a step towards me. "Did you get to watch them?"

“Yeah.”

Her eyes grew wide. “Was it as hot as you thought it would be?”

I was still getting comfortable with the idea of Jo knowing about this. “Jo...”

“Did it turn you on, watching your sweet wife fuck another man?” She approached, her hips swayed with each step. “Did he make her scream? He’s got a big dick. I bet he did.”

Jo closed in on me. I retreated, bumping into the kitchen table.

“She told me how much she liked sucking it,” she said. She knelt down between my own legs and reached up to caress my cock. Her hand felt like it was forged of fire.

“Jo, what are you—”

“Oh, Tom, don’t be such a boy scout. It’s nothing that Erin hasn’t done to him, right? Again and again?”

My cock grew long enough that it peeked out the top of my boxer-briefs. Jo took that as an invitation to grab my underwear and peel them down my thighs. I sprang free, a string of pre-cum trailing it.

“Very nice, Tom...”

I came to my senses, turning away and extracting myself from between the table and Jo. “What are you doing? We can’t do this...”

I crossed over to the counter, awkwardly yanking up my boxers.

“Isn’t that what you really want, Tom? To open up your marriage? Erin gets to play. Why can’t you?”

Jo was behind me again, her breasts pushing against my naked back. Her *breasts*. Bare. I looked back, finding her topless, the camisole forgotten on the kitchen table. Her mouth pressed up against my ear. “You know, I’ve got more than one condom. Come on up to my bedroom and show me what you can do with this nice, big cock.”

To say that I wasn't tempted was an understatement. I was. More than any time in my entire life, I was. But I couldn't. It wasn't my fantasy. It wasn't *our* fantasy.

Looking back at her out of the corner of my eyes, I found my resolve. "Jo, no. If you can't control yourself, I'm going to have to ask you to leave."

She stepped back, releasing me. "Good answer."

I shot a look back. "What?"

"You're a good man, Tom. Erin's lucky to have you." The seductress was gone.

"Still not following. I haven't had my coffee, so I'm a little slow."

"I had to know," she said. "I had to make sure that there were no ulterior motives."

I turned around, regarding her full on. She was still topless, and for the longest moment, that's all I could focus on. Jo's tits were magnificent—full like ripe grapefruit, evenly tanned, and capped with large, dark brown nipples. I loved Erin's body, but the tit-man in me appreciated the perfection of this pair.

Jo noticed me looking and smirked. "So do they live up to the fantasy?"

"Um...yes. I mean, there's no fantasy. I mean..." I scratched the back of my neck and forced my eyes to her face. "Can you put something on please? Before the kids wake up."

Jo laughed, crossing back to the kitchen table to fetch her cami. "For the kids. Of course."

"So this was all some kind of test? Did Erin put you up to it?"

"Does that sound like Erin?" Jo asked. She pulled on her top, mercifully covering those beautiful swells.

I honestly didn't know anymore. Erin was capable of anything at this point. "It was all you?"

"Mostly." She shrugged. "Like I said, I had to know. And you passed." She glanced at my cock, which was still hard.

“Barely.”

“You make a compelling argument,” I said, finally finding my smile. “But you know this can’t happen, right? Never could. I love her, Jo. I could never do something like that to her. You’ve got to believe me.”

“I do, Tom. And she’s crazy about you. If anything, giving her this freedom is only helping you be a great fucking husband. You know, I’ve never seen this side of her, actually. Not in relationships, anyway. As much as she’s having fun playing around with this young, hot guy, I think she’s getting off on what it’s doing to *you*, and the leverage it’s giving her.”

“So you don’t just talk about how big AJ’s cock is?” The question was meant to be light, but my voice nearly cracked at the end.

Jo laughed. “It’s not all like that, no. She’s working through a lot. This is huge—and not just the man’s cock. We spend a lot of the time talking about feelings: yours, hers—” She seemed to cut herself off, like she’d self-edited herself.

“AJ’s? You talk about his feelings, too?” That thought was painful to think, let alone say aloud.

Jo hesitated. “Yeah. Him, too.”

“Does she love him?”

“What? No! It’s not like that. That’s exactly it. It’s important that those kinds of feelings *don’t* happen. That’s one of the reasons she needed to talk to me. I’m the impartial judge. I’m supposed to suss that stuff out.”

“And there’s nothing there?”

“None, no.” Jo laughed. “You’ve met him. He’s not the kind of guy that girls fall in love with.” Jo went back to the coffee machine and poured out a second mug for me. “So anyway, what I was saying was that she needed someone to talk to, and some of this stuff she couldn’t talk to you about, obviously.”

Erin and I had gone over this, but I was curious about what Jo would say. “Why *obviously*?”

"I hate to play the men-don't-understand-women card, but *men sometimes just don't understand women*. There are some things she needs to get an unbiased opinion from."

"Oh, and you're unbiased?"

"Hey now. I'm at least impartial...ish."

"And your verdict?"

"Well, you're not doing this to sleep with other women, anyway. That's what I needed to know."

"I see." The coffee was bitter and black. Perfect. "You must think we're crazy."

Jo sighed. "I'm not one to judge. Not about stuff like this. I just got out of a polyamorous relationship with a guy and another woman. And yes, she was hot. And yes, we all had sex together."

"Wow," I said. I'd love to be a fly on that wall.

"Point is, I'm not your moral compass, nor do I want to be. My only concern is that the two of you don't fuck up what you've got now." She waved her arms around her. "You've got it so good—both of you. Nothing is worth all of this."

"You think that's something we should be worried about?" It was an honest question.

"No. I don't."

That was good to hear. I felt a tension leave me that I hadn't realized was there. Then she had to go and bring it right back with the next thing.

"I mean, here we are, talking about how much you love her, and she's passed out upstairs because she'd fucked another man last night." Jo slid off her seat and crossed back over to me. I stiffened, but all she did was kiss me on the cheek. "For what it's worth, I think what you two are doing is awesome. I just wish it was reversed. I wouldn't mind being the Other Woman here."

She stepped back, looked down at my cock, which was once again stretching the tight material of my boxer-briefs,

and nodded. "Definitely wouldn't mind being the Other Woman."

"Jo..." I said warily.

She raised her hands in surrender. "I know. Can't happen..."

*

The kids got up shortly after my encounter with Jo. Erin followed, exhausted yet happy.

"Coffee?" I said, already pouring her a cup.

"Please and thank you."

It was officially Labor Day, the unofficial last day of summer. The Hughes had already hosted the neighborhood for a cookout, but Erin suggested that we invite a few people over for grilling at our own home. "Nothing elaborate. Just the neighbors, Jo, of course, and the Hughes."

I didn't love the idea of seeing Lucas twice in one weekend. Erin seemed to read my hesitation. "Lucas is traveling. It'll just be Haley and the kids."

"Sounds perfect."

Erin studied me with those warm green eyes of hers. "He really gets under your skin, doesn't he?"

"What? No," I lied. Admitting that felt like giving Lucas a win, even if he never knew. I thought about what Jo had said last Saturday. "I just don't trust him is all. I don't like the way he looks at you."

Erin's eyebrows rose. Her smile was sly. "Tom, are you jealous?"

"Of Lucas? No. I just don't trust him."

"Meaning you don't trust me, either?" she asked.

I was walking into a trap that I'd set myself. That didn't stop me. "I do, he just..."

"He just gets under your skin," Erin finished for me. Here we were, back to the beginning.

I said, "You know, if I'm going to trust you, then you're going to need to trust me a little, too."

"But I do."

I shot back, "So what was this morning was about?"

Erin raised an eyebrow. "This morning?"

"Jo's temptation?"

Understanding broke across Erin's face with a mixture of surprise and amusement. "She actually did that... Wait, what did she do, exactly?"

I thought about Jo's breasts, full and...there. "She came on to me."

Erin covered her mouth, her laugh emerging shyly. "With Jo, that could mean...well, anything." She sidled up to me. "I hope you passed."

"Of course I did."

"What did she do, exactly?"

That she was taking this so well helped the confession, although I wondered what she would have thought had we not known Jo—or if Jo had actually been serious. "She stripped down to her panties and suggested we...have sex."

Erin's eyes went wide, despite herself. "Did she really?"

"Really." I touched Erin's face. "But I promise, nothing happened."

"That little bitch," she said to herself, shaking her head. At least the smile didn't waver. Much. She focused on me. "Thanks for telling me. And, I know nothing happened. I told her not to worry..." She looked thoughtful a moment, her eyes going soft. Then: "You don't want...something like that, do you?"

"Now you're sounding like Jo." My knee-jerk response was a defense mechanism. I did, but not seriously enough to even voice it. "She's your best friend. It's too complicated."

"So you'd be fine if she was some stranger?" Beyond the tease, I sensed a serious question—seriousness, but not jealousy. Would Erin really be fine if we opened things up that much?

"No, that's not what I meant. And you really are sounding like Jo." I took her face in both my hands and pulled her close. "This isn't about me getting some."

Erin's face broke into a smile again. "It's about *me* getting some. Kind of one-sided, don't you think?"

"Last night didn't feel one-sided."

"I loved that you were there," Erin agreed.

"We'll have to make it a regular thing then."

We kissed.

"So. Let's talk barbecue..."

*

The barbecue was a small affair, especially compared to the pool party at the Hughes's. Many of our immediate neighbors were at the beach. Haley showed up early with the kids to help Erin prep. Marcie and George joined us, along with Mark and Peter, the gay couple a couple houses down. A few families from the Mom's Club rounded out the group.

We drank beers. Watched the kids play on the Slip-N-Slide. I grilled hotdogs and burgers and relaxed. It was so normal, it was hard to believe that just last night I'd watched Erin get spanked by her personal trainer. I watched her laughing with the neighbors and just shook my head at the absurdity.

"What's that?" Haley asked. She stepped up next to me, a beer in her hand. She looked great in a casual way—wearing jean shorts and a plaid shirt with the sleeves rolled up.

"Nothing. Just marveling at Erin is all."

"Aw, that's so sweet," Haley said. Her blond hair fell loosely around her shoulders, making her look younger than her 33 years. "I've said it before, but I love watching you two together. You're so in love. What's your secret?"

I tried to keep a straight face, even as last night replayed itself in my mind. “Um, I don’t know. Lots of practice?” I felt like I needed to shift things away from us. I was still working through it all. “How are things with you and Lucas?”

“Oh, we’re pretty good. Wish he didn’t have to work so much. Or at least that his hours were normal.”

I looked down at Haley, so sweet and demure. Again, I didn’t understand what a woman like her saw in an ass like Lucas.

“Talk to the celebrities that he’s working security for. Get them to do shows during the day,” I said. I don’t know why I was covering for him, especially since I suspected he took advantage of those situations. Lucas struck me as the kind of guy who wouldn’t hesitate if some groupie threw herself at him, even if she were someone else’s groupie. Had he been in my situation this morning, he would have failed Jo’s test.

“I knew what I was signing up for when I married him, don’t worry. Doesn’t make it easier though.”

I chewed on that one for a while. Did she really know? I doubted that. Did I know myself? Absolutely not. I would never have guessed that the woman I walked down the aisle with would be capable of doing what she did these last few weeks. Marriage was all about discovery. I had to remember that.

FOUR

Jo stayed through Tuesday, then took a flight back to the West Coast. I was sad to see her go—not just because she was a good confidante for Erin, but because I actually liked her. Plus, the extra eye-candy wasn't bad.

The house felt empty without her vibrant presence. "The family unit, once again," Erin said, hugging me after we got the kids down Tuesday night.

"Couldn't ask for a better one," I said, kissing her softly.

She smiled and wandered into the bedroom, pulling her t-shirt off and tossing it onto the bed. She hadn't bothered with a bra. I grinned, reminded of one way we could pass the time.

I sidled up behind her, filling my hands with her soft, warm breasts. "Well, hello there."

Erin sighed, tipping her head to the side. I kissed her bared neck and up behind her ear.

"You feel good," she whispered.

Together, we unsnapped her jeans and pushed them over her hips. I knew what I needed to do. As she lay back on the bed, I crawled between her legs and kissed her mound over her panties.

I pulled her thong to the side and licked her smooth slit. She groaned, tossing her hair as I teased her.

Her voice was thin when she finally spoke. "You know it's Tuesday night, right?"

"Yeah," I said. I grasped her thong in my hands and pulled it off, giving me free reign of her wet pussy. I pressed two fingers deep as I tickled her clit with my tongue.

"I...ha...have a standing...date..."

The word *date* washed over me like cold electricity. My ears perked up. My mouth worked faster on her.

"Tuesdays and...and Thursdays. With AJ."

“To train?” I asked, my voice hoarse.

Erin’s smile was wicked. “Yes, to train.”

“He’ll work you *hard*?” I asked, ramming my fingers into her deep.

“Very hard.” Her husky reply wrapped itself around me and squeezed. She took my head in her hands and pressed me between her legs. The time to talk had passed. Did AJ go down on her like this? He didn’t seem like the type, but I knew now how surprising people could be.

Still, I couldn’t picture the muscular trainer between her legs. My mind kept getting distracted by what I’d seen last weekend—of AJ fucking her on his car, of AJ spanking her, of AJ treating her the way I never could, and how much she seemed to like it.

“Ah, yes!” Erin cried. The fantasy broke as she tightened her thighs around my head. But it wasn’t a fantasy any more, was it? And later tonight, she’d be getting more of that.

“That was good,” she said when her orgasm played itself out. She laid back, resting the back of her hand on her forehead. “Yes, thank you. So good.”

“A good warmup for tonight?” I asked.

She studied me, her hand still poised above her like a sigh. She was measuring me and how I’d react. “A great warmup. Thank you.”

“Send AJ my regards.”

She hopped out of bed and went to her closet. She pulled on a racerback workout top that highlighted her sexy back—and her new tattoo. She pulled on a tight pair of black pants, then turned. I was confused. Was she really going to workout? Or was she going to hookup? Seeing my puzzled expression, she said, “One thing that I’ve discovered about myself is that almost nothing puts me in the mood like some exercise.” She shouldered her gym bag. “Of course, what you did certainly helped. Thanks, baby.”

And with a kiss, she was off to see her lover.

I watched her go, watched her ass rock back and forth in those pants, her dark hair tight and high. I stood at the window of our bedroom, watching her climb into her car. She pulled out her phone and texted someone. AJ, perhaps, telling him that she was on her way. I shivered. I loved this part—the wait, the pins and needles, the suffocating thrill of not knowing. It had been amazing to watch her, but this was exciting in a completely different way.

I changed into my pajamas, but went back downstairs and flipped on the television. I put on SportsCenter, but didn't hear any of the banter. Instead, I recalled a conversation that I'd had two weeks ago, during a training session with AJ.

Erin's too special for a one-nighter. That chick's got a wild side I can't wait to tap... I've seen that before. Her life is proper and orderly. She's one kind of person there: mother, wife. But she's got a darker, naughtier side. A side she can't show her husband...

Thinking about those words made me shiver. Made me hard. But they were true. Sunday night—and tonight—she was proving that AJ was right. More of his observations haunted me:

What they have is comfortable, right? She loves him, and loves her life with him. It's a respect thing, I guess. Like, if she revealed this dirtier side of herself, he'd lose some respect for her... With me, she doesn't have to deal with the complications of justification or acceptance. She knows that I don't care. I'm safe, but in a totally different way. I'm safe for that inner slut.

He was right and he was wrong. That was exactly the woman I'd love for her to show me, but only when she was ready. In a twisted sense, AJ was the way.

I was in bed when she finally came home. It was close to 12:30. I had my Kindle in my lap, but I'd been re-reading the same page for the last half hour. "You're awake," she said, surprised and happy.

“Couldn’t sleep. Had a lot on my mind,” I said.

“Mmm, like what?”

She’d changed out of her workout clothes and into a more casual pair of shorts and blouse. Pulling the blouse over her head, she bared her unfettered breasts.

“Was thinking about my naughty wife,” I said.

She pushed her shorts off. She wore nothing beneath. “She’s naughty, huh?”

I pushed my own boxers off as Erin climbed into bed over me. She smelled fresh, but different. She’d shampooed with a brand that I didn’t know. She’d cleaned her body with someone else’s soap. “You smell good,” I said.

“Aj has a nice shower.”

“There’s something about you and showers,” I said.

Erin laughed as she positioned her pussy against my cock. I couldn’t tell what was more erotic: the smile she wore or the smooth glide of her nether lips along my shaft.

“Oh, yes, Tom.” Erin practically growled as she lowered herself onto me. Did I feel small to her, compared to Aj? Did she feel loose to me?

She grabbed my head, pulling me up to her. Her kiss was deep and hard, like she was reminding herself of my taste and touch. I held on like this was some kind of wild ride—which I suppose is what I’d been doing for months now.

When she pulled away, it felt like I was pulling out of a nose dive. “You feel so good, baby.” She squeezed my head in my hands, her nails digging into my neck. “You fill me just right.”

It wasn’t a concession to me not being as big as Aj. She wasn’t trying to stroke my ego to make me feel secure. I heard sincerity in her voice and knew that she spoke true. Still, I couldn’t help saying, “You’re not tired of me yet?”

“Never.” Her eyes didn’t waver. There was force behind that statement. “Never ever.”

We kissed again, slower this time, like one soul brushed up against another. My insecurity fled with that kiss. Any fears I still had about Erin and AJ were put to rest.

“So you want a story?” she asked at last.

“Please.”

“Well, since you used the magic world...” She kissed me softly. “I went to the gym. He’s still my trainer, so we did a light routine. Then, we left—separately—and headed to his place. There...” She sighed, like she was remembering a decadent meal. “There, we were all over each other. He’s a very forceful kisser.”

“So was that me you were just kissing? Or him?”

“You really need me to answer that?” she asked flatly. “He’s forceful, but he’s not you. Still, forceful is nice, too.”

She kissed me hard, demonstrating. I thought of AJ doing the same to her. She must have felt my excitement. “You like that, don’t you, naughty boy? How about if I told you that after the kissing, he pushed me to my knees?”

My stomach quivered.

“He’s got a great, big dick, Tom, and whenever I see it, I can’t resist sucking it.”

I shuddered, nearly losing it.

“You like hearing how I just can’t control myself around him? He likes me on my knees when I blow him.”

I groaned.

“After I got him nice and hard, he led me over to his bed—his great, big king-sized bed. Surprisingly, it was made. The man keeps a tidy apartment, even if it’s all leather furniture and shades of dark wood.”

Erin fucked me slowly as she reminisced.

“He handed me a condom. Made me roll it on him.”

I could imagine the scene—Erin naked, straddling him, her deft hands working the rubber down his large cock. My chest tightened.

“God, Tom, you feel so good.”

“So do you, baby.”

She leaned close enough to whisper in my ear: "So did Aj."

My balls seized. It caught me so off-guard, but once done, there was no holding back. I grabbed her hips and pulled her against me, exploding inside her.

"Yes," Erin sighed, keeping her moans as quiet as possible. She didn't climax with me, but she moaned like she was on the verge.

Before I knew what was happening, Erin was sliding down between my legs. She took my wet, softening cock and swallowed it whole. I immediately felt myself begin to rise again.

"I did this for him. A few times. He can usually get it up three times in a night."

I heard the challenge: *can you get it up twice?* Strangely, the challenge helped.

She wrapped her fingers around my stiffening shaft. "You know how hot it was when he spanked me?" Erin squeezed my cock in her hand. It was almost too much. "Well, tonight, he took it further. He handcuffed me. Right behind the back."

I grew back to full strength with that. I'd never known she was into that sort of thing. How was that true?

"Someone likes the sound of that." She licked up my now-hard shaft. "I did, too. It was so hot. He had me face down on the bed, knees tucked under me, my arms handcuffed behind my back. I felt *soo* helpless. And then he fucked me so hard and deep with his big, hard cock."

She crawled up into position over me, lowered herself on my cock, and sighed.

"You like the idea of your wife taking a big, hard cock, don't you?"

"Yes."

"You like hearing about how he uses me? How he takes me?"

“Yes, Erin.” My response was more groan than anything else. The things she was saying inflamed me. I’d just come, but I already felt a second orgasm building. I just needed to hold out long enough for Erin to get her fix.

She rolled us, maintaining our connection the whole way. Suddenly I was the one over her, setting the pace.

“Show me how you think he fucked me,” Erin said. She nipped my ear. “Fuck me and pretend to be him.”

She dug her heels into my back as I began pounding her. At first, I used my usual rhythm, only more forceful, but Erin’s driving heels encouraged a faster pace, one that had me out of breath in no time. My abs burned. My arms were sore. My body screamed at me. But I didn’t stop fucking her. Didn’t dare to.

“Yes, he fucked me...just like that.” Erin’s voice was tight beneath me. She was close. “But he was...bigger. He reached...places that you can’t.”

My balls seized, but somehow, I fought off my climax—for a few last seconds, anyway.

“You know the dirtiest thing he did to me tonight?” Erin hissed in my ear.

“What?” Asking the question felt like pressing the trigger of a bomb.

“He put his thumb in my ass.” She moaned. “And I loved it.”

“Oh, God!” I couldn’t hold back any longer. I stopped trying. I let it all out, clenching my teeth and squeezing my eyes shut. He’d fingered her ass. Was he planning on doing more?

Erin was right there with me, hissing out a quiet orgasm as I filled her with my heat. She arched back, shoving her chest into mine as her heels dug painfully into my ass. Somehow, she kept quiet. Somehow, she didn’t wake the house. I got the feeling that she wasn’t so restrained with Aj.

At last, her body relaxed. She turned to mush beneath me. I collapsed onto her, our bodies bathed in sweat.

"That felt good," Erin whispered, nuzzling against me. "I needed that."

"AJ wasn't enough for you?"

"Oh, he was more than enough...to get me off." Erin laughed softly. "But he'll never replace you."

It felt good to hear her say that, but a troubled part of me wondered if she kept repeating it to convince herself as much as to convince me. And an even more troubled part of me wondered why that thought turned me on so much.

"I'm sorry you didn't get to watch tonight," she said in the dark. "I tried to think of a way to share, but..."

"It's okay. You did, in a way. Just now," I said. "I was thinking about it...while you were out. It's kind of sexy this way."

I felt her turn beside me. "This way?"

"I loved watching you on Sunday, don't get me wrong. In fact, that may have been the single, most exciting, most thrilling moment of my life."

Erin laughed softly.

I continued. "But being at home, knowing you're being bad, yet not quite knowing... That's exciting, too. Just... different."

Erin tickled her fingers along my shoulder. I listened to her breathe, wondering what she was thinking. At last, she spoke. "Yeah, I know what you mean. It's hot for me, too."

I didn't speak. This moment felt fragile. I was getting insight into the secret side of Erin that I hadn't even known about until a few months ago. I didn't want to scare her away.

She was quiet a long time—long enough that I wondered if she'd fallen asleep. When she spoke, though, her voice was clear and awake. "It was amazing when I knew you were watching..."

"But?"

She buried her face in my chest. "It feels so wrong."

"What does?"

"Being with him. Without you."

My heart began to race. "Wrong in an exciting way, right?"

She hesitated only a heartbeat, but I felt it like a punch.

"Yes. Very exciting."

"Yeah," I said.

"Yeah," she agreed.

We lay awake for a long time, although neither of us felt tired anymore. Her hand dropped down between my legs, finding me hard once again—for the third time. AJ wasn't the only one who could get it up three times, I thought proudly.

"He asked me out, you know," she said, encircling my cock, gently stroking it.

"Did he?" I asked tightly.

"Mmm hmm. Friday night. On a date."

"What did you tell him?"

She straddled my lap, taking me inside her with a hiss.

"I'm going to regret this tomorrow. So sore."

"We can go slow."

"Yes, please," she said. After a couple minutes of soft love-making, she said, "I haven't told him anything. I told him I wasn't sure that I could get away." She leaned down, resting her head against mine. Our eyes met in the shadows of our bedroom. "Can I get away?"

"Will you be naughty?" I ran my hands down her back, clutching her ass. I thought about how he'd fingered her back there. My heart pulsated.

"Yes."

"Will you let him do things to you that you don't do for me?"

I felt her body tighten, her breath gasp. She pulled back to stare down at me. "Does that upset you?"

I thrust up into her. I dodged the question—and my own confused emotions—with a question of my own. "Does this

feel like it upsets me?"

Erin's laugh disintegrated in a moan. "Then maybe I will." She fucked me faster, despite how sore she must have been. "And you'll be back here, waiting for me, wondering just what your wife is doing with another man."

"Oh, Erin..." I moaned.

"Should I tell him yes?"

"Yes."

"Thank you."

We didn't speak anymore, both lost in the forbidden thrill of Erin's next date. Date. The word sizzled through me. My wife was now dating another man.

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FIVE

The following morning, my dreams wouldn't let me go. They were having too much fun tormenting me. I watched AJ fuck Erin against his Camaro again, her lean body bent over, taking it. Only this time, he pulled out of her. *Tell me what you want*, he demanded.

My ass. Fuck me in the ass.

I knew that's what you wanted.

He pressed against her, entering her from behind. She screamed.

What a slut, Lucas Hughes said beside me. *Think she'd be up for a tag-team?*

Erin answered like she was standing right beside us. *I was hoping you'd ask.*

I struggled to object—not with Lucas, anyone but Lucas! But I couldn't talk. My mouth didn't work. All I could do was watch Lucas Hughes walk out to my wife, buck naked.

I woke up around that point, left with the uneasy feeling of being violated. Beside me, my phone rumbled.

I picked it up, disoriented for a moment to see two letters on the screen: AJ. My stomach cratered before I remembered that today was Wednesday, which meant we had a training session.

"Hey, man," I said.

"Hey, bro. Where you at?"

"I'm sorry, I overslept. I think I'm coming down with something."

"Kay. I was up late last night getting my brains fucked out by this total hottie, but guess what? I'm still here on this trail, and you're home because of some sniffles?"

I clenched my teeth, biting the urge to simply hang up. There was a lot to unpack in that statement, and while it

was tempting to stick with my story, the competitive side of me took over. "I'll be there in fifteen."

"It's your dime, man."

He hung up. I groaned. No breakfast for me this morning. I pulled on my running shorts and a t-shirt and headed downstairs.

Erin was awake, looking fresher than she had a right to be. She had breakfast out for the kids and a bowl of yogurt and granola for herself. "I didn't think you'd make it," she said.

"Something kept me up late last night," I grumbled.

Erin stood and kissed me, handing me a granola bar. "You need to eat something. AJ can really...push you."

Her eyes flashed. I stirred in my pants. And I was out the door.

*

Did I want to talk about Erin with AJ? I did and I didn't. The last thing that I wanted was for AJ to figure out that I was Erin's husband. That would be a nightmare. The guy gave me a hard enough time when I wanted to bail this morning. I could only imagine what he'd be like if he knew that he was having sex with my wife. Nightmare.

On the flip side, I was dying to hear what he had to say about Erin—the "total hottie" who'd "fucked his brains out" last night. I wanted to ask about the date they had lined up for Friday. What were his plans?

Prudence won out. I kept my mouth shut. Luckily, AJ didn't.

"So I nailed that chick I was talking about," he said as he set a brisk pace down the trail.

My stomach trembled. "The brunette?"

"Yeah, bro. And *damn*."

"She was everything you were hoping for?"

“And then some.” He shook his head. “I was right. She’s got a wild streak.”

I’d watched them together. I’d witnessed how he spanked her and how much she got off on it. But there was something about hearing AJ’s side of things that really drove home what we were doing—we could call this a game all we wanted, but it was real. AJ wasn’t just a dildo. He was as unpredictable as a wild animal.

I didn’t ask for details on how wild she was, although I really wanted to. Instead, I asked a question that I already had an answer for: “So have you seen her since the race?”

“A few times, bro. Fact I was fucking her last night. Unbelievable ass on that chick.”

“Nice.” I was glad that we were running, not at one of the aerobic stations along the trail. Easier to hide my erection this way.

“It’s nice and juicy, yet firm. Totally unreal.” I could confirm that. “I’m going to enjoy fucking it.”

My heart skipped. “Oh yeah? She’s into that?”

“Oh yeah. She just doesn’t know it. Like I said, wild side. I’m going to have fun with her.”

I didn’t speak. I didn’t know what to say, so I breathed hard and played up my heavy exertion. Sadly, AJ didn’t continue to talk about her, instead switching into trainer mode. He instructed me on how to breathe when I ran, pushed me to a faster pace, then pulled up short as we approached the chin up bar. By the end of the morning, I was convinced that the man was a sadist.

Of course, if that were true, then I was the tortured masochist, and when we were nearing the end of the hour, I couldn’t leave the conversation there. “So when do you see her next?”

AJ grinned, like he knew I’d ask. “Friday night. I’m taking her out.”

“Like a date?”

AJ shrugged, like he barely comprehended what that word meant. "I guess you could call it that. Most dates don't end up at strip clubs, though."

I laughed, partly at his comment, partly at the idea that he thought he could take Erin to a strip club. I'd suggested it in the past, only to get an earful about how exploitative *those places* were.

"Good luck with that," I said, realizing that I was speaking with more knowledge than I should. To cover, I added, "Husband must suspect something's up. I mean, how many times can she be *meeting a friend*, or whatever she's telling him."

"Oh, he knows."

I felt the floor drop out from under me. Somehow, I managed to contain my panic. "He...knows?"

"Yeah. He actually gets off on it, can you believe that shit?" AJ shook his head. I forced a short, strained laugh. "Some guys do. Actually makes things easier. No need to sneak around."

"Wow." My mind raced as I worked through the implications. Obviously he didn't know I was the husband, but all it would take was a quick search on Facebook and he'd figure it out. I made a mental note that this would be my last training session with him, and wondered if I could get out of my membership at City Fitness.

"Yeah, I know it's weird, but we all have our weird kinks. I get off on banging married chicks. I'm happy that those guys exist out there."

"So you've done it before?"

"A few times, yeah."

"Do you ever...meet the husband?"

"I had this one couple, yeah. It's kind of complicated, but she was my boss's wife."

"Really?"

"Still is, actually, although we don't get together much. It just ran its course. Was sweet, though. She's this stacked

redhead..." He shook his head. "Maybe I should introduce her to Erin. That'd be a hell of a good time."

"Erin's...bi?" The question sent a shiver through me.

"My guess? Bi-curious. We'll see how she handles Avalon on Friday, eh?"

"Yeah."

"Alright, bro. See you in two weeks. We'll do a session in the gym. Work the weights."

"Sounds good." There was no way in hell I'd be doing that.

*

I went straight to the office, showering in the facilities we had there. I tried to focus on work. I certainly had enough of it. The sagging numbers in the New Orleans office weren't going away. I thought about what Lucas had said back at the barbecue, that maybe Brian Benoit was encouraging his staff to underperform, just to sabotage me.

On paper, nothing appeared amiss. If Benoit was fixing the books, or doing anything else weird, I didn't see it. In fact, they looked like they were following my instructions to a tee. They were doing all the right things; they were mimicking the best practices that had made me so successful in DC. So why were the sales sagging?

But any shenanigans would be almost impossible to tell just by looking at reports and ledgers, and it was a grave enough accusation that I didn't want to make it unless I was sure.

As the day wound on, insecurity began to creep over me. Benoit wasn't right, was he? Had I been too heavy handed as a boss? Should I have left well enough alone?

I went over the numbers at the other offices. Things were turning around there, although we'd made a few adjustments. Maybe that's all New Orleans needed—an adjustment.

Of course, every time I stopped thinking about work, the revelations of this morning came rushing back—the strip club date, AJ’s theory that Erin was bi-curious, but most of all, the fact that she’d told him that I knew. That, more than anything, incensed me.

Jo knew, and while I wasn’t crazy about the notion, it was actually a good thing. Erin did need someone to talk to who wasn’t me, and she became someone I could confide in if I needed it. But AJ? Why did she tell AJ? And why hadn’t she consulted me before doing something like that?

As the day progressed, I got more and more angry. She shouldn’t have told him. We should have talked about this together. And who else had she told? Haley? They were close. And if she’d told Haley, did Lucas know?

I couldn’t even wait until the kids were asleep. The argument had already played itself out a dozen times in my head, and as I walked into the house, the beginning of it spilled out before I’d even kissed her hello.

“You shouldn’t have told AJ.”

Erin blinked. “Excuse me?”

I glanced at the kids, who were rushing up to us. Kneeling down, I hugged them. To Erin, I said, “Later.”

Dinner preparation was tense. Erin had prepared lasagne and made a salad. I watched the kids draw at the kitchen table when Erin floated in and guided me back to the kitchen. Did she look nervous, or was it just me?

“What did AJ say?”

“He told me that your ‘husband’ knows about our arrangement. How could you have done that?”

“Oh. That.”

“So you knew?” I felt heat rise in my cheeks. I glanced into the dining room, where the kids colored away, and lowered my voice. “We should have talked about it first.”

Erin shook her head. “It wasn’t like that. I didn’t...” She sighed, but when she looked up at me, she was defiant. “I

didn't tell him. I wouldn't have. He just...figured it out or something."

"What are you talking about?" I felt off-balance.

"Look, I promise you, I didn't tell him. You've got to believe me."

"But you knew that he knew about me."

"He doesn't know about *you*," she said.

"You know what I mean."

Erin glanced away. "Yeah. Last night, actually, was the first time he'd brought it up. He mentioned it when I was... on my knees..."

My blood began to pump faster from more than just anger.

"...he said something about how you—or 'my husband'—probably wishes he could see me now, or something."

"How?"

Erin glanced back at me, the memory gone. "I don't really know. He's done this before—being with other men's wives. We've talked about that. I guess I just put out that vibe."

I realized that my haze of anger had started to burn off. I looked deep into Erin's eyes, searching for any trace of deceit. I didn't see anything but openness—and a little fear.

"You didn't deny it, did you?" I said.

"No." Erin grimaced. "I'm sorry, I should have, but..."

"Yes?"

"It's actually easier this way."

My turn to blink, confused. "Come again?"

"Well...he doesn't know that you are my husband, and he doesn't have to." As she spoke, she gained more confidence. Clearly she'd thought this through. "But on the flip side, since he knows that you know, I don't have to keep making up reasons to sneak away and be with him."

Now that the haze had cleared, it did make a kind of sense. But it was still dangerous. I told her as much. I said,

"I work out with him."

Erin looked relaxed, almost mischievous. She reached out and touched my shoulder. "Isn't that part of the game, though? The danger?"

"I don't want to be humiliated. I'm not some wimp—"

"No, you're not. A skydiver doesn't want to hit the ground, either, but he still gets a thrill jumping out of planes."

The timer went off in the kitchen. "Let's talk when the kids are in bed."

I thought through her theory about danger being part of the thrill. It rolled over me like an epiphany. It explained so much. It was exciting to think about Erin with this dirty side, but that excitement was amplified because she was exploring that side with another man.

It also explained Lucas, and why the thought of him fooling around with Erin was so extremely exciting and so extremely wrong. As always, I buried the idea of it and moved on.

That night, as we snuggled into bed, Erin said, "Do you want me to cancel Friday night?"

This wasn't a rhetorical question. "Why are you asking?"

She didn't directly answer my question. "I can tell him that the situation has changed. That my husband is no longer comfortable with it."

She was giving me an out. She was also putting this decision squarely on me, which could potentially lead to regret, or even worse, to resentment. So I said, "If you'd like to stop, tell him. Do you want to stop?"

Her hesitation was sexy. The fact that she was so into this was so erotic.

I pressed on. "You said it earlier. The danger is part of the game. I'm not...thrilled that he knows that you're not sneaking around on your husband, but mostly because he thinks I'm someone else, and it was fun getting new information from him like that."

"You don't have to stop, you know," she offered.

It was a dangerous proposition, and more tempting than I would have thought. "I'll play it by ear."

Erin smirked. "Learn anything juicy?"

With the turmoil behind us, my conversation with AJ returned—the strip club, his plans to have anal sex with her, his claim that she was bi-curious. My pulse raced.

Erin saw the excitement in my face before I even spoke. "Tell me," she said, licking her lips.

"You might end up cancelling on him after all," I said, stroking her body as I wondered what to bring up first.

We slipped out of our clothes, kissing and caressing. Erin straddled me. She was wet. I was ready. She rolled her hips, stroking my erection with her smooth pussy.

"Tell me," she repeated.

"He's planning on taking you to Avalon."

Erin shook her head, not recognizing the name.

"The strip club downtown."

Erin's eyes went wide. "He said that?"

"He did." I took her hips and shifted her over me. My cock found her pussy, warm and inviting. We took a quiet moment to enjoy the sensation, our breathing growing heavy. She leaned over me, her breasts sweaty and soft against my chest.

I desperately wanted to ask her what she was thinking, but left her alone to work through the revelation. Was she driving her hips faster? Harder? Was she thinking about walking into that strip club on AJ's arm, looking as good as any of the dancers?

I clutched her ass, encouraging her to sink deeper into her imagination. Would AJ buy her a dance? Would Erin accept? I would have said no way before AJ had come into our lives. Now, I wasn't so sure. I closed my eyes and pictured a blonde in her lap wearing nothing but a thong. *Feel how soft her skin is. Is she making you wet?*

"You thinking about it?" I asked at last.

Erin's moan was response enough. I nearly lost it. Erin did. She crashed over me, gasping, eyes shut tight, head back. She ended with her face buried in my shoulder, her dark hair fanning out around her.

The moment still hung fragile, still uncertain. But I had to ask. I couldn't keep it in any longer. "What were you thinking about?"

Erin opened her eyes, her face inches from mine. She looked bashful, flushed. "Umm..."

"Think you'll be experiencing a strip club for the first time Friday?"

She glanced away. "I'm not sure. Why would...why would he take me to a place like that?"

"Really?" I said, smiling.

With the roll of her eyes, she said, "You like the idea, don't you?"

"Of course I do."

"You and AJ can both go on dreaming. Nothing's going to happen."

"But you *are* going, aren't you?" I pressed.

"Well..." she said, coyly playing with my chest hair. "I'm not supposed to know about it, right? So how can I object?"

Even as we discussed it, I'd never really thought that she'd go through with it. After all, strip clubs were just not her thing. Now, though, it sounded like I'd judged incorrectly. And that was exhilarating.

"I felt that," she said, her face lighting up.

"Well, you know, it's pretty hot thinking about it."

I rolled us until I was on top and began to rock in and out of her, slowly, gently. Erin sighed, relaxing into the languid pace. At first, I almost thought that the conversation had moved on. Then, she spoke, her voice so quiet I thought I'd imagined it at first.

"When I'm with him..."

My body shook, my heart jumping. I held my breath, waiting, slowly moving my hips up and down.

“He gets me to do things that I’d never thought that I...”

“That you liked?” I offered.

She said, “That I thought I wanted to try.”

“And it gets you excited, doesn’t it?” I said.

“Yes.” She raked her fingers through my hair. The touch felt good, the physical connection that I needed with that confession. “I’m sorry, honey.”

The knee jerk reaction was to ask why, but I knew why. I knew why her voice and touch swelled with guilt. She should have been willing to try those things with me. She should have been open to it all *with me*. But what had AJ said? That she had a darker, naughtier side that she couldn’t reveal to me?

The anger that I’d felt when I thought that she’d told AJ about me without consultation was back, but this time tempered with something else—the buzz of excitement deep in my gut. We were still discovering things about ourselves. That she opened up at all was fiery and fierce.

“So if AJ wants to buy you a lap dance?”

Beneath me, she answered. I wished that I could see her face, but that I couldn’t probably helped her answer more honestly.

“I’d let him buy one for me.”

“What would she look like?” I stroked her with the whole length of my cock, reminding her that she was with a man, that she loved men, even as she explored a softer side of her sexuality.

“She’s blond,” she said at first. “She’s got a nice, athletic body.”

I groaned. It didn’t matter if she was humoring me or not, the fact that her words were mapping to my earlier fantasy was electric. “What else?”

Again, her response came slowly, drawn out from somewhere deep and unknown until now. “She smells good. Her skin’s so soft...”

My balls tightened. I pumped her faster, in, out, groan, sigh. I saw the stripper undulate over my wife, saw their skin brush, saw Erin's lips part in a gasp.

Her words were breathy. Her body rippled beneath me. "Yes, yes..."

I glanced down at her, at her closed eyes, at her orgasm held tense in her face. She was thinking about another woman. She was *getting off* on another woman.

"Erin, I'm there." I grunted as my balls tightened and things went soft around the edges. I closed my eyes, seeing Erin lift her chin to a blonde who was closing in for a kiss.

The vision was consumed with the intensity of my orgasm, washed away in a fury of white fire. I felt Erin shudder beneath me. I vaguely heard her cry out through her clenched teeth. Then even that was lost to the blinding light.

I came down from the high, spent, gasping, exhausted. I rolled onto my back, sticky with sweat. Erin snuggled up beside me, her breath labored as well.

I wavered between letting sleep take me and continuing this conversation. Sleep sounded so tempting, but there was something that I needed to ask.

"I thought you said you weren't into other women."

"I don't know that I am." Her voice was thick. Sleepy. She kissed my shoulder. "Guess we'll find out Friday."

And with that, she slipped off to sleep.

*

Her words followed me into the next day like a particularly vivid dream. She was going to a strip club. She was going to let AJ buy her a dance. Was she doing it because of my reaction—and AJ's?

It wouldn't have been the first time that Erin did something purely for my enjoyment over hers. I thought about the stockings example, of course, and how she'd wear

them more for me and less for her. But there were others: going out for sushi, road trips to my brother's house in Boston over flying, and all the times we went camping before the kids. It wasn't that she hated doing those things; they just weren't her preference.

The strip club never would have been her preference, but she was doing it. Only difference was that she was going to Avalon for AJ, not me. Her concession was to her lover—just like shaving, just like being spanked and treated like a slut. And now that I had perspective on the “sacrifice,” I realized that she really did get off on the act of surrender. She'd told me before the whole AJ thing started that she got excited because I got excited. Was the same true for her and AJ?

That line of thinking was unsettling, so I moved on to thinking about the actual date. How would she handle the strip club? I'd never been to Avalon, but I'd heard a few things about it. It was neither on the upscale side of things, nor the seedy one, and as far as strip clubs went, it was pretty small. Maybe the more intimate setting would help her open up. Maybe she'd come back with a wild new story.

It was exciting, and I wanted to make it happen. I wanted to encourage her to explore this new side of herself—and for her to know that I supported it. So I decided the best way to do it, short of telling her yet again that I supported it, was to buy her a dress for Friday night.

*

Le Fraise was a tiny boutique shop that sold chic, sexy, expensive clothing and accessories. I'd heard some of the younger women in the office talk about, so I just went for it. As I stepped into the shop, though, two things occurred to me.

The first was that I couldn't see Erin ever coming into a store like this. It was too high end, and honestly too

feminine. The dresses on the mannequins were all short, the heels were towering, and even the lingerie in the back corner was more reminiscent of a courtesan than my sporty wife.

The other thing that occurred to me was that this wasn't the kind of shop that men usually visited. When the store clerk—a stylishly dressed young woman with glossy red hair—approached me, my first instinct was to run.

“May I help you, sir?” Her tone was pleasant, although I couldn't help but think that she was looking like a wild animal had just wandered into her store.

“I'm actually looking for something for my wife. For her birthday.” It wasn't a complete lie, I told myself. Erin's birthday actually was in a little over a month.

The sales woman seemed to relax. She had a friendly, disarming smile that helped me relax, too. “Of course. Hi, my name is Tanya. So what did you have in mind for your wife?”

“I was thinking a...dress. And some shoes.” *And lingerie*, I couldn't seem to bring myself to ask.

“I see. Well, we've got some great new lines in, over here.” She led me deeper into the store. “What style were you looking for?”

“Something sexy,” I said before I could help it.

Tanya paused, shooting me a look that said, *Oh, that kind of dress*. I suddenly felt like my whole story was laid bare: my wife-sharing fantasy, Erin's upcoming date with another man, the fact that I was here to support it.

“I see,” Tanya said. “Well, we've got some great options for exactly that. What are your wife's measurements?”

“Measurements?”

“Her body measurements. You know, like *Playboy*. Hips, waist, bust?”

“I'm not sure. She's s size 2, I think?”

“Hmm, this is going to be tricky.” She turned to me and put her hands on her hips. Her cute, dimpled smile and curly

red hair gave way to a cultivated beauty that I can't believe I overlooked. She had a beauty mark just to the side of her left eye that, to me, made her look French without being French.

Tanya said, "How different is she from me?"

"Excuse me?" I asked. I looked around the store, but we were still alone.

"Your wife. We're both 2s, but that still leaves a lot unknown. Is she shorter? Taller? Bustier?" A wickedness seemed to pull at the corners of her mouth.

"Um, she's... she's a little shorter than you, I think." I glanced at her heels, tall and expensive-looking, and second guessed myself. "She's 5' 5"."

"So we're the same height, actually. How about the rest?"

Even though she was inviting me to look, I had to force my eyes down her body. Encased in a ribbed turtleneck sweater and a flirty little skirt, Tanya's body was actually very similar to Erin's—compact, yet with hips that flared and breasts that complimented it.

How about the rest? I almost answered, *Very nice*. "Um, you and her are actually close in size. She's got slightly smaller...um, I mean, her bust is a little bit smaller than yours."

Tanya didn't laugh, but her face lit up like she was. "How about her color? What's her complexion? Her hair color?"

"Tanned. Her hair's dark and pretty long."

"Got it. And you're looking for something sexy?"

"Yes, but something she can wear out."

"Ah, I see. Something you can show her off in." Tanya didn't sound disapproving, but put like that, it sounded bad.

"No, not like that. I mean, yes, but no. I mean—"

"Relax. I know what you're looking for, and I'm not judging. I think it's sweet that you think so highly of your wife. Come on, I have a few things that would be perfect."

As she moved through the racks, examining slinky dress after slinky dress, rehanging most, I wondered what Tanya would think if she knew the truth: that I wanted to show Erin off to one man in particular.

“So how about one of these?” she asked. She held up a couple dresses, one black, one white, and both very small. “Want me to model them?”

“What? No, it’s okay...” But she was already slipping into the changing room behind her. As she drew the curtain closed, I looked around the room again, wondering if I should just leave. My annoying sense of etiquette kept me rooted to the spot.

Tanya emerged wearing the black dress. I swear my mouth dropped. It was short and chic, the top made up of a complicated criss-cross of straps and ties. She swiveled, showing me how it dipped down her back and hugged her ass. Tanya had a tiny scorpion tattoo etched on her shoulder that the sleeveless dress didn’t quite cover. I thought about how Erin’s own tattoo would be displayed—AJ’s mark. It sent a shiver through me.

“Like it?” she asked.

“It’s...nice.”

Tanya laughed. “It’s sexy is what it is. Like an upscale LBD. I’d pair it with the new Christian Louboutin’s we just got in. Stockings, too. Ooh, something with a seam up the back would be perfect.”

The thought of Erin in stockings made me smile. She didn’t seem interested in wearing stockings for me, but maybe she would for AJ? The duplicity of the thought left me breathless.

“Got it? Now for the white one.”

She was back behind the curtain again, stepping out of the black dress as my mind wandered to Friday night, to the thought of Erin walking into a strip club on AJ’s arm dressed in that black dress.

From behind the curtain, Tanya said, "I've actually got one of these dresses myself. I love it, but so does my husband."

I gulped. She had a husband, too? I didn't notice a ring, although I may have overlooked it.

"He knows that whenever I wear it out, he's in for a fun time."

With that, she slid the curtain aside and stepped out. If I thought the black dress was stunning, the white made it look cheap. First of all, it was *short*. Like, *be very careful when you sit down* short. Like, *Erin had negligees that covered more of her legs than that* short. Made of white silk, the spaghetti strap dress was snug without being tight, flowing down Tanya's gentle curves like it was designed for her.

"Tricky thing about it is that you can't wear much underneath," Tanya went on, once against swiveling to show off the back—or the complete lack of one. The spindly white straps that held it in place in the front criss-crossed the back just enough to hold it in place. I could see Tanya's thong through the thin material, black and cheeky.

"I can see that," I said, my mouth dry.

"I'd pair these with something flirtier, so that it doesn't come off as too bridal, you know? Maybe a pair of leopard print platforms. Hold on, we've got a pair, even."

As Tanya cross the shop in that little dress, I knew I was going to buy it. It was so far outside of what Erin typically wore—it was classy, yet borderline slutty—that I knew I had to see it on her. It would probably go the way of the stockings I'd purchased, but I didn't care.

Tanya was able to crouch down and still preserve her modesty, although just barely. She pulled out a pair of strappy Prada sandals, which did indeed have leopard print detailing on the tall heels. She slipped them on, to demonstrate the look, and I had to admit that it worked.

"So?" she asked.

“Yes. That’s it.”

Tanya had a throaty laugh. “Not even going to ask about the price?”

“I don’t want to know. And I can afford it, so why bother with that detail?”

Tanya brightened as I flexed my spending power. I hadn’t been frivolous since the promotion—too wrapped up in Erin’s “training” program. Being frivolous on my wife seemed appropriate.

“I like you,” she said. “And I don’t even know your name.”

“Oh, sorry. I’m Tom.”

“Nice to meet you, Tom.” We shook hands, which was weirdly formal, and she handed me a business card she seemed to produce out of the air. “If your wife’s not interested in the dress, then you can always give me a call. Like I said, I have this dress, too.”

But I thought you were married, I thought, but left it alone. I projected as much confidence as I had and said, “I’ll keep that in mind.”

*

After the strange exchange at *Le Fraise*, I drove home in a total daze. I don’t think I even connected how scandalous the dress I’d purchased with the reality that Erin might wear it. It was the kind of dress that models wore to premieres, not mothers or wives living out in the suburbs—not even mothers and wives who fucked other men.

Not to mention the price. Even with my jacked up salary, that one was going to make a dent. Still, it was worth it, even if it never got out of the bedroom.

When I walked into the house, carrying the large paper bag from the expensive boutique’s name in silver lettering across the top, I didn’t know how Erin would react. Erin didn’t seem to know, either.

"What's this?" she asked, taking the dress box out of the bag. Even the box was smaller than it had a right to be.

"Something to show you that I love you."

She looked at me curiously and pulled at the bow. "A dress?" she asked, pulling the silky material free. She held it up. "A really short dress."

"For Friday. For your...date."

Erin's eyes shifted from the dress to me, her eyebrows raised. "It's beautiful, Tom..."

"But?"

She set it back in the box and ran her fingers across the label. "*Le Fraise* and... Prada?" She noticed the shoebox inside the bag.

I nodded, nervous as I watched her process the sexy things I'd purchased for her to wear with another man.

She opened the box and lifted the leopard print heels out. "Wow, very...sexy."

"Don't worry about it. You're worth it."

She set the heels back into the box, too, then turned to me. She drew me into her arms and hugged me tightly before drawing back. "I know what you're doing, and I really appreciate it."

"But?"

Erin sighed. "I can't wear that dress. Especially not to a..." She leaned in and whispered, "...to a strip club."

Disappointment plucked a chord deep inside of me, but I knew she was right.

"It's short. It's *really* short."

"Yeah," I said.

"I love that you bought it for me." She kissed me, her lips soft on my own. "But you know you don't have to do that for me, right?"

"I just wanted to..."

"To show me that you approve?"

"Not so much approval. More like...I'm okay with it."

“Oh, Tom, you don’t have to do that anymore. I already know that you’re okay with it. That’s what these last few months have been about—you proving to me that you can handle me with other men. If you couldn’t, we wouldn’t be having this conversation. You would never have let me go to Annapolis. You wouldn’t have just stood in the boathouse watching as AJ spanked me.”

I shifted, suddenly uncomfortable in all kinds of different ways.

“But I already have that. Today, when I dropped the kids off at preschool, I hung out at AJ’s. Well, mostly in his bed. He fucked me almost the entire time—three solid hours of his thick, hard cock. I lost track of my orgasms.” Erin pressed herself up against me, her hand sliding across my erection through my pants.

My heart raced. She’d done what?

She said, “I was going to tell you all about it later, in bed, but seems more apropos right now.”

It was a reminder that while Erin may do some things for my pleasure alone, she was into this thing that she had with AJ.

“Thanks for the dress, but you don’t need to do that any more. You’ve closed this deal, Mr. Sexy Businessman. Now it’s time to reap the rewards.”

She kissed me one last time, and we shifted once again into parenting mode.

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SIX

With the date looming later that evening, Friday dragged. I couldn't focus on a damn thing, so I didn't try. I thought about going to the gym, but there was a chance that AJ was there, so I didn't chance it. Instead, I went for a run. A long run. It helped a little, clearing my mind of everything but the exertion of the jog and the road right in front of me, but when it was over, the date once again loomed.

At home, I sat downstairs with the kids as Erin got ready for her date upstairs. I was a ball of nerves, but she'd pegged me correctly: I was *okay* with her going out. Not just okay—I was almost as excited for her as she must be.

"Tom, could you come up here real quick?" she called down. I knew what this was about. A preview. My heart raced. I felt like I was walking under water. And yet I took the stairs two at a time, excited by what I might uncover.

I pushed the bedroom door open. Erin turned at the sound of my sharp intake of air. "I need help with my dress."

She wasn't wearing the white dress. In fact, she wasn't wearing much of anything beyond a black garter belt and a pair of stockings. She turned in her heels—strappy black stilettos that I'd never seen before—to give me a full frontal view of her nudity. No bra. No panties. Just the garter belt and stockings framing her shaved sex.

All for AJ.

"Your point is taken," I said, crossing over to her.

Erin smiled, running her fingers along the lacy band of the garter belt. "I'm glad you noticed. You know, you're right. They're pretty sexy. And I can't wait for my date to discover them."

She picked up a thong, black and transparent, stepping into it over her suspenders. The dress went on next, black and tight while still remaining elegant. It was the kind of

dress she could easily wear at a cocktail party with my colleagues, and much more Erin's style.

I said, "You're evil."

She said, "You love it."

"Should I wait up?"

"Not unless you plan on staying up all night."

"Have fun," I said. "Hope you've got plenty of singles."

Erin looked at me questioningly.

"For the dancers," I added.

"Oh," Erin said, and laughed. "Well, I'm sure AJ will cover me there." She kissed me. "You have fun thinking about that...but not too much fun. I can't wait for you to reclaim me."

And with that, she was gone.

All the emotions from her last couple outings with AJ were back—the heart-pounding thrill, the stomach-churning anxiety, the nervous excitement. I wondered if that feeling would ever dull. As I sat there in the quiet house, shaking, I didn't think that they could.

I didn't know any details of the date besides the trip to Avalon, but that was a big enough detail to keep me occupied late into the night. Would AJ buy her a lap dance? Would she turn it down?

There was one part of waiting that was easier. I knew where I stood, and I knew that no matter what, she wasn't going to leave. *I can't wait for you to reclaim me.* I was part of this, and while I would have loved to watch, I loved this agonizing wait almost as much.

Knowing that, I was free to be happy for her. And I was so happy for her. I liked the idea of Erin out to dinner, on a date, even if it wasn't with me. I liked the idea of her laughing over candlelight, a glass of red wine in her hand.

Around ten, just as I was about to assume radio silence, I received a text—with a photo. What was surprising was that it wasn't just of Erin, but a selfie of Erin and AJ. He had his arm around her shoulder, their heads tipped together,

smiling cheekily. In the background, just out of focus, was the black awning of Avalon, the name emblazoned in gold.

The caption read:

-here's to new experiences

The night had officially begun. I just didn't realize it until then. I studied the photo, willing there to be more. For two hours, I got nothing.

Then, around midnight, my phone came alive once again—another photo, this time one that I couldn't process at first, and when I did, I recoiled from it. There, in its high resolution, Retina screen glory, was an erect cock. It was dark, curved up like a scimitar, and completely devoid of hair. But it was the hand that curled around it that captured all my attention—Erin's hand. There was no doubt, not with her diamond ring sparkling on her slender fingers, not with the glossy, dark red nail polish that she'd applied before heading out.

No caption this time. No context. Were they still at Avalon? Was this taken in the backroom of the club, or back at AJ's? I studied it for context clues, but the shot was too tight to discern anything else.

That gave me a kick of adrenaline that kept me up another couple hours, but eventually even that flagged. I fell asleep reluctantly, with Christmas Eve anticipation of the day to come.

*

When I felt Erin crawl into bed beside me, dawn had begun to break, casting its wan glow through the room. She kissed me on the neck and whispered, "Shh, go back to sleep."

I rolled onto my back as she snuggled against me. She was naked, her skin smelling like fresh soap.

"Did you have fun?" I asked sleepily.

“So much fun. I’ll tell you all about it in the morning.”

“Isn’t it already morning?”

Erin giggled. “Technically, yes.”

I pulled her in for a kiss, my body waking up. My *cock* waking up. “So were you naughty?”

“I was very naughty.” Erin moved over me, sensing what I wanted. She pushed my pajama pants down and mounted me. Her pussy felt different than it had the night before—not really looser, but definitely...used. “I had sex with another man. And I liked it.”

She groaned as I sank into her, hissing. “Sore?” I asked.

“Yeah.”

“We don’t have to...”

She didn’t stop. “I want to, baby. Just take it easy, ‘kay?”

“Of course.” I let her dictate the speed, getting used to me. Going slowly. “So did you even make it to dinner?”

“Actually, we did. It was sweet.”

“How romantic.”

“It was.” She rolled her hips against mine. “And I know you like that idea. I can feel you grow inside me. That’s so hot.”

“So how was Avalon?”

“I was wondering how long it would take you to ask.” Her smile was sinful. The pale light of morning caught the glossy waves of her dark hair as it spilled over her shoulder. She could have been a dream. “You want to know if I had a stripper in my lap last night? If I asked how she kept her skin so soft as she rubbed herself *all* over me?”

My cock hardened again as Erin painted the picture. My breath caught. “Yes, please.”

Erin giggled. “It was a lot more fun than I thought it would be. You should have seen the look on AJ’s face when Ashlyn kissed me.”

My eyes bugged out. “What?”

Erin rolled her hips along my length, her lips curling up at the ends. “At first, we just watched the dancers and had

drinks. AJ got me to put a few bills into a few g-strings, but it was all pretty silly.” Her eyes unfocused as she recalled the night. “Then I saw Ashlyn do her set. She was beautiful.”

“Blonde?” I asked, remembering her tease earlier in the week.

“Redhead, actually. Long and glossy, like copper. I’d never really seriously thought of a woman that way until... well, tonight, really.” She came out of her trance as she worked through it, meeting my eyes once again. “But in that place, with AJ, I felt...open to anything. So when my eyes met Ashlyn, I felt...something.”

“She turned you on.”

“Oh, yes,” she said. I wasn’t entirely sure that she was aware that she licked her lips. “And when he waved her over, I thought my heart was going to burst it was beating so fast. Like, I was hyperventilating, you know? Because of this other woman...”

“And she danced for you?”

“Mm hm. Although we talked at first. She made me feel comfortable. She sat in my lap at first, stroking my hair and...flirted with me, I guess.”

Erin was back into her story, lost in the memory. Her hips continued to move over me, but just barely. I was as enraptured as she was.

“We eventually moved into the VIP lounge. For privacy.” Color sprang to her face. “I was so nervous walking back there. Ashlyn held my hand, she must have felt how sweaty my palms were, because she kept putting me at ease.”

Erin’s eyelids slid shut. She took a deep breath and continued. “I’d always heard that strippers had soft skin, but Tom, it was incredible. She felt...unbelievable. I can’t even describe it. Her thighs on my thighs, her...breasts against my face...”

I saw it, Erin’s face pressed between this redheaded stripper’s full tits. I nearly lost it, willing myself to stop.

“And she kissed you?” I prompted.

“Yes. Towards the end of our time, she leaned down and kissed me.”

My lungs tightened. “Did you...did you kiss her back?”

Erin nodded, eyes closed as she relived the moment. “I did. Her lips were so soft. And her tongue...” She pursed her lips. “She tasted so good. I was so, so wet after that.”

I gulped. “Did anything else happen?”

Erin smiled, her eyes opening up. “Other than AJ racing me back to his place so he could fuck me senseless?”

“Other than that, yeah.”

“No, sadly, nothing else. She actually thanked us for the evening and left.”

I said, “If AJ had invited her back with you...?”

Erin shook her head. “I don’t know. I really don’t.”

“I think you would. With AJ, you would.”

Erin blushed again, burying her head in my shoulder as she began to fuck me faster. “I’m sure AJ was thinking about it. He was such an animal. We fucked for most of the night.” She squeezed me with her pussy. “I’m glad I just trained for a triathlon. I don’t think I would have been able to keep up otherwise.”

Those last few minutes were filled with slow, gentle love-making. I felt so connected to her. As one.

“I love you, Tom.”

“I love you too, baby.”

The day began, and we began with it.

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SEVEN

Saturday morning was farmers' market morning. We all had breakfast together, got dressed, and wandered through the large market, picking up fresh produce for the week. Now that Erin wasn't training every Saturday morning, she could join us.

She wore brown cargo capris that clung to her shapely butt, sandals, and a blouse and cardigan combo of pale pink. She pulled her hair back into a ponytail and wore aviators to shield her eyes. With a backpack and Mary on her hip, she looked like every other mom in the outdoor market. Yet I couldn't stop looking at her.

No, that wasn't quite it. I couldn't stop looking at the way others were looking at her. Had she always garnered that much attention? Had the heads of other husbands and vendors swiveled as she passed by? Maybe. But what was definitely new was the tingle of excitement I felt every time I noticed.

Hotwife. I wasn't crazy about the term—I didn't like the objectifying undertone that it implied—but the idea behind it certainly fit this new stage of our marriage. Erin reveled in her fling with AJ. I'd never seen her more confident in her life, and now that the exertion of her training regimen was behind her, our sex life was on fire.

"I'll take two loaves of the 10-grain, please," Erin said at the bread vendor.

The guy serving her was young and good looking, a college age kid here to earn extra cash. The bread stand always had young and interesting people working there. Guys like this kid, who looked fresh off of being crowned Homecoming King. Pretty young woman who could get away with a nose stud and look cute. They were the alt crowd of

the farmers' market, and I always wondered what the bakery must look like.

"Mmm, that smells good. How much are those?" Erin asked, pointing to some Danishes.

"Three. Or two for five. But for you, I'll cut you a deal and go three for six."

As I watched the exchange, my stomach squirmed. I knew that it was completely innocent, yet couldn't help going to dirtier places. I thought of the bakery, of this young man working in the early morning to get the bread ready. Sweat glistening on his skin as he fed the oven. Behind him, Erin looming in the shadows, wearing nothing but an apron. And—

"How sweet of you, Gavin. I'll take three, please."

"That'll be six dollars, Erin."

They knew each other's names?

"You know each other's names?" I asked when we were out of earshot of the bread stand.

Erin smiled at me cryptically. "Gavin's pretty cute, don't you think?" She laughed at my puzzled expression. "I know him from the gym. We recognized each other from our farmers' market visits. He's good with faces."

"Or something else," I said, glancing toward her chest.

"Fair. Should I go back and see if he wants to *knead my dough* later tonight?" Erin laughed again. This time I joined her.

"I love this new you," I said as we paced on.

"How so?"

"You're just more confident. You wear it well, and guys like Gavin notice."

Erin demurred, then added, "Have you been spying on me at the gym?"

Immediately, my heart began to race. We stopped before a busker playing bluegrass on old guitar. The kids immediately broke away from us to dance to Old McDonald.

"You have anything to tell me?"

Erin shook her head. “Not really, no, although...let’s just say Gavin’s not the only one to notice. Some have even been a little bit more forward.”

I licked my lips nervously, and glanced at the kids. They were still enthralled by the music, where other children had joined.

“More forward?”

“I don’t work out with my rings, so I guess guys assume I’m single.” She sidled up to me. “Just last week, when I was there in the morning, I had a guy ask me out for drinks, and one of the trainers wanted to know if I was interested in a massage because he just happened to have an opening.” She laughed. “I asked AJ about him. Apparently he tries that all the time.”

I always figured that Erin got approached by guys when I wasn’t around, but hearing about the specifics was heady and exhilarating. “Wow. Did you—”

“Of course not, goof.” She nudged me with her hip. “If I did, don’t you think I’d tell you?”

That wasn’t disappointment, was it? “Of course.”

“Come on, let’s go check out the squash stand.”

The rest of the weekend passed in a blur. It rained Sunday, which meant we spent the day coming up with art and craft projects that didn’t involve screen time, which the kids begged for.

The following week, I pored over the reports coming in from around the southeast region. The Orlando office had a small clutch of sales guys quit, which was going to be a pain to deal with, and one of the largest clients in the Atlanta office was threatening to go to a competitor. Rising above all of those issues, though, was the New Orleans office and their sagging numbers. I could deal with new hires and the mutiny of a single client, but I’d been hired to turnaround the numbers as a whole, and only the New Orleans office was preventing me from doing that.

And then Sean, one of the guys I'd brought along with me when I'd received my promotion, walked into my office, looking like someone had run over his dog. Turned out, it was worse than that.

"What's up, Sean?"

Sean shuffled from side to side, then awkwardly took a seat across from me. For a queasy moment, I thought he was here to quit on me, and that was the last thing I needed right now.

"I know that you wanted me to fly out to New Orleans this week, but...now's not a good time. I...I think I need to take some personal time."

"Of course, of course." I studied him. Sean was about as Irish as an Irish American came: orange-red hair, pale complexion, freckles, slightly lanky. His red hair didn't look like it had been washed in a while. He looked pale to the point of ghostly. I had to ask. "Anything you want to talk about?"

He looked across the desk at me, one hand clutching the arm of his chair like he was ready to bolt at any moment. Then, he slumped back into it and sighed. "Val is cheating on me."

Erin and I had had dinner with Sean and his wife Valerie on more than a few occasions. We liked her. We liked the two of them. They seemed happy, and she was always so sweet.

"Are you sure?" I said carefully. Mostly, I was buying time to process this. It didn't make sense.

Neither does your situation, said a small voice in the back of my head.

"I'm sure," Sean sighed. "I caught them. I got an earlier flight home last Friday, after the Atlanta trip. Guess she wasn't expecting me."

He rubbed his face in his hands, and for a moment, I wondered if he was about to start crying. Instead, it was exhaustion he was trying to outrun.

“Worst thing was I knew the guy. He worked with Val. He came to my barbecues. We’d even gone golfing once.” He shook his head. “And I had no clue.”

“Damn, man, I’m really sorry to hear that. Take as much time as you need, Sean. Obviously don’t worry about New Orleans this week.”

“Thanks.” He stood to go.

“And Sean, if you need anything, even just someone to talk to, you know where I am.”

“Thanks, man.” He smiled weakly and left.

I leaned back in my seat, releasing a lungful of air I hadn’t realized I’d been keeping. I couldn’t help but think of Erin and me. This wasn’t our future, was it? I wouldn’t come home one Friday night to find her gone? To find a note saying she’d left me for AJ?

Seemed very doubtful. AJ just didn’t seem like the type of guy that women fell for, but stranger things had happened. They did spend a lot of time together, and when they weren’t together, they were texting. Maybe we were playing with fire by focusing on one man. I thought of Gavin from the farmers’ market. Should we diversify? Would that be safer?

I rubbed my eyes. It wasn’t a problem that I could solve in the moment. The New Orleans trip was. If Sean couldn’t lead the observation team, then I would.

I booked a quick trip out to Louisiana, leaving Thursday morning, returning early Saturday. Ready or not, I was coming for Brian Benoit. Time to get to the bottom of this.

*

Mary ran a fever Monday night—nothing serious, but high enough that it meant she had to say home from preschool the next day. Watching Erin shift into full-on mom-mode was amazing. She was patient. She entertained. She was organized. When I got home from work on Tuesday, she

had Martin working on a craft at the kitchen table, Mary playing with her dolls, and dinner just about ready. We'd been so focused on AJ and the race day that I'd nearly forgotten about this side of my wife.

She was also exhausted. We had dinner and got the kids ready for bed, and then she crashed, cancelling on her AJ session. Good thing, too, because Martin got whatever Mary had in the middle of the night and ended up sleeping in our bed, which meant that we didn't sleep much either.

I felt guilty about leaving her alone with the kids like that, but by Wednesday, whatever they had seemed to have passed.

"We're at the playground now," Erin said on the phone. "It's like they don't even remember being sick."

"Wish I had resilience like a kid," I said.

"You give yourself too little credit. You've got plenty of resilience," she said. We both knew what she was referring to. "What I really need is a vacation."

"Come with me to New Orleans," I said before fully thinking it through.

Erin laughed. "Now you're talking. I'll need to make sure that we leave enough food out for the kids. Maybe train Martin on how to use the DVR." She laughed. "I like the thought, though. Maybe next time you head out there, we can plan for it?"

She was right, of course. While I'd already started working through the conversation I'd need to have with my parents to get them to take the kids on such short notice, Erin was the voice of reason. "Well, unfortunately, I think you're right. I think there will be many more trips to New Orleans."

*

Despite the domesticity that reigned at home, I couldn't stop comparing our situation with Sean and Val's. I still

wasn't quite comfortable with our current arrangement, and now Sean had introduced me to an entirely new complication.

I put myself in his shoes, again and again. I thought about walking in on Erin, seeing her with another man...

Then again, I *had* seen her with another man. There was nothing hypothetical about the vision. Not that it was the same. Val did that behind Sean's back. Erin had my permission. But it wasn't just the discovery that hit Sean so hard. It was who the other man was—a co-worker of Val's, a man who spent more time with her than her own husband, a man with time enough to work his way into her heart.

Was Erin seeing too much of AJ? Was she getting too close to him? Again, I thought of the bread guy, Gavin, and how he'd flirted with her—how there were others. Maybe it was time to loosen the reins even more.

As if to punctuate this point, Wednesday evening, after the kids were down, Erin wandered into the bedroom, tapping a message into her phone. She laughed at whatever she read, then thumbed out a response.

She looked effervescent, like sunlight through champagne bubbles. She walked with a spring in her step and the hint of a smile, like she'd burst into giggles at any moment. She looked like a woman in the early stages of a relationship—which in a very real way, she was.

It was as scary as it was exciting.

As casually as I could manage, I asked her, "So anyone ask you out today?"

Erin looked up from her phone. "I didn't make it to the gym, although there's a cute new stay-at-home dad we met in the park."

This woman knew exactly how to push my buttons, and best of all, she knew it. I kept things light. "You set up a play date?"

"Now that's a good idea," Erin said. She stuffed her phone into the back pocket of her tight jeans.

My blood pressure began to rise as I formulated my next sentence. "You know, I'd have no problem with it, right?"

"The play date? Or...something more?"

I felt fuzzy, like I'd been startled from sleep only to find myself in a strange new place. "Something more."

Erin walked up to me, her playfulness giving way to something softer. "You know I don't need any of this, right? I appreciate the...freedom we have, but you've already given me so much."

She thought I was making a concession, when I was trying to encourage instead. "It's not just...that..."

Erin nodded, as if I'd said a lot more than four stuttered words. We'd been together for a decade, maybe I had. "It turns you on, doesn't it?"

"You know it does," I said, telegraphing as much confidence as I could muster.

"But it's not just the sex. It's everything that comes with it, too. The flirting. The availability. The naughtiness when you think about me acting like I'm single."

Each line surged through me. Each word sent a spark down my spine.

"So if Mike asks me out again, you'd be okay if I accepted?"

"Mike?"

Erin bounced on the balls of her feet. "From the gym."

"He the one who asked you out before?"

"One of them," she said, raising her brows playfully. "Liz and a few of the others from the training group have asked if I wanted to go out with them some night. Maybe I should take them up on it. Dance with a few strange guys. Have some...fun."

She reached down and found me as erect as she expected.

"You'd like that, wouldn't you?" Erin said.

"As long as I hear about it."

Erin lowered herself to the floor, slowly unzipping me. Her eyes never left mine. “Of course you would, dear. Part of the fun is sharing just how naughty your wife can be...” When her mouth closed around my cock, my anxiety faded away.

For a time, anyway. By the next day, it was back, as forgetful yet ever present as the pressure in the plane’s cabin. Getting on the plane, knowing that while I would be hundreds of miles from Erin, AJ wouldn’t be, was hard. It was like leaving the house with the burner on. I had to ignore my instincts to deboard and run home. Instead, I dutifully powered my phone down and waited for takeoff.

But Erin wasn’t Val. Erin was Erin, and what we had was our own. Not hers. Not mine. Ours.

That helped. Some. The anxiety tapping at my heart seemed quieter. It was still there—I don’t think I ever wanted to be fully comfortable with this setup—but it was distant.

There was a car waiting for me at the airport, a man in a black suit holding a sign with *Smith* on it. It was a strange thing, being treated as a genuine executive, but there it was.

I had just enough time to drop my things off at my hotel and take a taxi over to the offices. The other members of my traveling team were already there, ready to observe Benoit and his staff.

*

“So how did it go?” Erin asked later that night.

“Hm?” I was already in bed, exhausted after the long day. I’d called to say goodnight to the kids earlier, and now it was time for me to turn in. “Oh, my day? Long.”

I wish that I could have said that I’d left the lingering anxiety behind in DC and that I was focused on the task at hand—to figure out what the hell was going on in New

Orleans—but that wasn't true. My mind was split, one part on Benoit, the other on my wife, and the result was that I couldn't focus on either.

"So is he up to no good?" she prompted.

"Benoit?"

Erin laughed. "Who else?"

I didn't want to talk shop with my wife. I wanted to ask her about her day, about whether anyone flirted with her or if she saw that "cute stay-at-home dad" at the park again.

"Sorry, I'm just...totally beat. No, I found no smoking gun. His team seems friendly enough, although I get the feeling that they're kind of standoffish."

"You're the boss. Of course they're going to be like that."

"I suppose, but I don't remember ever being like this when I was working for Al Myers."

Erin said, "Well, that's because you never respected him. Clearly Brian Benoit respects you. It's better that way."

"I like you," I said. "You want to get a drink some time?"

"But sir, I'm married."

"Oh, right. Sometimes I forget." We shared a laugh. "I bet you miss your AJ time this week."

"What makes you think that?" she asked, lightly enough that I heard it for the trap that it was.

"Really?"

"We went for a run this morning after I dropped the kids off in preschool." I could practically see her smile in her voice. "Then we went back to his place and had a lot of sex."

I was lying in my hotel bed, feeling the vastness between me and my wife. I wished that she was there to tease me.

But she wasn't, and that wasn't stopping her. "During one of our water breaks, we were in the kitchen. We were naked, of course, because why bother with clothes?"

“Yeah, why bother?” It was true, but it also sounded so different than the woman who’d taken care of two sick kids earlier that week.

“Anyway, he wasn’t exactly hard, but he was just hanging there in that slightly swollen state, you know? It was so distracting, so I just went down on him, right there in the kitchen. He let me go at it until he was fully erect again, then he took me against the wall.”

She went quiet for a moment, letting my mind fill with the two of them. I swelled. I reached down, touching myself. I heard her heavy breath down the line. She was back there, too. Back with AJ.

Her voice returned, breathy. “He held me up like I weighed nothing. He’s so strong, Tom. So physical.” She was pushing my buttons and knew it. “And his cock... Oh, Tom... I definitely couldn’t handle something that big all the time, but I’m not going to be able to give that up anytime soon.”

I saw them fucking. Saw AJ lifting her up and down along his cock, her legs wrapped around his torso, her tits crushed against his hard chest.

“Are you touching yourself?” Erin asked tightly.

“Yes,” I said, realizing that I was. “You?”

“Yes...” She groaned. “Oh, yes.”

I stroked myself as her moans and sighs caressed me, thinking about AJ fucking Erin against the wall, thinking about Erin alone in our bed, her fingers furiously at work on her clit.

“Wish you...could have seen it,” Erin said between moans. “He held me against the wall, my legs wrapped around him. We kept trying to kiss, but it was just...too...hard...”

“Oh, Erin...” I felt myself begin to lose it.

“Oh, Tom!” Her cry sizzled down the line, igniting an explosion of my own.

For the longest time, we just lay there, listening to one another’s heavy breathing down the line. At last, Erin said,

"I miss you, Tom."

"I miss you, too, love. I'll see you Saturday."

"Saturday. Yes. Good luck tomorrow."

"Thanks. Night, Erin."

I cleaned up and let sleep take me, too exhausted to think about Erin or AJ or Brian Benoit or what the future held. For once, I let it all go and slept.

*

In the morning, on my way into the New Orleans Lattice office, just as I shifted into troubleshooting executive mode, I received a text from Erin that shook me right back out of it.

-Mike from the gym asked me out again. I told him I might be free next week. xx

We pulled up to the office before I could respond, and my team was waiting on the curb for me. I took a deep breath and put it out of my head.

Which was, of course, impossible.

Benoit's team spent the morning outlining their current business processes. I was happy that I wasn't the only one there, because it took until after lunch for me to get my head on straight.

Even Benoit noticed. As we were walking back from lunch, he said, "You alright, buddy?"

Benoit was an okay guy outside of the office. He was just a complete asshole while he was there.

"Yeah, just working through some things."

"Heavy is the burden... I get it." He was quiet a moment. "I know you mean best for Lattice. I've studied what you did for the DC office. I respect you." I heard the *but* coming. "If I came to you last year with my action plan and made you implement it, how would you have felt?"

I thought about that one. Really considered it. If he'd done that, I would have been upset that some bigwig was

about to undermine all that I'd worked to build. Benoit had a point, but he wasn't seeing the bigger picture.

He pressed, seeing an opening. "Look, my guys have a proposal. A compromise. They've been working on it all week. Let us present it to you. See what you think."

I heard the plea in his voice. That didn't seem right. Here was a man who normally spat fire practically groveling.

"You don't have to make a decision today. Or even this trip. Just...hear them out."

Something about his phrasing rang true for me. I couldn't put my finger on it, but it couldn't hurt to hear what they had to say. "Sure thing."

The guys really had put a lot of effort into the proposal. I was glad that we'd just spent the last day and a half going over this office's current processes. It let me understand how this new one fit in. Benoit and his team had stopped simply writing off my ideas in favor of theirs. As they went through their slides and explained the numbers—past, current, projected—I saw the compromise in their logic.

It took most of the afternoon to cover it all, and when they were done, my head was spinning and I was left with a fat, coil-bound report that summarized everything.

"Look, I know that everyone claims that they're special," Benoit said in closing. "And everyone thinks that their way is the right way. I know I've been guilty of that a few times."

A few of the guys on his team laughed to themselves at that.

"So thanks for hearing us out. I know you've come a long way, and are probably looking forward to getting back to your family, so please don't make your decision now. Think on it. Have your guys look at it. And we'll be in touch next week."

Again I had to shake my head at how different this version of Benoit was. As I left, shaking his hand and promising to take his proposal seriously, I realized that he was doing what he had to in order to survive. He was

adapting to the new norm, and doing a better job than I would have thought.

*

We'd finished up early enough Friday afternoon that I was able to catch an evening flight home. I started typing out a text to Erin, letting her know that I'd be home that night instead of tomorrow, then stopped myself.

Sean's story bubbled up. He'd flown home early. He'd walked in on his wife. He'd discovered something that changed his life. A pit opened in my stomach as I was once again in Sean's shoes, walking into his house. Only suddenly, it was my house, it was my wife moaning, it was my heart sinking.

I knew that wouldn't happen. I trusted her. Maybe that was why I didn't call and tell her that I'd back tonight.

Of course, there were other possibilities. There was her text, which I had completely forgotten about until now. It was unlikely, but what if she'd found a babysitter. What if she had a date? That was a far more likely scenario—Erin would never do anything with the kids around. It was a line neither of us would ever cross.

At the airport, I picked up two t-shirts for the kids, along with some Mardi Gras beads. I flew home with my suit on and psyched myself up. I had a hot wife at home, a dizzying salary, and the entire southeastern region of Lattice working for me. Even my toughest manager was doing his best to make things right—for me. That was power. That was control.

So why did I feel so much dread?

It was after nine by the time my cab pulled up outside of the house. The upstairs lights were off, although the main floor was alight. When I saw Erin's Toyota in the driveway and no others in the street, I felt a pang of disappointment. No date. No babysitter. No sexy story.

Still, my heart thundered as I slipped the key into the front door and opened it.

Laughter struck me in the chest. Erin's and someone else's. A man's laughter.

I froze, quickly trying to figure out where it was coming from. Upstairs? No. The kitchen.

"Are you *serious?!'*" Erin said, her laughter still lingering in the question.

"One hundred percent. I was actually driving the limo myself that night. I could probably get you a ticket..."

I recognized the voice instantly. It wasn't the New Jersey accent of AJ. It was the more brash, more boisterous one of Lucas Hughes. I felt like I'd wandered down the wrong alley and had been jumped.

Erin laughed. "Are you really offering me a ticket to a sex party?"

"It's not a sex party. It's a *lifestyle* club, for couples with open minds," Lucas said.

My ears burned. My heart pounded. Was I Sean? Was everything about to change? I stepped into the entrance to our kitchen, cold jealousy racing through my body at what I might find. Were they in one another's arms? Was Erin seated on the kitchen table, naked as Lucas fucked her standing up? I felt like Sean.

And like all the times I'd imagined this moment, beyond the crippling sense of the imagined betrayal, I was also deeply, disturbingly turned on.

My voice sounded stronger than I felt. "Am I interrupting something?"

They weren't fucking. Or naked. Or even standing close to one another. Lucas was leaning against the sink, his sleeves rolled up as though he'd just finished washing the dishes. Erin was on the opposite side of the island counter. Both held glasses of wine, which did a number on my nerves, but Erin looked neither guilty nor apologetic.

Erin was dressed in the guise of suburban housewife: khaki capris and a tight fitting, white-collared polo shirt. It was almost impossible to imagine this preppy brunette with so many secrets.

I looked from her to Lucas, my mind still reeling from the possibility that the two of them—

“Tom! You’re home early!” Erin breezed over to me, her smile genuine, her kiss loving. “This a good thing, or a bad thing?”

Confused, I said, “Is what a good thing?” Did she know I was testing her? And was that even what I was doing?

She seemed confused by my confusion. “The fact that you’re home tonight instead of tomorrow. Things either went really well with Benoit, or really badly.”

I chanced a look at Lucas, who wasn’t looking nearly as happy to see me as Erin.

I turned back to Erin. “Maybe I just couldn’t stand another night away from you.” Take that, Lucas.

Erin rolled her eyes playfully at the cheesy line. “Aw, I missed you, too.”

I put my arms around Erin as she turned to face our guest. “Hey, Lucas,” I greeted at last.

“How’s it going, Tom.” Lucas’s sandy hair was slightly longer than the last time I’d seen him, but his beard was as neat and clipped as ever. He had a cultivated ruggedness that some might find handsome—I just saw a smarmy prick.

Erin spoke as if she didn’t sense the tension in the air. “Haley and Lucas came over for dinner tonight, but Haley had to leave to put Andy to bed. Lucas stayed to help me clean up all the dishes.”

Uh huh. “How thoughtful of you,” I said.

Lucas’s smile never reached his eyes. “You know me, didn’t want to make a mess and run.” He unrolled his sleeves and gave us a nod. “Well, I better head home before Haley sends out a search party. Thanks for dinner, Erin. I’ll

see you next week.” To me, as an afterthought, he said, “Welcome home, Tom.”

Erin watched him retreat with a smile of amusement on her face. As soon as the front door opened and closed, though, she turned that smile on me.

“You’re jealous.”

I was, so I decided to go on the offensive. “What was he really doing here?”

“Helping me finish the wine.” The smile held, full of mystery and innuendo.

“I’m *sure* that’s all that was on his mind,” I said sarcastically.

“No, I’m pretty sure his mind was on...other things.” She glanced down at her chest, where her tawny cleavage was on display. “It was cute, watching him trying to resist looking.”

“You know you can’t trust him, right?” I said.

“And wasn’t it you hinting at wanting me to see other guys?”

I couldn’t tell if she was messing with me or not. If she was looking for a bite, I bit. “Lucas? Lucas is...married. He’s our neighbor—”

“And you don’t like him,” she interrupted.

“Well...no. I don’t.” I felt off-balanced. “Do...do you?”

“Yes. Actually, I do. He’s pretty charming.”

“He was talking to you about a sex party. How’s that charming?”

Erin laughed out loud. “Yeah, it’s kind of crazy, right? Apparently there’s some kind of underground swingers club out here? For people like us.”

“Like us?” I thought of our arrangement with AJ and panic seized me. “You didn’t tell Lucas about AJ, did you?”

“Of course not. And that’s not what I meant. I just meant people like us as in...regular people, I guess? Couples with kids living in the suburbs.”

“Is that something you want to try? A...swingers’ club?”

She kissed me on the lips and shook her head. "It could be fun, but no. What's interesting is that I'm pretty sure Haley and Lucas have gone."

If my jaw were any looser, it would have hit the ground. "No way. Haley?" I thought of the sweet blonde. "No way," I repeated, and then: "Why do you think that?"

Erin's eyes flashed. "Because she told me."

"No way! Really? Lucas and Haley are swingers?"

Erin laughed. "Not exactly. Haley says they went once, and only watched. But after she left and I got to talking to Lucas, I don't think that *he* only looked. But that's just a hunch."

My head reeled at the news. "Wow."

"Come on upstairs with me," Erin said. "I want to fantasize about Lucas while you fuck me."

She laughed at my stunned expression. Stepping away, she grabbed her wine glass and headed for the stairs. I hated Lucas, and I hated the idea of her with Lucas on an intellectual level, but I couldn't deny that my cock was hard enough that I had to adjust it.

*

"Fuck me. Fuck me. Fuck me!" Erin's curse words rang in my ears. Half a year ago, hearing her drop the F-bomb would have been shocking. Now, it spurred me to do her harder.

"Like this?" Sweat beaded on my skin as I drove into her. She dug her heels into my buttocks, urging me faster. I obeyed, putting the last scraps of energy into my thrusts.

"Yes. Like that. Just...like...that!"

Her head rocked back and her eyes closed...thinking of Lucas? My chest tightened. I fucked her faster, determined to fuck that fantasy right out of her body. I didn't last. I couldn't last. Not when I closed my own eyes and saw Lucas enjoying my wife, Lucas between her legs, pounding her. I

pushed one last time, burying my cock in the familiar embrace of Erin's pussy, and emptied myself. Erin moaned beneath me, raking her fingernails across my back as she came.

After catching our breaths, we snuggled under the covers. With my lust satisfied for the moment, my insecurity came crashing in. Lucas? Really? Lucas?

I scrubbed him from my head, focusing on Erin, at my side, in the flesh. We were both too overheated to do more than touch each other with our hands, but even that was nice after the absence.

"Welcome home," Erin whispered.

"Thanks for the welcome." Even as I said, though, I remembered the real welcome I'd had—the one that involved walking in on her chatting with Lucas Hughes.

He'd been flirting with her for months, I realized. Was he making a play for her? "I can still trust you, right?"

Erin's caress grew soft. "Baby, you can always trust me. I love you, you understand? If anything, my time with AJ has just proven that what you and I have is so special." She paused then, her thoughts coming around to something. "Wait, is that why you came home tonight without telling me?"

Uh oh. "Not exactly."

"So you weren't actually testing me? Then were you hoping that you'd walk in on me?"

My breath caught. Erin picked up on it. "Really?" she said.

"No, not really." But that wasn't true. A part of me had been hoping, right? I stumbled to explain. "Your text this morning...about that guy."

"Mike?" She looked amused.

"I thought maybe you got a babysitter or something."

Erin laughed softly. "That would have been something. *Thanks for coming over on such short notice, Taylor. And*

pretend you don't notice that I'm dressed up for a date and my husband is out of town."

She draped herself back over me, her breast soft against my chest. She said, "So part of you was disappointed when you came home and I wasn't up to anything?"

"I never really thought that you would."

Erin's hand slipped beneath the sheets and discovered my erection. She closed her hand around me and stroked. "But you *were* disappointed."

I couldn't lie. Not with the evidence she had literally in her hand. "Maybe a little."

"So how would it make you feel if I told you that I kissed Lucas tonight?"

It felt like someone had dumped a bucket of acid down my throat. It burned inside me. Burned me right to my core. And yet, I jumped in her hand.

"Judging from the horror on your face, you hate the idea. Judging from other things...you're conflicted."

"You didn't, did you?"

"Not yet." Erin's gentle smile was as good as any caress. "But he did make a pass at me during his Labor Day barbecue."

"He did?"

Erin laughed in delight. "You boys are so easy. Just a few words here. A touch or two there. I can't believe you can get anything done. Everything's a distraction." She stroked me faster, working our still wet juices into my skin. "You should have seen Lucas tonight. I'm surprised he didn't break a plate as he rinsed them off."

I didn't like the idea of our neighbor, but I could no longer deny what the fantasy of it did to me. Not with Erin's hand pumping me.

"Oh, I felt that," she said. I saw her eyes fix on me in the dark. "It gets you excited, thinking of me and Lucas Hughes."

"No." *But God, yes.* I actually groaned as her hand picked up speed.

"At the barbecue, he told me that I was beautiful. That he was attracted to me." She studied me as she confessed it. "I didn't know what to say. He'd been drinking, so I figured it was just that. But you know what the strangest thing was?"

My answer had to squeeze free from my tight chest. "What?"

"When I looked for you, I saw Haley. She was across the lawn, watching us. Like she *knew*. And do you know what it reminded me of?"

"Me?"

She smiled brightly. "Yes, exactly. She reminded me of the way you look when I talk about AJ."

"Do you think she's, like, a voyeur? You don't think she and Lucas are playing the same game."

"I think they are. Or something like that. Exciting, isn't it?"

I groaned. Her hand jacked me faster.

"Maybe one of these days, we should all get together and see what happens?"

"What are you saying?" I said. My lungs felt tiny.

"I'm saying that I'd like to fuck Lucas Hughes as you and Haley watch."

"Uh, God..." Her confession ripped my orgasm right out of me, so intense it was almost painful.

Erin pulled her hand out from under the sheets. It was covered in my come.

"Well," she said. "Guess we know how you feel about that."

She slipped out of bed, padding naked to the bathroom to wash her hands. Even cloaked in shadow, she looked fantastic. The idea of Lucas Hughes even sharing this view sent a cold spike of jealousy through me.

"I still don't trust him, Erin."

She returned from the bathroom and slipped beneath the sheets. “Then it’s a good thing that all you have to do is trust me.”

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EIGHT

The week following my trip to New Orleans felt tense, and there were too many reasons to focus on any one thing. I tried going over the proposal that Benoit's team had come up with, but kept getting lost in the details, and when I did, all my other anxieties came crashing in to distract me. I handed it off to my team to review—delegation, I called it, not a shucking of responsibility.

Sean was still out on personal leave, and I hoped that he was sorting things out and getting to a better place. I tried not to even humor the possibility that he was a warning to me. He wasn't. Our situation was different.

I'd been so green with jealousy last Friday when I'd found Lucas Hughes flirting with my wife that I failed to grasp the Hughes's situation. They were swingers? Haley liked watching? It was crazy, yet not. It made sense. Yet as I considered it, I couldn't help but judge them. It was duplicitous, yes, but also real. Others would judge if they found out about me and Erin—my parents, my co-workers. I'd been so afraid of how this game would affect my marriage that I hadn't thought of the repercussions beyond it.

And yet if it was so ruinous, why couldn't we stop?

Tuesday morning, for example, when I got a text from Erin that she was getting a drink with the new guy, Mike, why was telling her *no* the last thing on my mind? Instead, I felt hot and buzzed and turned on as hell. It was like I was back in that time before I knew who AJ was...which reminded me that tonight was an AJ night.

-what about AJ?

Her response came quickly.

-Aw, that's so sweet that you're concerned about him. Don't worry, he'll get over it.

And then, on the first text's heels:

-Although he'll probably have to punish me next time I see him.

Those texts haunted me through the rest of the day. I left early, anxious to hear from Erin about this new guy. When I got home, the house was a picture of normalcy. The kids were painting pumpkins with Erin. I could smell dinner cooking in the oven. NPR played in the background.

The kids rushed up to me, welcoming me with open arms. Erin followed shortly behind, the swath of blue paint on her cheek contributing to her beauty.

"Hey, honey. Welcome home."

Dinner went down like any other. Bedtime crawled. And when we finally made it to the bedroom, Erin went straight for the shower. "I need to get all nice and clean for my date tonight."

She stripped out of her every day domestic clothes and invited me into the shower, where I helped her get all clean, licking her, using the showerhead on her, even touching her up with a new razor. When we emerged, I was hard and ready, but knew that she wouldn't give me relief until she'd returned.

"Think Mike will like something red? Or something black?" Erin asked, moving naked to her lingerie drawer.

We settled on a red thong and matching bra that she wore beneath a pair of skintight jeans and a loose blouse that was casual in a sexy way. "I'll text you with updates," she said, kissing me at the door, where a cab waited for her outside. And that was that.

Waiting is always the hardest part of this experience. It was also one of the sexiest. I had to sit there, my gut churning and my heart racing, as I thought about my wife out with another man.

The first text I got was a selfie of the two of them at the bar, without a description. Mike was a good looking guy, square-jawed, clean cut, and handsome in a generic kind of way. He wore a short-sleeved polo shirt despite the chillier weather, and I bet part of that had to do with showing off his arms. They looked happy together. And they looked good together.

I didn't receive another text until close to eleven, and it wasn't one that I expected.

-Headed home. I want you naked in bed when I get there.

I was about as disappointed as I could be when getting a message like that. Did that mean nothing had happened?

I was naked in bed by the time I heard the door open and shut downstairs. As Erin entered, I tried to figure out whether anything had happened. Her blouse had an extra button undone, but her makeup was in the same impeccable state as it had been when she'd left.

"So?" I asked.

Erin unbuttoned her blouse, letting it flutter to the floor behind her as she bared her red bra to me. "So it was nice."

"Just nice?"

She shimmied out of her jeans, but kept her red panties on. "Just nice. He's a good looking guy, but unfortunately... we just didn't click."

"So if Mike didn't do it for you, why are you so horny?"

She crawled onto the bed and kissed me hard. I ran my hands all over her familiar body, feeling her curves.

"Tonight, I realized just how amazing you are."

I chuckled, confused. "Well, it took you long enough."

Erin rolled her eyes. "I'm serious. You know when we first went out, and everything was so new and exciting? Like, basic things could get my heart racing. I'd think, *Tonight's a date night with Tom. I wonder what he's going to wear. Or how he's going to make me laugh.* Everything was

exciting anticipation. Well, meeting up with AJ, or getting drinks with Mike, is like that all over again, only I have you to share it with."

She crawled into my lap, pressed her cock against her wet pussy, and sank onto me.

"Well, tonight was the first night that I realized how much freedom I have. It's like I've been living on this tight budget, and now I've got an unlimited expense account."

"Hold on, now," I said. "It's not completely unlimited."

"Okay, so your brother's off limits," she said.

"And yours."

Erin laughed. "Seriously though, I've never been the hot girl—"

"Please. You've always known you're attractive. At least as long as I've known you."

"Right, but that's not what I'm saying. I've never been the *hot* girl. Not like girls like Jo. I knew guys were attracted to me, but I never felt like this before."

"Like what?"

"Like I could walk into a bar and have any man I wanted. I mean, maybe I flirted with the idea. But I never believed it."

"And now you do," I said. It was awesome to see this side of Erin bloom. I ran my hands up her body, caressing her tits.

"Now I do, yes. And it's kind of insane. Especially since I'm married."

"I love it," I blurted.

"Yeah?"

"Yes. I love you as much as I did on our wedding day, but you never cease to amaze me."

Erin smiled, picking up speed with her hips. "You just like it that you married someone with a repressed whore inside of her."

"That's part of it," I admitted. "I love how into this you are."

We fucked quietly a few more minutes as I pieced together her night. What must have happened between her picture with Mike and the hug at the end?

“So why didn’t Mike work out? What didn’t click?”

Erin thought about her answer for a long while. “He wasn’t going to be the kind of guy I need—someone dominant. Someone like AJ. Maybe it was his age—”

“His age?”

“Oh, I’m pretty sure that he is still in college.”

“Cradle robber!”

Erin giggled. “I know, right? Aaaanyway, with these guys, I’m not looking for a relationship. I’m not interested in exploring our feelings, and I’m definitely not looking to be anyone’s Mrs. Robinson.”

“You just want to get fucked.” I ended the statement with an up thrust.

“Ha. Yeah, I guess.”

So she wanted someone more dominant—more like AJ. I tightened my hands on her hips. “So, you said you wished he was more dominant. Do you ever wish that I was?”

“You are. You’re like my Don Draper in real life, with the dark good looks and the confidence.” She lowered herself over me, pressing her tits to my chest. It was enough to almost make me forget my line of thinking.

“That’s not exactly what mean.” I moved my hands from her hips to her ass. “You said the other day when you went over there that he made you get on your knees and go down on him. Do you want me to treat you like that?”

Erin pressed her lips to my ear, whispered, “Only if you want to. I don’t want you trying to be someone that you’re not.”

“But you like the way AJ treats you?”

“I wouldn’t say *like*,” Erin said carefully. For a moment, I worried that she’d try to tiptoe around this touchy subject. Maybe a few months ago, she would have. The new Erin

didn't. "What AJ and I have is just different than what you and I have."

AJ and I have. The statement stung a little—a true admission that she *had* something with another man. But at the same time, I was happy that she was being honest.

"Different how?"

"Oh, I don't think I need to spell it out for you," Erin said with a laugh. She pulled back, looking down at me. Her hair fell around us. "I think you want me to, though." She squeezed me with her thighs, with her pussy. "When I'm with AJ...when he *fucks* me...it's so intense. So intense. It's like there's no filter with him. No context. All we have is sex, you know? And in a way, that's totally freeing. I've...never been involved in a relationship like this."

"Not even before you met me?"

"Not like this. Not like...booty calls or something. When I go over to his place, there's no ambiguity anymore. I'm there to fuck him. He doesn't need to romance me. He doesn't have to sweet talk me. He just throws me onto the bed and takes me. I never thought I could be that girl, but with AJ, I am."

"Do you regret that you didn't do that before?"

She looked down at me, thinking over her response. "Not even a little. Only reason this works at all is because I know I've got you to come back to."

I stared into her eyes and knew what she was saying was true. They were so vibrantly green, like wind blowing across grass in a meadow.

I remembered how AJ had spanked her. How he'd taken her to a strip club and had another woman strip for her. He was going to take her ass. Who knew where else he'd take her? And as these thoughts built like a cacophony, Erin fucked me faster, feeling my cock grow with my excitement.

"You like thinking about me being so bad, don't you? So when the next hot guy asks me out, you won't mind if I just go for it?"

“Oh, Erin...”

“And if he ties me to the bed and fucks me until I pass out, you’d get turned on almost as much as me, wouldn’t you?”

I never realized how into bondage she was, yet the thought of letting her go with another guy was intoxicating.

“He’d spank me. He’d treat me like a dirty girl.”

A dirty girl that you aren’t, I thought.

“And he’d make me come so hard.” She was close, her voice taking on the edge of immediacy. I clutched her ass and fucked up into her. I was there in her fantasy, watching from the corner as she unleashed her inner slut.

I came hard, Erin right on my heels, and with the orgasm went my energy—the good, the bad, the nervous and excited. For a couple blissful moments, as Erin rolled off me and covered us in our thick comforter, I was empty and at peace.

That peace didn’t quite make it to sleep, though, as my subconscious crawled back through the orgasmic haze. AJ and Erin and dominance and desire laced through me as surely as the tendrils of exhaustion. Were there times when she thought of me like she had Mike, someone who didn’t push the right buttons? Sleep took me before I had an answer.

*

I almost decided to skip my workout with AJ on Wednesday morning. That fear of discovery was no more real than with the man himself, and while AJ hadn’t figured out who I was, I was terrified of the day that he would.

I decided to meet him because I couldn’t think of a good way to cancel. Every reason I came up with felt like I was wimping out—which was basically what I was doing.

And Erin was right, too. A part of me was excited by the danger of him knowing. There was a thrill to it, like walking

along the lip of a fissure.

Not that I brought Erin up. I played it cautiously, and mercifully, he didn't mention her, either. We met at the gym, as he'd suggested, working weights as we talked about typical guy things: football, grilling in the fall, that sort of thing. He even gave me pointers on how to be more efficient with my lunchtime gym routine.

I asked him about his tattoo. "A dragon, huh?"

"Not any dragon," he replied. "The *Pendragon*."

I blinked. Aj was into King Arthur? That was... unexpected. "Like, Arthur and Excalibur?"

Aj laughed. "Fuck no. I'm talking Uther the Pendragon. He fucked another man's wife, and Arthur was born."

"Now I see the appeal," I said, chuckling.

"Way more badass."

I didn't know what to make of it, so I just laughed along with him.

He mentioned that he may have a new high profile client coming on board, but it wasn't a done deal so he didn't want to talk about it. "May cut into our bro time, though. I'll keep you posted."

*

Once again, I did my best to focus on work. My team had reviewed Benoit's proposal. Bernard, our accountant, went over his numbers with me.

"It could work. There's some brilliant ideas here—really novel stuff."

"But?" I asked, sitting back in my chair. My eyes drifted to a photograph of Erin, smiling up at me. Had she always had that glint of mischief in her eyes and I was just noticing it now?

Bernard went on. "You know how they say that the sign of compromise is when no one is happy?"

"You're not happy," I said.

“And neither are the guys who put this together. I can read it in their tone.”

“We’re all in a pretty shitty position, aren’t we?”

“We are,” Bernard agreed.

“Thanks, man. I’ve got a lot to think about.”

“I’ll email you my full report.” Bernard rose. “I’m glad I’m not in your shoes.”

“Thanks, buddy.”

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NINE

"I need to go to New Orleans next week."

"Uh oh. So soon after the last?" Erin said.

"So soon."

"Sorry to hear that."

We were eating dinner, so that short exchange actually took about ten minutes as we entertained the kids. Mary kept switching between my lap and hers, and Martin wanted us to read a Batman book to him or he wouldn't touch his pizza slices.

"I can't believe we have to bribe them to eat pizza," I laughed.

"Tell me about it!" Erin said.

Later that night, when we had more time, I gave Erin an abbreviated update to the situation with the New Orleans office. "The trip shouldn't take too long."

"You sure about this?" Erin asked. I'd kept her updated on the inter-office drama, so she knew the beef between my team and Benoit's.

"I think so. At least, it's what my gut is telling me is the right thing to do."

Erin nodded. "Trust your gut then. It's gotten you this far."

"Hopefully I'm not making a huge mistake."

Erin kissed me softly. "If you are, then we'll get through that, too."

We. It had a nice ring to it. "Meet me out there. After."

Erin's smile formed slowly, like a sunrise. "Yes. Let's do that. I'll set it up with my mom." She kissed me long and deep. "Our first vacation together in five years..."

"Why don't you fly out Friday night, for dinner. I should be done then."

"It'll be nice to reconnect. Just the two of us."

I nodded. She didn't need to say AJ's name. I knew what she was saying. "Just the two of us."

*

Of course, the teasing and the game didn't stop on the lead up to our trip. She saw AJ Thursday night, and then the following Tuesday. She'd tease me with details of their encounters.

"AJ had to get the handcuffs out for me tonight..."

Or, "My jaw is so sore tonight."

Or, "AJ made me shave my pussy in front of him because he said I wasn't smooth enough."

She met up with the triathlon training group Friday evening for the first time since they'd all gone out and gotten their collective tattoos. I waited at home on bated breath, but she returned just before nine with only innocuous stories to tell—apparently Hayden and Ellen were engaged, Hope was moving to London, and the group was still oblivious to AJ and Erin. Erin did say that Liz seemed suspicious though.

She also said that while she was at the bar, waiting on her drink, a couple of guys had hit on her. "I almost considered giving one of them my number," she said.

"You didn't..." My heart raced nervously. Flirting was fine, but her number seemed like a step too far, especially in our own town.

"Of course not," she said. "But I got his."

"Come on, let's go upstairs."

Sunday, we went apple picking and she flirted with the guy at the checkout table. We went out to dinner as a family Wednesday night—one of those great big chain cantinas where they press their own tortillas and the kids could be as loud and as messy as they wanted—and she flirted with our server. The poor guy didn't seem to know what hit him.

And with each flirty encounter, I grew more excited by this confident woman who was my wife. She seemed more comfortable in her skin than ever before. The thought of Erin broadening her bullpen of guys was hot—and fit that hotwife term. I wasn't sure that's where we were headed, but I was prepared to go there if it was.

All the teasing ended up being a good thing. It distracted me enough that I didn't worry so much about my trip to New Orleans, or what I needed to do. Ironically, the more stuff I had going on in my head with the home life, the more certain I was of New Orleans, and by the time I was set to fly Thursday evening, I was ready for what came next.

Erin made sure to keep up the distraction, right up to the last minute before my meeting Friday morning. "I'm going to call you tomorrow morning," she said as we said our goodbyes at the airport. "I want you alone and in your hotel when I do."

"What time? I've got an entire team waiting on me."

"Tell them to wait longer. It'll be worth it. I'll call at nine."

That night, alone in my hotel room in New Orleans, I barely slept.

*

My phone rumbled to life five minutes to nine on Friday morning. Erin's smiling profile photo filled the screen. My heart leapt. I still had no idea what she'd planned, but my nerves were on edge.

"Good morning." I tried to sound more calm than I felt.

"Morning." She sounded out of breath. "Are you alone?"

I looked around at my hotel room. My suitcase was flipped open, still mostly filled. "Yeah. I'm still at the hotel. I've got an extra hour before I need to head into the office."

"Great. I'm going to call you up on Skype. Hold on."

The line went dead. I pulled the phone away, studying the way the screen flashed, *Call Ended*, as pressure built around me. The hotel room was quiet enough that I swear my pounding heart filled the void. When the Skype call came in, I jumped.

Connecting...

Connecting...

Video blurred onto the screen, a room smeared by a hastily moving camera. I made out beige walls zipping by, dark wood furniture that I didn't recognize. I saw a purse sitting on the dresser—Erin's purse—and then the world shifted again and was still. Erin's face filled the screen. She looked nervous.

"Where are you?" I asked.

Erin didn't answer. She didn't even seem to register the question. A half-second later, I understood why. She leaned in close, her face filling the screen. "I muted you," she whispered. "Enjoy the show."

She stepped back and ran her hands through her hair. It was damp, and she wore nothing but a white towel. I was confused, but I was rapidly formulating a theory.

In the background, the hiss of the water that I hadn't even realized was there cut off. Erin glanced over her shoulder, licking her lips quickly, then looked at me. She leaned in enough to give me a peek at her cleavage down the front of the towel, and whispered, "Love you."

She straightened up, turned her back to me, and dropped the towel onto the floor. I gasped at the sight of her heart-shaped ass, still full, yet toned from her long hours of training, punctuated with crisp dimples in her lower back.

A moment later, AJ emerged from the door in the background, toweling off his hair, but otherwise totally naked.

He entered with a swagger that would have looked ridiculous if I tried it. AJ carried it naturally. I didn't want to look, but I couldn't not; his cock swung full yet flaccid

between his thighs, a meaty testament to his virility. Just as before, it was hard not to notice that he was clean shaven, somehow making his nudity even more obscene.

He looked like a man forged completely of muscle—deeply tanned skin stretched taut over sinew and bone. A large, dragon tattoo covered his left chest and shoulder, and he had another on the inside of his right bicep. I never thought Erin was one to go for tats, but here she was, in his bedroom.

AJ grinned at Erin and tossed his towel back into the bathroom. “Fuck, you look good.” He reached down and circled his fingers around his rising member. “Come here.”

Erin approached, tentative despite how much action she must have already experienced. It was a strange thing to see after the strong, dominant woman I’d discovered these past few months.

When he pulled her into him and kissed her, my chest tightened.

“So we’ve got an hour?”

I didn’t need to see her face to see the smile in her reply. “Just over.”

“Then let’s stop wasting time.” He guided her to the bed, granting me full frontal access to my wife’s rocking body. If AJ was the epitome of what a man was, Erin was his perfect compliment: soft where he was hard, curvy where he was all straight lines.

They tumbled into the mattress, their tongues dancing in another stomach-wrenching kiss. I eased back onto my own bed and worked open my trousers.

“I can’t get enough of this.” He ran his hands over her body, making it clear what he meant by *this*.

“Me either,” she said.

Erin stretched backward, letting AJ smother her with his hard body. He filled his whole hand with tit-flesh and lifted her nipple to his mouth. Erin stretched even more, her head slipping off the side of the bed. Her wet hair cascaded to the

floor as AJ rose over her. In his hand was his fully erect cock, and even on the little screen, it was intimidating.

"Were you thinking about this?" he asked, stroking it.

"Yes."

"Were you thinking about me instead of your husband the last time you were with him?"

"Mmm hmm..." she said.

With my cock in hand and heart in my throat, I tried to puzzle out whether she was telling the truth, telling AJ what he wanted to hear, or saying what she thought I wanted to hear. And like all things in this crazy adventure, there was no clear answer.

He wrapped his hand around his cock, now fully erect. It was huge. I was nervous for her. Nervous for *us* and what that thing meant to our relationship. "You ready for this?"

"Yes," she said tightly.

He slapped it against her smooth mound. "Me too. *So* ready."

I waited for him to pause in his teasing of her and grab a condom. I waited for them to shift out of foreplay. It never happened.

I had the perfect angle to see everything. To watch Erin spread her legs for him. To watch her reach out and guide him against her glistening pussy. To watch him rock forward, his cock stretching her open. His cock. His unshielded, condomless cock.

Erin moaned, her head lolling back.

I couldn't breathe. I couldn't think. I was frozen as that little screen consumed my entire world. He was fucking her bareback?

AJ pushed deeper. His cock sank into Erin. Into her moist, wet sex, until the smooth skin of their pelvises touched. He drew back and entered her again. And again.

"Oh, yes, babe. That feels so much fucking better like that."

Despite the sense of wrongness, I nearly came. I could have easily, but there were fifty more minutes of show left, and I didn't want to tap out so early.

"You like the feel, baby?" AJ asked.

"It's good," Erin sighed.

"Good? I'm going for *great*."

AJ dominated my wife, fucking her hard enough to shift them along the groaning mattress. She wrapped her legs behind his back and gave herself to her lover as more of her body slipped out over the edge. She didn't try to brace herself. She didn't try to adjust, even as her head hung upside down and her dark hair pooled across the hardwood floor.

Her eyes were closed, her brow furrowed. Her mouth hung open as her moans tumbled out, tight and breathy.

Above her, pinning her between bed and body, loomed AJ. He shifted his approach, taking her in quick, short thrusts as their position on the mattress grew tenuous.

This wasn't real. It couldn't be. As I stared at that little screen, I couldn't reconcile the woman on there as my wife. It felt more like porn than a snapshot of real life: she was a hot brunette with a great body getting fucked by an equally good looking dude. And yet, I couldn't deny her voice and the way she moaned. I'd been hearing it for over a decade, only it had always been directed at me.

"Oh...mygod!" She clenched and released her fists, which dangled up over her head, as AJ raged over her.

"Come, baby. Come for AJ."

Her voice strained a yesss... She moaned again, twisted back. AJ took her neck, sucking along the slender column of flesh. She crashed through her orgasm, arching beneath him enough to pull her neck out of range. He shifted down to her tits instead, swallowing a nipple whole. Her moan intensified as she pushed more of her chest against him.

AJ slowed his thrusts as she rode out the intense throes, but never stopped. Erin got her breathing under control,

reducing them first to deep breaths that rattled in her throat, and then to something more normal.

AJ dragged her back until they were once again centered on his ruined bed. When they kissed, it was long and slow—a post-sex kiss that I knew well, and never thought she'd share with someone else. That kiss, more than anything else, got me squirming. I had to look away and stop touching myself or I'd lose it.

He pumped his hips over her, as if reminding both of us that he was still hard and still buried inside of her. "Aren't you glad we skipped the rubber?"

"It feels nice," Erin said with a dreamy smile.

So this wasn't some spontaneous thing. They'd talked about it. That revelation didn't do much to ease my discomfort.

They fucked some more after that. I watched, nursing my erection like a designated driver would a beer. Erin had been right, AJ was much more aggressive than me, and a lot more physical. He manhandled her, flipping her onto her stomach and pushing her hips down into the bed as she spread her legs to either side. He entered from behind, the angle acute enough that each thrust must have rubbed right against her g-spot. Erin groaned with each plunge like it did.

He smacked her ass, just as he had back when I'd watched them from the boathouse. On camera and so much closer, there was no doubting that it turned Erin on.

"Fuck, you've got a great ass." He spanked it again, this time squeezing the meaty cheek. She moaned louder. He traced his thumb along her crack and found her asshole. Erin squirmed. "So you've never had it back here?"

Erin shook her head, unable to speak through her soft squeals.

"You and your husband never get nasty?"

"Aj..."

"Tell me, babe. Your husband never fucked your ass?"

"Uh uh."

“Pussy.” Aj’s slur registered on me like a blow, but like the spansks he’d given Erin, pleasure twisted with the pain. “Waiting for a real man to take it?”

“He...is a real man...”

“Then why are you here, fucking me?” He pushed his thumb against her anus. Erin cried out. “You want it, don’t you?”

“Aj, just...just fuck me...please...”

He did, lifting his hips even higher for a full on assault of her g-spot, but his dirty talk didn’t relent, either. “You mean like this? This what you want?”

Erin raked her hair out of her face as she squirmed beneath him. Her moans grew. Watching them earlier had the intensity of a first time. Watching them now was just intense. Erin was into the sex in a way I’d never seen before—she’d said he’d been different than me, more aggressive, but I had to see it to understand how turned on it made her.

My heart tightened, but this time not from jealousy or fear, but from lust. That bombshell on the other end of the phone? She was my wife, and she was so fucking sexy. I remember feeling this way the night of our wedding, when Erin had stripped down to her white lingerie and spread out on our marital bed. *How could I be so lucky?*

Aj continued to plow her, his tanned skin glistening with sweat. He slapped her ass with his left hand, continuing to tease her backdoor with his right. “God, baby, your pussy loves my cock.”

She moaned something unintelligible.

He went on, pressing the tip of his thumb into her asshole. “You know what else will love it?”

Her voice emerged strained and soft. “Oh, my God, Aj...”

“You want it, don’t you?”

The question hung, thick and swollen. I lifted the phone closer, turning up the volume. Even then I could barely hear her reply over the Skype call.

“Yes.”

“Say it. Tell me what you want.” He pushed his thumb harder.

“Ngh!”

“Say it.”

“I want you...” She was panting hard, close once again. “I want you to fuck my—uh!”

“Your what?” AJ buried the first joint of his thumb into her.

“I want you to fuck my ass!”

“My pleasure.” He yanked out of her, leaving her sputtering at the precipice of her orgasm.

“No!” she protested, rocking her hips back in search of his dislodged member.

AJ reached into a drawer by his bedside, removing a bottle of lube. “Don’t worry, baby. You’re about to have the biggest orgasm of your life.”

My mouth dropped open. This wasn’t happening. This was a dream. Had to be. And yet, the image didn’t go away. AJ smeared lube along his length, and then rubbed some against her asshole. Erin wriggled, but the protest I’d been expecting didn’t come. We’d never actually talked about anal sex, but I never thought she’d be into it. She proved just how wrong I could be.

“Spread your cheeks, babe,” AJ ordered, taking up position behind her once again.

Erin reached back and did as she was told, splaying her buttocks as AJ guided his cock against her puckered opening. On such a small screen, the details were hard to discern, but the things I heard out of the speakers were enough to burn my ears.

Erin’s moans bordered on wails as AJ’s girth probed where no man had before. “Slower...slower...”

“That’s it, baby. Just relax. Let me in and relax.” He delivered the instructions with an ease that suggested this

was far from the first time he'd been here. "Breathe. Remember to breathe."

She tried to follow his instructions, but her breaths came shorter and shallower. At last, he slid home, ball-deep in Erin's ass. He paused there, letting her get used to the intrusion and catch her breath.

"How does that feel, baby?" he asked.

"Oh, my...so...so full."

AJ drew back slowly, the friction of the movement drawing a scream from Erin. It took me a moment to realize it wasn't one of pain—or if it was pain, there was a hell of a lot of pleasure, too.

"You like that? You like feeling my cock in your ass?"

"Ngh, huh..." she moaned, twisting like a pig on a spit.

AJ slowly accelerated into the ass fuck, always keeping her right at the edge of too-much. She twisted enough that I could see her face on my little screen, covered in a tangle of dark bangs. I wanted to remember that expression for the rest of my life—the expression of pure, unadulterated lust.

And it wasn't from me.

"Touch yourself, slut. Finger yourself while I take your anal virginity."

I winced at the word *slut*. Erin didn't seem to mind. She squeezed both arms beneath her, her hands seeking out her vacant pussy as AJ rode her. She did everything he told her to do. It was still so fucking incongruous with the strong, dominating woman I'd come to know over the last three months, but there she was—a woman who got off on being called *slut* and let herself be used like a sex toy by an egocentric man-whore.

"Jesus *Christ!*" AJ cried out.

Erin's lips curled up in a smile.

AJ rammed into her hard enough that their bodies slapped. "You naughty little slut. You really *do* like my shaved balls."

I got the idea: she was tugging at his scrotum.

“Maybe...I just want to feel your come...in my ass.”

“That’s not how it works. Only I decide when you get that.” Such a different dynamic than what we had. “What do you want, Erin? Tell me what I want to hear?”

On her stomach, with her hands working her pussy, her legs splayed, and AJ bearing down on her, Erin was as pinned as a butterfly on display.

“Fuck my ass. Fuck my married ass.”

We came together, although I may have been a split second behind them as her statement sank in. I dropped the phone as my come spewed into my hand. Erin’s screams and AJ’s heavy grunts sounded tinny and weak. I could almost pretend they weren’t real.

Almost, but not quite.

I carried the phone into the bathroom where I cleaned up. It was 9:45. Reality came storming back: my job, the meetings, the hard conversations and even harder decisions. I needed to get going.

“This is mine,” I heard AJ say on my phone. “Only I get to fuck your ass. Not your husband. Not another lover. Only me. Understand?”

I zipped up my trousers before my cock had a chance to harden any more.

“Understand?” AJ asked again. I paused to listen to Erin’s reply.

“Yes, baby. Don’t worry, he’s never asked for it, and he’ll never know.”

I laughed at the lie, but just as I hit end, I heard AJ’s follow-up: “No, babe. Tell him. Tell him that you gave it to me and he can’t have it.”

I wished I could have heard her response, the my finger had already touched the end button. I held the phone until the screen went dark, my breath heavy, my heart racing.

Then, somehow, I gathered my strength and refocused.

Okay, time to start my day.

*

Only it wasn't that easy, of course. I wasn't exactly crippled by insecurity or anything, but as my blood cooled in the quiet of my hotel room, I was left with a lot to think about. It was a gorgeous room—gilded mirrors, a plush bed with high thread count sheets, and high ceilings. I saw none of it.

For the first time, I realized just how *not* a game this game was. AJ wasn't the kind of guy who played second fiddle, and with that command—to rub the anal sex in my face—was a good indication of the kind of guy that he was. It was like going to pet a dog and realizing that he was really a wolf.

And yet the risk was intoxicating. It came with a sense of tension that I knew well in my professional life—the risk of the deal, the risk of doing something that no one else in their right mind would do, and getting away with it.

The ride from the Hotel Montmartre, where I was staying at the edge of the French Quarter, was a short ride to the Lattice offices. This time, I brought no one else from my team. I needed to send a message, and showing up with an entourage would not help.

I reviewed Benoit's coil-bound proposal on the trip over one last time. I knew in my heart that Brian Benoit wanted to go back to the way things were. Even as recently as a couple weeks ago, he'd reiterated again that *we can still salvage the numbers. Let me show you before it's too late*. And yet he'd gotten his team to produce this compromise. Here was a man who'd finally given up control.

I thought about my own situation. Was that what I was doing? Was I ceding control in my relationship to Erin (and AJ)? The very idea of it rankled me. I didn't need to think too hard to recall AJ calling me a pussy to my wife's face, and while she'd come to my defense, she'd still let him fuck her ass.

Yet she *had* come to my defense. No matter how wild she got, she always came back around to me. I may be surrendering, but I was doing so to someone I trusted. In fact, I seemed to be an integral part of the fantasy for Erin. Jo had said it at the Labor Day Party. She'd said that Erin got off just as much on what it was doing to me as what Aj was doing to her.

My phone rumbled as the cab pulled up to the Lattice office. I checked.

-not looking forward to sitting on a plane for a couple hours later today. hope you enjoyed watching that. i know i did ;)

I groaned, adjusting myself as I stepped out of the cab. Erin had given up control, too, to another man, and she'd loved it. As I looked up at the tall building, where a room filled with anxious employees waited, I wondered if giving up control would be as easy for me.

*

The boardroom was, indeed, packed. All twenty-eight members of the New Orleans office were there, standing along the walls, crammed into a room meant for no more than a dozen. I could see fear in their eyes. And resentment. To them, I was an outsider, coming in to upset the comfortable routine that they'd fallen into. I knew the feeling well. New boss, same old story.

I stood at the front of the room, at the front of the long board table. I had no PowerPoint, no meeting notes. I didn't need that for what I had to say.

"Thanks for meeting with me," I began. The crowd shifted, grumbling, but no one said a word. They all sat there, waiting for judgment.

"I don't want to drag this out, so I'll just get right to it. I reviewed your proposal. I had others review it. It's not a bad

plan, but...let's face it, we all know that it isn't going to work."

Brian Benoit looked like a man who just realized that he'd been chewing nails. I was surprised that he didn't spit right at my feet. "But—"

"I know how much effort your team has gone to," I interrupted. "Believe me, I've been here. And I know how it feels to have a boss who doesn't listen."

"That's not what I'm—"

"Brian, please. Let me finish." I didn't raise my voice, but there was command in my tone. Brian threw himself back into his chair, arms crossed, but kept his mouth shut. To the rest of the room, I said, "I want to thank you all for trying it my way, but I'm a man who can admit when I'm wrong. This time, with this office, I was wrong."

The room was silent. Mouths hung open. Eyes were wide.

"I wasn't brought in here to make everyone do it my way. Or to leave my mark. I was here to turn profits, and the best way to do that is to trust in my team." I spread my hands out, motioning to the room. "I trust this team. Should have from the beginning."

I turned to Benoit, who sat there with his mouth hanging open. "It's not a promotion, since you're already the director of this office, but you now have the autonomy to lead it your way."

I offered my hand. He stood, uncertain whether this was a joke or not. I shook his hand. "Want to talk over the details at lunch?" I asked.

It was funny to see a guy of so much bravado completely speechless. Even though I was giving up control, I'd never felt more like the boss.

"Um, sure."

"Great. You know, there are some ideas in your proposal that we could use. Not just here, but at the other three offices." *Yes, even mine.* "Let's talk."

“Sure.”

I took Brian to lunch. *Brian*. I actually started thinking of him by his first name, which surprised even me.

“You know, when I first met you, I thought you were an asshole,” Brian said over lunch.

That much candor deserved some in return. I said, “So did I.”

Brian laughed. “I’m used to it.”

He was smug, but now that I could see past it, I saw aspects of myself in him. He was a guy who trusted his intuition, was usually right about things, and was used to everyone around him depending on him.

“Point is,” he went on, “I’m glad they picked you. Don’t get me wrong, if you’d just have listened to me from the get-go, we’d all be a lot richer and a lot happier, but what’s that saying again? About letting toddlers fall so they could learn to walk?”

“You have kids, Brian?”

“Nope. Not even married. I don’t think it’s for me. I’d get too frustrated watching the kid try stuff, like walking.”

We laughed. “It’s actually an amazing experience, watching them learn something like that. Something totally new. I’ve never been so proud as the day my son successfully peed in the toilet.” I smiled at the memory. “Anyway, I’m glad that you didn’t quit on me.”

“I was close,” he said.

“I figured. But you stayed.” I held out my hand. “Make me proud.”

TEN

As I stepped out onto the curb, I checked my phone for the time. It was later than I'd expected. Nearly 7:30. And I had a text waiting for me from Erin.

-I'm here! Hanging out in the hotel bar, waiting for you. Better hurry. I don't know how much longer I'll be able to hold these guys off.

And just like that, Lattice and Brian and all that I'd done left my head. I had two full nights with Erin alone, and I intended to not miss a minute more.

Hotel Montmartre was an old hotel dating back to the 1900s, and it came with all the charm. The lobby alone, with its tall, coffered ceilings and marble floor, was worth the booking. It also featured one of the oldest sazerac lounges in the city, which is where Erin was waiting for me. I didn't even bother going up to my room to drop my things off.

The lounge at Hotel Montmartre felt like it was lifted from an old French film. It felt old and classic, with brass fixtures and red velvet booths. The ceilings were high, like the lobby, but the heavy curtains and plush, Oriental carpeting swallowed sound, giving the space an intimate feel.

Hotel Montmartre was far enough away from Bourbon Street that it wasn't overcrowded for a Friday night, although it wasn't empty, either. The bar area was mostly full, and the table tops in the bar section were also filled. The crowd looked mostly like me—men and women traveling for work, but looking to play a little before heading home.

I spotted Erin almost immediately, and in this environment, of course there was a man chatting her up. He was tall, fit, and wore a toothy white grin that made me

think of a fairytale prince. This guy was used to getting the girl, and right at that moment, he had his sights set on Erin.

It was a strange thing that despite the scene I'd witnessed this morning, watching her laugh at this guy's jokes made me so jealous.

I didn't blame the guy for trying. She wore a simple blue dress, snug but not tight or low cut. It was sleeveless, showing off her slender, tanned arms, and was cut just above her knees. Her long hair framed her face in loose, dark waves, and her face shined as she smiled at the guy talking to her.

Her Prince Charming had assumed a cocky pose beside her—half turned into her as she leaned against the bar, one arm braced just beside her.

He spoke. Erin laughed again. My chest tightened.

She glanced away from him, searching the bar. She found me by the door, holding my eyes for a curious moment. A smile tugged up the corners of her mouth and she turned back to her suitor, leaning into him a little more than before. When she smiled and nodded at him, it was a fraction brighter.

I hadn't intended to play this game out here in New Orleans. I'd figured that since we were alone for the first time in ages, we'd spend it all with each other. But as I watched her carry on with her sandy-haired stud, I wondered if she had other ideas in mind.

I crossed the room, getting closer to them without actually joining them. Erin had a glass of rich, red wine in her hand. The guy held a beer in his.

I ordered a bourbon, straight. Seemed fitting for the locale.

Erin was right beside me. I could smell her familiar perfume. Hear her familiar laughter. Just as I put my order in, the guy leaned in and kissed her neck. "You smell good," he whispered.

Erin laughed. "And you're being a little forward." She didn't seem offended.

"Tell me you want me to stop and I'll stop." He'd moved his hand to her shoulder, I noticed with a dull thud, and his thumb was caressing her bare skin.

"I'm married, remember?" she said, holding up her ring finger.

"Ditto." He tapped his own band against hers. "I won't tell if you don't."

"What if I told you that my husband and I have an arrangement?"

The room kept getting hotter and hotter. The bourbon arrived and I suddenly wished that I had ordered something colder and more thirst-quenching. Instead, I took a heavy swallow at the bourbon and let it burn in the back of my throat.

"I'd say that makes things a hell of a lot more interesting for me," the guy said.

"And if I told you that he likes to watch?"

For the first time since I'd been watching, the guy looked uncertain. He hesitated before answering, giving Erin's body another once over as though gauging whether she was worth it. "Would he want to join?"

Erin's laugh made me want to hug her. "Now that would make it a *hell of a lot more interesting for me*," she said, echoing his earlier statement.

"I don't do...I'm not into—"

"No, no, not like that." Her laugh was one of pure delight. "He's not into guys, either. This would be purely you and him on me."

Next to them, my own doubts churned. Could I do that? I'd watched, sure, but could I actually participate? This wasn't where I'd expected the night to go.

"For you, I could do that," he said.

"You *could*. Well how generous of you."

The man seemed off-balance. "Is he here, or...?"

Erin's smile lit up her eyes. "Uh uh. First, I need a token of your devotion to me. Isn't that what gentlemen do?"

"A token?"

"Are you wearing underwear?" she asked.

"Yes." It was almost a question.

"I want them. Go into the bathroom, take them off, and give them to me."

I almost burst out laughing, listening to the exchange. I sipped at the bourbon, stealing glances at the uncertainty on her suitor's face. Once again, he seemed torn between bolting and doing what Erin said.

"But these are my favorite pair."

Erin nodded. "Your lucky ones, huh?"

"Very lucky."

"Well, good, because that's about all that's going to be lucky for you tonight. Too bad, too." She reached out and brushed her hand along the front of his pants. "I was looking forward to feeling this inside me as I sucked my husband's cock."

"Hold on, I'll be right back," he said. He backpedaled, keeping his eyes on her as if she'd disappear as soon as he looked away. "Don't go anywhere."

He practically ran to the bathroom, weaving through the thickening crowd.

Erin turned to me with a smile. My stomach was in knots. Was that her plan for tonight?

"So did you make dinner reservations somewhere?" she asked, as though I hadn't just overheard the naughty conversation.

"Yeah. Dinner should be in..." I checked my watch, "... just a few minutes, actually. Should I cancel?"

Erin laughed. She latched onto my arm. "Why would you do a silly thing like that? Come on, let's get out of here before that guy comes back."

"You're evil, you know that?"

“Just having a little fun. Guys like that need to be put in their place. Like I’d just sleep with the first man who smiles at me. A girl needs to be wooed.”

“Like AJ wooed you this morning?”

We hit the evening air in New Orleans. I marveled at how humid it still was.

“AJ put in a lot of work to get to where he is today,” Erin said.

She had a point, AJ had spent the better part of three months working for it before he slept with Erin, but she was acting like she was still in control. I’d watched them in the park last week, and in his bedroom this morning. If she really did think that, she was lying to herself.

I thought about the guy she’d just dispatched so thoroughly in the bar. I didn’t want to be him tonight, so I kept my mouth shut as we made our way to dinner.

*

We walked arm-in-arm toward the restaurant, clinging to each other in a way we hadn’t done in years. “So?” she asked. “Is Brian Benoit your new best friend?”

I chuckled at that. “I wouldn’t say that we’re friends, but I don’t think he’s going to have me killed anymore.”

Erin laughed. “You real estate guys take your job seriously! I bet they were shocked.”

“Oh yeah.”

“It’s not every day that the boss admits that he’s wrong.” She smiled at me, squeezing my arm. “So what made you change your mind with him?”

“I’m still working that out, but I think it’s got something to do with control, and trusting when to give it up.” As I said it, I felt it slipping away. My gut shifted uncomfortably.

“I think I know what you mean,” Erin said with a smile.

We’d arrived at our destination, a small but busy restaurant with an old city charm to it. I held the door for

her. "Such a gentleman," she said, sliding past me.

I admired her dress again—a soft blue that hugged her body and projected polished sophistication. She wore it with confidence and a smile.

"What?" she asked when she saw me looking.

"Nothing. Just...you look good."

Erin brushed her loose hair back over an ear. "Thanks."

We were seated in the back room, which was quieter and slightly more private. The server came and took our wine orders as we settled in. When he was gone, Erin turned to me, said: "So..."

My heart immediately began to race. "So?"

"You probably have some questions."

I licked my lips as the Skype call came rushing back, full of heady and heavy emotion. I'd done a pretty good job keeping my mind off the crazy encounter. That was impossible now.

"So that was intense," I said.

Erin didn't look ashamed. She didn't look away. She didn't even blink. "It was."

"You enjoyed it?"

I felt her foot slide along my shin. "I did. You?"

It was a complicated question, although my answer was a simple one. "Yes."

"Did it get you all excited, watching me be so bad?" She stroked my leg with her foot. "I loved that you watched. I don't know that I could have...done that, if you weren't."

"Really?" I tried to recall the moment that AJ had entered her ass. Had she been hesitant? All I could remember was the way she'd screamed for more—screamed, *Fuck my married ass*.

"Yeah, really."

"Some of the things that he said—"

"Were just things he said," Erin reassured. "What are you thinking, Tom?"

"I don't want to be humiliated," I said. The force behind my statement surprised me. I lowered my voice, looking around. "It's not an aspect of the game that I'm into."

Erin took my hands into hers. "I know, honey."

"But you do, don't you?" My own question sprang out of nowhere, a realization that knocked me off balance. "You get off on being humiliated."

Erin didn't answer immediately. Not verbally, anyway. Instead, her face went bright red. She glanced away, looking down at our hands. Her thumb brushed along my wedding band absent-mindedly.

"It's okay," I said softly. "Honestly, it's really..."

Erin looked up at me, searching my face.

I finished my thoughts, "It's really sexy. Wrong, but sexy."

She bit her lip. "Yeah. For me, too." Her face, incredibly, went even brighter. "I'm sorry."

"Why?"

"Because I shouldn't feel that way. It's not who I am," she said.

"But that's just it, right? It *is* who you are. Or one aspect of you."

"I..." She sighed. "You're right. And that really turns you on?"

"It does."

"So you liked watching him..."

"Fuck your ass?"

Erin averted her eyes and touched her neck.

"It was crazy. Like my own personal porn, starring a woman who looked like you, talked like you, but she sure didn't act like you."

"Oh, it was me alright. Trust me."

"Still sore?"

"I'm better. The flight wasn't the most pleasant thing. Had to soak in the tub a while." Erin seemed to relax, now that we'd finally started talking about the elephant in the

room. "When he started touching me...back there...I just went with it. I never...I never thought I'd want to try that."

"But with AJ, you did."

"AJ gets me to do a lot of things."

"Like visit strip clubs. Like get spanked."

"Yeah," Erin said. "We had ourselves tested."

I cocked my head at her. What was she talking about.

"For STDs. He does it regularly. He doesn't like condoms."

The bareback thing. So many crazy things had happened over the last day that I'd almost forgotten about that.

"So that's what the kids are doing these days?"

"Apparently." We stared at each other quietly, uncertain of where to take this conversation. "Are you mad?"

"No. If anything, it's somehow hotter this way."

Erin studied me quietly, like a puzzle she kept trying to solve. "I still don't understand what you're getting out of this, honestly."

I raked my hand through my hair. "I'm not sure, either. But...but I'm learning that sometimes, letting go is the best course of action."

"I've definitely learned that, too."

*

We got up Saturday ready to be a couple of childless tourists in New Orleans. I realized that I had no plans for what to do, or really what we *could* do. Between prepping for the trip and dealing emotionally with the Erin and AJ situation, I hadn't done any research into the city of Nola.

Luckily, Erin had. Quite extensively, in fact. She had a list of things to do, places to see, and the drive to experience it all.

We started with one of the most amazing breakfasts I've ever had at the Court of Two Sisters, a charming restaurant

set in a courtyard, complete with strung lights and a band. After that, we were a blur through the city. We took a streetcar ride down St. Charles, looking at all the gorgeous Victorian homes. We walked along Magazine Street, stopping to browse in the myriad of quirky shops. I thought of *Le Fraise* and how a boutique like that would be right at home here. We eventually made it back to the Quarter, meandering down to the French Market and along Frenchman Street.

Throughout it all, though, we ate. And drank. We had no plans, we didn't even bother checking the reviews of the small restaurants that we stopped in. We judged on charm alone, and New Orleans had more charm to offer than we could accept.

Best of all, we did it together, just me and Erin. No kids. No AJ. No responsibilities. For that one day, we were just a man and a woman in love, sharing an experience as a couple. We left our lives behind—the good and the stressful and the anxious. We explored and ate and drank in this new city together.

"We need to do this more often than...never," Erin said with a laugh as we left a hole in the wall bar that served the most amazing cocktails.

I slid my hand inside Erin's. "Yeah. It's been good."

She looked at me for a quiet moment. "More than good. It's been important."

"Yeah." Neither of us needed to elaborate. We just basked in the warmth of our shared buzz.

"So for dinner, I was thinking we find some place in the Quarter," Erin said. "I've got some great recommendations." She listed a few before she saw me grinning.

"What?" she asked.

"Nothing. It's just funny. I was starting to wonder if you'd somehow trained the foodie out of you." Not to mention that a guy like AJ seemed more like a burger joint guy than the fine dining sort.

She laughed. "Hardly. If anything, it means I can indulge even more. We just haven't had time."

"Sounds to me like you've had plenty of time to indulge these last few weeks." It was meant to sound nonchalant, but I heard the of accusation in my tone.

Erin chewed on the statement. I almost added something to soften it, but let it alone and left her to think. At last, she said, "I think we need a safe word."

"A what?"

"A safe word. A word that one of us can use that ends the game we're playing. That tells the other that things have gone too far."

"Why don't we just say, *Things have gone too far?*"

Erin smirked. "That works when we're talking like this, all calm and out of the moment. But when things get crazy..." She shrugged. "It's a better idea to have something that's not ambiguous."

"Okay, couldn't hurt." I still didn't understand, but had learned it best to go along with her. "So what should it be? Our safe word?"

"You pick," she said.

"Why? Because you think I'll be the one who'll be using it?"

She pressed her lips together and lifted her eyebrows, as if saying, *You said it, not me.*

"Fine," I said with a laugh. I looked around, spotting a storefront selling Mardi Gras masks. A particularly flamboyant one covered in peacock feathers reminded me of the sex party out of *Eyes Wide Shut*. "How about *peacock*."

Erin laughed. "Too close to...another word that I may use...in the moment."

"Ha! Fair enough. How about...*buttocks*."

Erin laughed even harder. "How about, *harder*," she suggested.

I squeezed her hand. "Okay, seriously." I thought. "*Magnanimous*."

Erin covered her mouth as she laughed more. "Should I read into that?"

"If you want to," I said.

"Nah. *Magnanimous* it is. Our safe word. But keep in mind one important thing—if you ever you use it, then all this ends. No more games. We go back to the way things were. Understand?"

I already knew that I'd never use it. "I understand."

She brightened. "Cool. Now let's go eat some more!"

*

We actually ended up swinging back by the hotel before dinner so we could shower and change. I half thought that Erin would invite me into the shower with her, but when she didn't, I figured it just meant more energy for later. I showered after her, thinking about this past day and how good it had been. I wasn't ready to give up our adventures with AJ—and I knew that Erin wasn't even close to that—but it made me happy to remember how good things had been before. We didn't need AJ. We'd always have each other.

When I exited the shower, I realized why Erin had made me go second. She was standing by her suitcase wearing nothing but a bra, thong, garter belt and stockings—all constructed of wicked red lace except the black hose.

"That's new," I said.

Erin finished fastening the lace-topped stockings to a garter. Bent over like that, her tits practically tumbled out of the low cut bra.

"You like it?" Erin smiled, knowing the answer.

"Stockings? Did you buy these for AJ?" The question made my stomach squirm. Erin wasn't a fan of stockings and had only worn them a handful of times. That she'd do it for AJ and not me triggered that anxious excitement in me.

Erin laughed. “No, this is just for you, husband.” She straightened to a stand, looking every bit the wet dream. “When I wore them for Aj a few weeks back, he complained that there was too much to take off.”

Erin pulled a red dress out of the closet. She wore tall heels, I noticed, and her stockings had seams up the back. So sexy.

“You going to get dressed?” she asked with a smirk.

I unfroze from where I stood in the bathroom door, pulling my towel off. I was already semi-erect.

Erin approached, her hips swinging. She reached out and touched my cock, which responded with a twitch. “You know, Aj would make me blow him right now.”

She raised an eyebrow before passing me, heading into the bathroom. I stood there, uncertain if that’s what she wanted me to do. The moment passed.

Erin did her makeup. I got dressed in a pair of slacks and a dark shirt. And out we went.

*

We talked about the city over dinner, continuing our unspoken pact to focus on us. We talked about our kids, and how much they would enjoy this place—parts of it, anyway. We talked about future trips, a cruise perhaps. We talked about Disney World and the Greek Isles and the Grand Canyon. I didn’t realize how much I missed these conversations until we’d stopped having them.

We settled our bill and wandered back toward the hotel. Erin pulled me into a little bar. “I’m not ready to call it a night,” she said with a smile. How could I resist?

And then I went to the bathroom, only to return to a now familiar sight—another man leaning into my wife, doing his best to woo her. Her red dress was racier than yesterday’s black one, but mostly because of the color and the fact that I knew what she wore beneath. I thought about the tiny,

white number I'd bought for her at *Le Fraise* with embarrassment. She was right, it wasn't her.

Erin laughed at whatever this guy said, the sound as powerful as music. He was good looking—they always seemed to be. This guy looked Persian, with a close-cropped beard and broad shoulders to match his tall frame. I could see what he did to Erin's confidence. She stood up straighter, she smiled wider, and when she looked at this handsome guy flirting with her, she looked at him with leverage, like she was the one in charge. And of course, she was.

She touched his arm, whispered something into his ear, and walked away. He followed her trajectory to me. For a moment, he looked confused, then surprised, then he left the bar with the shake of his head.

"I can't leave you for a second, can I?" I said.

Erin looked innocent. "He wanted to take me up to his room," she said. She straightened the lapel of my shirt before placing her hand over my heart. "Your heart is racing. It turns you on."

"Yes."

"The thought of me going back to a total stranger's room?"

Who was this minx? A moment ago, we were laughing about our kids. Was that the real Erin? Or was this? One thing I knew, one thing I could see in the way her eyelids drooped and her breath came short, was that she was turned on by it, too.

"You're two for two," I said. "Tonight and last night."

"It's the city," Erin said. There was the modest woman I knew, peeking out.

"It's not, and you know it." I looked around. The bar was small, but it was far from empty. More than a few guys were eyeing Erin up. "You can if you want to, you know." My chest squeezed in around me, but my offer was genuine.

Erin studied me. "You're not lying, are you?"

“No.”

The corners of her lips tugged up.

“Well, you know I’ve never been the kind of girl who went home with some stranger, right?”

That much was true. We’d talked about our love lives before meeting each other. Erin was a long-term relationship kind of girl, and she never slept with anyone on the first date.

“You’ve also done a lot of things that I wouldn’t have thought you’d ever do,” I said.

“I have, haven’t I?” She leaned into me, pressing her body to mine. “So you’d rather I go find someone else to fuck tonight?”

“No,” I said tightly.

“Good, because tonight, I’d really like to feel your cock...” She lifted her lips to my ear. “...in my ass.”

My breath caught.

“But AJ said... And you said—”

“What he wanted to hear. But Tom, baby, it felt so good. I *need* to share it with you.”

“Can we get out of here now?”

Erin pushed her glass of wine away. “I didn’t pay for this. There’s no bill to settle. Come on.”

*

I felt nervous and giddy and excited as we made our way back to the hotel, like the prom night I’d wished for back when I was a teenager. Even though I’d watched Erin do it live, I still couldn’t marry that woman with the one in the red dress, pulling me down the hall to our room.

Inside the room, though, things started lining up. Erin stripped out of her dress, but kept her red lingerie on as she went to her knees and blew me. Even when we made it to the bed and she straddled my cock, she only took her

panties off, leaving me to appreciate the garter belt, the bra, the silky caress of her stockings.

“So for the last couple days, you really thought that I’d do something for AJ that I wouldn’t do for you?” she asked as she rode me.

I hadn’t thought about it like that, but she was right. I’d just assumed that she’d honor AJ’s order, and more troubling was that I hadn’t been too upset about it.

“I wasn’t sure.”

“Interesting,” Erin said. “Maybe I should just keep it between me and AJ.”

When my cock swelled, it surprised the both of us. Erin looked down at me, wide-eyed. “Even more interesting...”

“Erin...”

She smiled, slipping out of my lap and slithering back down between my legs. Her eyes never left me. “Don’t worry, it felt too good to not do it with you.”

I groaned. Was she really talking about anal sex like that? She reached into her purse and removed a tube of KY Jelly.

“Yes, Tom. That’s right. I want to feel you in my ass. Yesterday, as I lay there, barely conscious after AJ fucked me back there, all I could think about was why didn’t I do this earlier. I was...” She laughed breathily. “I can’t even describe it. I just want more.”

I moaned as she coated my cock with the lubricant, jacking me off. “Oh, Erin...”

“You like this bad girl, don’t you?” She kissed the tip of my cock before crawling over me. “This isn’t me wearing stockings for you, Tom. I don’t want this out of guilt. I *want* this.”

She kissed me one last time before turning her back to me and slipping into a spoon. Taking my cock, she guided it against her pussy again. I pressed forward, dipping in and out. She was so wet. She really did want this.

Erin shifted, reaching out to guide me against her asshole. She twisted her torso so that she was on her back, looking at me as I pressed against her. Our eyes met. Hers were fiery with lust. "Go slow," she whispered. "At first."

I pushed, the tip of my cock entering her tight opening. She grimaced. Her eyes went soft.

"Am I hurting you?" I asked.

"Yes," she said tightly. "But it's good. Good..."

She pushed her hips back, encouraging me to enter her deeper. I did, slowly, feeling the ring of her anus like a vise around my shaft. She was so tight back there, and as good as that felt, the groans of pleasure she made were by far the hottest thing about the experience.

I entered her with short, gentle thrusts, each time pushing a little deeper, each thrust reflected on her face and the sharpness of her cries.

"That's good, that's so good," she whispered over and over, her eyes boring up at mine. I felt so close to her, so intimate. She touched herself, her free hand rubbing her pussy, adding to the mix.

I kissed her softly. Pulling back, I watched her again. Her eyes fluttered shut at last, the pain and pleasure becoming too much for her. Her lips parted and her body shook as she released a pent-up breath. I pushed deeper into her, slowly, ever so slowly.

I kissed her again, long and loving. She tried to return it, but her mind was scattered, her breath a hot wash. I kissed her jaw, her neck, and at last her breasts, burying deeper and deeper. I was close. So very close. Her face tightened, lines racing across her brow and at the corners of her eyes. A bead of sweat ran down her temple.

At last, my pubic hair pressed against the smooth skin of her buttocks. I was in to the hilt, my cock buried in her ass. Her eyes opened to meet mine again, sharp, deep, swimming. We didn't speak. We didn't need to. She gave the most subtle of nods, and I began to fuck her ass.

“That feels so good.”

I held her tightly against me, a hand cupping her face as she moved in and out of eye contact. She fingered herself faster as we built speed, her breathing growing shallow. Her body glistened with sweat. Her hair clung together in damp, dark strands.

“You like that?” I half asked, half stated.

“Mmm hmm. It feels so...full.”

I thought about how Aj had fucked her ass. How he pushed her face into the pillow and rammed her. Pulled her hair. Took her like a plaything. And how she screamed.

“Ooh, yes.” Erin’s moans were softer with me. More restrained? Filtered?

I rolled her onto her knees, taking hold of her hips. I thought about how he’d spanked her. How he’d grabbed her ass and squeezed. My fingers flexed to do the same, but I couldn’t bring myself to do it. But I did fuck her butt harder, now that she was used to the motion. She turned her head so she could breathe and reached between her legs with both hands, working her clit and cunt.

“Oh, yes, Tom,” she moaned, louder now. “Just like that. Just like that.”

Her voice broke, her body bowing down onto the mattress as she pressed her buttocks against my cock. The ring of her asshole tightened down on my shaft. She opened her mouth, silent at first, her entire face clenched.

Then the moan came on like a tsunami, flattening everything around me. Unable to restrain myself any longer, I exploded in her ass, filling her backside for the first time in our long history together.

Sweaty, I collapsed on top of her. We rolled into a spoon again, my cock softening inside of her, slipping out to rest in the crack of her butt cheeks. We didn’t speak. Not for a long time. I could feel her heart racing against my own. Our heavy breathing filled the void.

When I spoke at last, my throat was sore. Had I been shouting, too? “You really liked that, didn’t you?”

Erin cooed, snuggling back against me. “Yeah. Who would have thought?”

“Aj, apparently,” I said.

“Thank you, Aj,” she said with a sigh.

Our bodies cooled. Our breathing returned to normal. I pulled a sheet over us, but remained in place behind her naked body.

“Aj’s going to be pretty upset when he learns that we did this,” I said, trying to keep things light.

“He’s not going to know,” she said.

The irony wasn’t lost on me: that it was her lover’s back that we had to sneak around, not her husband’s. I thought about the things I’d heard her say over the Skype call. Like, *Don’t worry, he’s never asked for it, and he’ll never know.*

“Would you have told me if Aj didn’t make you? Told me about you and him?”

“Well, you *were* watching.”

“What if I wasn’t?” I insisted.

I hated that Erin was facing away from me. I wanted to be able to study her face, her reaction. “I would have told you.”

Were you thinking about me instead of your husband the last time you were with him?

Mmm, hmm...

My stomach churned.

“And the things you said to him? All of that was just... what? Things he wanted to hear? A way of pumping up his ego?”

Erin took longer to answer. “No, it was all real. Or...real in the moment.”

At last, she rolled onto her back. Her dark bangs stuck to her forehead. She brushed them away. “I warned you about this. Way back when this all started. It’s not as simple as a *yes* or a *no*. None of this is. When I’m with Aj, I’m really

with him. I want him. He blows my mind. I've said it before, but he really does turn me into someone I never thought I could be. But then, when it's over, I'm with you again."

"I'm sorry—"

"No, don't be like that, Tom. It's not like a regret thing. Or even a feeling of being settled. I don't want to ever feel settled with you. I'm learning more and more about myself, and I hope tonight proves that I want to share that part with you." Her chuckle gave way to a sigh. "But this is exactly why we need a safe word. When I'm with him, I get so caught up in it. In him. In being his. And sometimes, I say things—"

"That you mean."

"At the time."

"Like?" I asked.

"Like how his cock fills me like my husband can't."

"But it does, right?"

She ignored me. "And how I can't stop thinking about it. Or how I play with myself after you're in bed, thinking about the next time I can get together with AJ."

"You do?"

Erin laughed. "AJ thinks I do."

"So it's all an act?"

Erin shook her head. "See, you're back to trying to categorize it. It's an act, and it's not. I had anal sex with him. I let him take me to a strip club and made out with a stripper. I do things for him, I say things to him, and in the moment, I'm into it. But that doesn't mean I spend all my time thinking about him. Or that when you and I are together, I'm thinking about him."

I felt a great weight lift off my shoulders as she said it.

"Like just now, I wasn't thinking about AJ. Like, at all. I wasn't comparing, or wishing he were fucking me. I don't even know if I *could* compare. It was such a different experience."

“Yeah,” I said, remembering how much wilder she’d been with him.

She heard the concession in that one word. “Sometimes it amazes me how competitive you guys get,” she said, her laugh touched with exasperation. “It was different, and I *loved* that it was different. I love that with you, I’m going to be loved. I love that you worry about how I feel, how comfortable I am, how into it I am. That’s something I don’t think I’ll ever get from AJ. But I don’t want it from AJ, just like I don’t want what AJ does from you.”

“I don’t think I understand.”

Erin kissed me. “That’s okay, you don’t have to. Just remember that I love you, no matter what I may say or do. And definitely remember that safe word if you ever think we’ve gone too far.”

We’ve gone too far. I liked the sound of that.

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ELEVEN

The early numbers out of New Orleans were promising. What was even better was the total change in attitude coming from Brian Benoit. I'd expected an *I told you so attitude*. Instead, I got respect.

Erin fell back into her routine with AJ, which still caused butterflies whenever she was out, but I was now much more confident that it was just a fling—to both of them. AJ reassured me of that when I saw him at the next Wednesday training session.

"You still seeing...Erin?"

"Of course, man."

"It's been what? Almost a couple months since the race. Things getting serious?"

AJ laughed. "Well, I fucked her in the ass and she loved it. That's a pretty serious step."

My chest tightened. "You think she'd...leave her husband?"

"Oh, ha. If you're asking if we're going to run away together or something, that ain't happening. If they did break up, I wouldn't see myself as the cause. More the symptom, you know?"

That didn't sit well with me. "So you think they'll break up?"

"I don't know, man. I'm not a marriage counselor. But she is banging her personal trainer, and I know she's gone out with a guy from the gym. That takes a toll. Plus, her husband's kind of a controlling asshole."

I felt sucker-punched. "She told you that?"

"No, she didn't have to. But hey, I'm in it for the ride right now, and it's a fucking awesome ride."

And like that, all the insecurity was back. Was that what Erin thought of me when she was with AJ? That I was a

controlling asshole? It made me think about the way I'd been with Brian Benoit. I *had* been one with him. Was I only just realizing this now?

Only one person could answer this for me, of course, and I was so agitated that I diverted back home. Erin was standing in the front yard when I came home, talking to Haley, Dana, and a few of the other neighborhood moms. It was cool enough in mid-October that the sweaters and fleece vests had come out, but they still all looked great.

As I got out of the car, they turned to look at me, and I got the distinct impression that I was disturbing a bunch of wild animals in their natural habitat.

"Tom, you're home early!" Erin said, a laugh in her response.

"Yeah." I glanced at the others. I wasn't going to confront her in front of them. "I remembered a few things I forgot to grab."

Erin nodded, although she must have sensed something because she waved goodbye to the others and followed me inside.

"So what's up, Tom?" She sidled up to me, proving just how good a white turtleneck sweater could look. "Home for a little morning play time?"

We hadn't had morning sex in a long time, and for a frazzled moment, I almost forgot why I was here. Then I remembered with a sour taste in my mouth.

"Did you tell AJ that I was an asshole?"

Erin frowned, putting enough space between us that she could look up at me. "What?"

"He's under the impression that I'm an asshole. That I'm controlling. Why?"

"I have no idea, Tom. We don't talk about you. Like, at all." I'd expected defensiveness, but instead, she seemed almost...amused. "But does it even matter what he may or may not think about my 'husband'? That guy he thinks he knows isn't you."

“It matters what you think of me—” I began.

“And I don’t think of you as an asshole. Or controlling. Think about it, Tom. Think about it rationally. Why would I ever suggest that you were controlling? You’ve given me permission to have affairs with other men.” She closed the gap between us again, putting her arms around me. “You’ve given me permission to *cheat* on you.”

I groaned. Erin brushed her hand across the seat of my pants. She said, “And I have. And I love it.”

She slipped her hand inside of mine and pulled me toward the bedroom. “Come on, let’s take advantage of having the house to ourselves...”

*

The morning sex helped me get through the rest of the day—and even for the week—but AJ’s words lasted. Maybe Erin hadn’t told him that I was a controlling asshole, but he’d arrived at that conclusion somehow. What had Erin done to make him think that, even on a subconscious level? Was I, after all, controlling?

I spent the next few weeks watching myself and my actions closely. I gave Brian Benoit the freedom he wanted and he was happy because of it. I gave Erin her freedom, too, going out of my way not to question her about her day and her outings, unless she volunteered information.

Not that she withheld anything. She’d always come home after a night with AJ raring to go, and full of stories about how good he felt. She’d fill me in on how she flirted with some guys at the supermarket or at the gym. She told me about a massage she had and how strong her masseur’s hands felt all over her. She knew how to press my buttons, and while it always made me uncomfortable, it always led to explosive sex.

She went on a couple other dates—just drinks with other guys—but they didn’t lead anywhere. No one connected

with her like AJ did, but she was ready for someone else. We were primed for something new.

And then her 34th birthday rolled around.

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TWELVE

Erin and Lucas Hughes shared birthdays: October 24. Erin was turning thirty-four, while Lucas was celebrating the big four-oh. In the past, we usually celebrated the joint birthday as a group—the Hughes, Marcie and George, Kelly and Dana from the Moms' Group, along with their husbands, Norm and Dave. They were always fun, but since we were responsible adults with children at home, these celebrations were basically just extended happy hours that ended with us stumbling home around nine.

This year, though, the plan was much more extravagant. Lucas—or more likely Haley—had planned a full night for us all. We'd start off with a dinner at Trellis downtown, then dancing downtown late into the night. Apparently Lucas had pulled some strings and gotten us on the list for some new club that catered to our age range.

"It's not...that club, right?" I'd asked when Erin had filled me in on the plans. "The swinger one?"

Erin laughed. "No. This one's strictly bump-and-grind."

She'd also booked us a room at a boutique hotel downtown, so we wouldn't have to even worry about getting home when it was time.

Despite my general dislike of Lucas Hughes, I was excited. I liked the rest of the group, and this was a rare opportunity to hang out with them all without much responsibility. Going out to dinner without the kids was an incredibly rare thing. Going out with the kids staying at the grandparents' house had only ever been exercised for our anniversary in the past.

I dropped the kids off at my parents' house with all their overnight stuff. It was nice to see my mom and dad light up to see their grandkids. I wondered how they were going to

feel tomorrow when we picked them up after no one got much sleep.

Erin spent the time while I was out getting ready, and by the time I got home, she was making her way down the stairs in her evening splendor. I think I stopped breathing as soon as I saw her.

“How do you like my dress?” she asked.

“You kept it.” The dress was the white one I’d purchased at *Le Fraise*—the dress that I thought she’d rejected because it had been so scandalous—so not Erin. It was definitely still scandalous, and a lot shorter than I remembered.

“Very observant, Tom.”

Gliding off the stairs in the leopard print heels that I’d also purchased, her hair up off her neck and shoulders, and so much of her legs laid bare, she looked taller and more graceful than the woman who’d kissed our children goodbye. And way hotter.

“Damn, you look...” I couldn’t settle on a word, so I just trailed off.

Erin smirked. “Think the birthday boy will approve?”

Her question drove a spike of jealousy through me. I searched her face. Was she messing with me? Her expression was amused, but inconclusive.

I said, “Lucas? I’m sure he will, but why do you care?”

Erin shrugged, but her expression remained the same. “He’s a good looking guy.”

“He’s an asshole.”

“And that presses some buttons,” she said. She finished her descent down the stairs.

“What are you saying? That you want to fuck Lucas Hughes?” Unbidden, I imagined the two of them together... and my heart picked up a notch.

“That really is a nerve, isn’t it?”

“I don’t like that man.”

Erin said, "It's not like I'm asking if *you* want to fuck him."

Here's where AJ's words insinuated themselves into my confidence. Here was a situation where I could relinquish control, to fully pass it over to Erin. It had worked with New Orleans, and if I was completely honest with myself, Lucas Hughes *was* a button for me. I hated him, I hated that it turned me on, but this wouldn't have been the first time that I'd gotten excited at the two of them together.

"So Lucas? Really?"

She floated by me, collecting her clutch purse by the door. I'd almost forgotten how little the dress covered—how the back opened up but for the criss-cross of those dainty straps and it was impossible to wear a bra.

"Well, we do know that they'd be open to something like that," she said over her shoulder.

"I still don't trust the guy."

"But you trust me, right?"

"Always."

Her heels clicked along our hardwood floor as she stepped up to me. Her perfume was light and sensual. She tugged at my tie, cinching it back into place. My collar burned. "And you trust me enough not to say anything if I invited Lucas back to our hotel room at the end of the night?"

I swallowed. My throat was dry. "If that's what you want to do."

"*Want*. It's a funny thing, isn't it? Do I *want* to invite Lucas into our bed? To let him take this teeny tiny dress off me? To feel his lips on my breasts? His cock..." Her eyes had been on my mouth, but at the word *cock*, she bit her lip and looked right at me. "...his cock sinking into me? Yes, I do. But here's the thing." She placed her hand against the seat of my pants, finding me hard. "So do you."

"It's a little fucked up."

Erin smiled. "I think that your little rivalry's going to make it even hotter for you. It will for me."

Was that true? It almost sounded right, but my mind was too busy spinning round and round. So I seized onto the first question I could. "Does Haley know about this little plan?"

"There's no plan. Just a possibility." Erin leaned close to me, her body soft and warm, even through my clothes. I could tell she wasn't wearing a bra, although I wasn't sure that she could have under that dress. "And isn't the anticipation thrilling?"

With that, she stepped away and turned to the door. I was drawn to her ass, barely covered and so perfect looking. I could make out the faint outline of a thong, white like the dress. In certain light, that was going to be very obvious.

"Ready?"

I wasn't sure that I was, but I nodded anyway.

*

We met the group at Trellis after checking in at The Crimson. They were all waiting for us at the bar, and drinks had already been poured for the birthday girl.

Everyone was dressed to the nines, so much so that I barely recognized them. I was used to seeing this crew with kids around, dressed like the upper middle class parents that we were. Instead, all the women wore sexy little cocktail dresses, and all the guys looked like they'd just come from a Hollywood premiere.

I actually felt the most overdressed in a dark suit and tie, my crisp white shirt French cuffed, my tie narrow and electric blue. By contrast, Lucas wore a shimmering, European cut suit over his tall frame, no tie and a bright red shirt beneath. This is how I imagined the rich did casual. I took note.

It was Haley that really drew my eye. I'd always seen Erin's mom's club friend in the trappings of domesticity, and while she always looked good in a snug pair of jeans or a loose sun dress, I'd never seen her dressed to party. While not quite as short as Erin's, Haley's strapless black dress looked painted on her slender curves. I no longer needed to imagine what her naked silhouette looked like.

Marcie, Kelly, and Dana looked great as well, particularly Dana, although with her dark hair, light eyes, and petite frame, her resemblance to Erin probably had something to do with it.

"There they are," Lucas said, going to Erin first. He took her hands in his and made a show of looking her up and down. "Wow. That training program has turned you into a goddess."

The other women in the group nodded and said the same, and while none of the other guys went there, they certainly took a moment to scope out her body in that dress.

"Thanks. It certainly was harder than I thought it would be." She glanced at me. "But so worth it."

We mingled. Drinks flowed. Haley came up to me, kissing me on the cheeks. With more makeup on than I was used to, she looked glamorous.

"You look incredible, too," I whispered, my compliment more for Haley than the group.

"Thanks. So do you. I like the tie." When she touched it, it felt intimate. I wondered once again how far this night was going to go.

"I feel like it's too much. I was about to take it off, actually."

"Don't. Leave it on. I think you wear it well."

That made me feel all warm inside. "Thanks."

"Your table is ready," the maître'd said. He lead us to a private section of the restaurant, where we could be as loud as we wanted.

And we were loud. The never ending stream of wine helped with that, but so did the lack of children to worry about. I could tell how ready this gang was to throw down and have a good, grownup time. Bad analogy, but it was kind of like that first week at college. We couldn't believe the freedom we suddenly had.

Like most gatherings with Lucas, our brash, handsome neighbor monopolized the group with his stories. Erin always loved his gossip, but she seemed to hang on his words more than ever tonight. I didn't miss the way she held his eyes with her own, the way she touched her neck or batted her lashes. Three months ago, I would have pulled her aside and had a talk with her. Now, I was as hard as ever, my heart racing as quickly as it had when I'd watched Erin drive off to Annapolis. She was right, this was definitely a button for me.

She wasn't alone, either. Lucas had charisma, particularly with women, and had the group hooked. I studied the other guys, wondering if they harbored the same jealousy that I did. Most of them laughed and listened along with their wives. Interestingly, Dana's husband, Dave, watched the man with quiet curiosity—particularly when Lucas spoke to Dana.

I filed it away—or intended to—before the wine washed it to oblivion.

For my own part, I remained more on the outskirts, listening and observing as I tried puzzling out my emotions. How could I feel so insecure around Lucas, so certain that I couldn't trust him, yet so ready for him to do forbidden things with my wife?

I watched as Erin laughed at some sordid tale about a Congressman's wife—watched the way she twisted a loose strand of dark hair around her finger. She seemed to sense me looking, flicking a look at me for an instant. It was as reassuring as a squeeze of my knee.

This was just more of the game, I realized. Lucas was another tool in Erin's bag of tricks, a way to wind me up. She had our best interests in mind. This wasn't just for her pleasure or mine. This was for the two of us.

At some point, we moved from dinner to the exclusive little basement club a couple blocks away. Haley fell into step beside me while Erin and her friends moved ahead. Lucas was among them.

"They look pretty good together, don't they?" Haley said, quiet enough that it was just for me.

Something uncomfortable shifted inside of me. How much did she know? Jo had figured out our game. Had Haley? I looked up at Erin and Lucas, talking animatedly with one another. Even in her heels, Lucas towered over her.

"Yeah, they do," I said. "Does that make you jealous, at all?"

"A little, sure. But I'll confess something—only because I'm a little tipsy." She leaned into me. "It's kind of hot, too, don't you think?"

"Uh...how do you mean?"

"You know, Erin's a beautiful woman. Isn't it awesome that she can still turn heads? It's the same with Lucas." We walked on for a few, quiet minutes. For a second, I thought we were past the conversation. Then, Haley said, "Erin told you about us, right?"

It suddenly grew warm under my coat. There was no point in denying it, though. "She mentioned something. You and Lucas are...what? Swingers?"

Haley blushed, leaning into me and clinging to my arm. "You make it sound like such a bad thing!"

"I'm sorry. It's just...different," I said. But was it? I didn't even know how to have this conversation. I felt off-balance. "How long has it...?"

"A couple years. Martin was still a baby. Our sex life had slowed down. So we had a serious talk about...things. We talked about Lucas's first wife and how that had dissolved.

He hadn't cheated on her, but he felt trapped by it. This seemed like the best solution."

"So you what? Have an open marriage?"

"Yes, pretty much." And just like that, she dispelled all my disparaging opinion of the lifestyle. Her eyes lit up. "Besides, it's such a turn-on to watch him rocking someone else's world and knowing that he's mine."

"What are you guys talking about?" Dana asked, dropping back.

I went hot with embarrassment. What had she heard?

Haley spoke for us. "Just how awesome it is to be out without the kids." She lied convincingly.

"I know, right?" Dana said.

It was a reminder that even with the alcohol, we needed to be careful. Talking to Haley was easy, but this fragile illusion of normalcy that Erin and I maintained could so easily fall apart if the wrong thing was said.

"Here we go," I said. "Wow, that's a line."

We arrived at the club a moment later. Lucas led us past the long line to the bouncers in front. By the time we caught up, the bouncer was already pulling the velvet rope aside and letting us in.

*

Maestro was small, but was just about perfect for what we were looking for. The clientele was all about our age. The DJ played hits that we could sing to just as well as we could dance. Thanks to stingy door enforcement, it was crowded enough to get lost in without being overwhelming. And while the drinks were expensive, they weren't strong enough that they snuck up on you.

We mostly stuck together as a group, dancing, drinking, and talking in big circles. A few couples did break off from time to time. Erin was always in the thick of things. She

danced with several guys, including me, but only one of them made my pulse rise.

I watched Lucas take Erin out on the dance floor. They looked good together. Like a couple. Him with his light hair, her with her dark. I'd never realized quite how large Lucas was until I saw him envelope Erin on the dance floor. Aj was large in a fit, toned kind of way, but Lucas was probably around 6'4".

My stomach tightened as Lucas whispered something in Erin's ear, and Erin smiled at whatever it was. His hand sat low on her hip, low enough to let his thumb stroke the band of her thong.

"Interesting view," Haley said beside me.

I jumped, caught red handed. "They've always been flirty with each other."

Haley said, "They have. How do you feel about that?"

"I..." I didn't know how to answer that.

Haley giggled. "Well, it's always turned me on."

Erin laughed at whatever the grinning Lucas said. She spun away. He pulled her close, her back now to him, her smile peeking over her shoulder like a sunrise. Their closeness filled me with an intense tangle of emotion.

"They want each other, you know," she said. "I think they have for a long time." She looked at me, a soft blush in her pale cheeks. "It turns you on, doesn't it?"

"How do you..."

"How do I know?" She giggled again. "I can just tell. I can see the same feelings in you that I feel. You like to watch, and those two are fun to watch."

Haley wandered off, leaving with the turmoil of my thoughts.

The crowd ebbed and flowed around us. People got their drinks. Went to dance. I let myself be pulled along with it, heedless of where the night would take me. I got lost in the music, the drink, the energy of everything.

Our friends left in pairs, giving Erin and Lucas their well wishes. I hugged them, told them that I'd see them later, and worried over whether I'd said too much. The night kept hurling faster and faster, reckless and exhilarating, set on a course of wild inevitability.

"So how're you doing?" Haley asked as I watched Erin with Lucas at the bar. He was issuing what looked like a challenge, and Erin appeared happily indignant. I felt queasy. I felt aroused. I felt—

"Good. I'm good."

Haley stepped in front of me, blocking the view. "Really? Because I've done this a few times already, and even I'm not good. I feel like my insides are trying to scramble out."

"Done...what?"

Haley sighed. "Tom, we all know where this evening is going, right?"

"Did you all set this up?" My anger began to rise. If they'd planned this—

"No, no set up. It's not like that. But let's be honest, it's been headed here for a long time." Haley stepped closer. "So just go with it. It'll be wild, I promise. Watching your spouse with someone else is...I can't even describe it."

"I think I can imagine," I said flatly.

Haley looked at me, confused, but before she could answer, Erin came up behind her, with Lucas in tow.

"Hey, Tom," Erin said. "Lucas invited us up to see their honeymoon suite. Maybe have one final drink."

Moment of truth. Erin was more than a little buzzed, but she stared up at me with very sober eyes. They asked the question. Are you ready for this?

The sound around me went hallow, like I was watching it from the far end of a long hallway. My mouth went dry. My heartbeat drowned out even the music. And then, in an instant, I blinked, it snapped back. I drew a breath and smiled.

"Okay. Lead on."

*

We left coupled up with each other's spouse. The nervous buzz of wrongness was still there, but I felt better because I had Haley to commiserate with.

The walk to the hotel was about ten minutes, but we hailed a cab anyway. We were all anxious to get on with the next part of the night.

Haley took the front seat. Erin rode between me and Lucas, and for a moment, I thought she'd just start making out with him beside me. It made me sick to my stomach—yet also painfully aroused.

Instead, though, she turned to me and smiled. She was happy-tipsy—sober enough to know precisely what she was doing. “Hi.”

“Hi.”

Volumes were exchanged in those two words. She was still mine. She was still with me, even when she wasn't. We were still good.

I don't think I'd ever felt as nervous in my life as I did on that elevator ride up to the top floor of the hotel. Erin going off to meet up with AJ certainly had trained me for this moment, but this felt different. Lucas Hughes wasn't some boy-toy that Erin could throw away. He wasn't a sex-addled jock looking purely for pussy. I didn't like him, Erin knew it, and that made this moment so much more intense.

Lucas led us down the long hallway to his room, with Erin striding at his side. We followed, her entourage, as they escorted us into decadence.

Lucas unlocked the door with a card. It beeped three times in rapid succession before turning green. The door swung inward. I felt the pull of that empty space. What came next was inescapable.

Lucas switched the lights on low. Erin turned to me. “Tom, honey, turn on some music, would you? Haley, help me with the glasses?”

It was clear who was in control here. It made me nervous, but for the birthday girl, I suppressed it.

Lucas's suite was huge, larger than the room we'd booked by far—probably larger than the first apartment we lived in together, back in our twenties. It had a full kitchen to one side, a large sitting area staged in front of an 80 inch television, and double doors that hinted at a bedroom that was just as expansive.

Erin and Haley moved off to the kitchenette. I went to the entertainment center, searching for the correct wire to hook up my iPhone. Lucas threw himself into the sofa, his arm draped over the back of his chair.

"Nice rooms," I said, looking around.

"Only turn forty once," Lucas said. "I decided to treat myself tonight."

I followed his eyes to Erin, standing on the opposite side of the room, tearing the foil off of a bottle of champagne. Jealousy clawed up the inside of my chest.

He said, "She looks amazing in that dress."

In that short dress and tall heels, she certainly did. Her bare legs were lean and glossy, toned from hours of running. Her dark hair cascaded around her in loose, shimmering waves.

"She does."

"I heard you bought it for her. I should thank you for that." Notably, he didn't actually thank me for that.

I found the audio-in station and the sexy, Latin beat of the Gipsy Kings filtered through the suite.

"You can thank her for wearing it," I said.

A loud pop was followed by laughter from the other room. Erin and Haley walked over, Erin with the bottle, frothing with champagne, Haley with all the glasses.

"I may have spilled some," Erin said, her laugh still in her voice. She handed it to me. "Here, you pour."

I did, pouring the bubbly into the flutes Haley held out. She handed Lucas the first as Erin stepped to his side.

“To a night of four adults and no responsibilities,” Lucas toasted once we all had glasses.

We all drank to that. Erin said, “I feel like I’m in college again.”

“I bet you were a fun girl back then,” Lucas said.

“And you don’t think I’m a fun girl now?”

“Well, I didn’t say that. But I’d like to see you prove it.”

“Of course you would.” Erin glanced at Haley, considered her options for a moment, then handed her glass of champagne to Lucas. She stepped up to the blonde, placing her arms around Haley’s neck. “How’s this?” Erin said.

I couldn’t quite comprehend what was happening. Not when Haley smiled back at Erin. Not when Haley’s hands came to rest on Erin’s hips, still holding her champagne. Not even when Erin leaned her head in, eyes closing, lips parting.

One moment we’d been toasting to the night ahead of us. The next, Erin was kissing another woman, her tongue pushing past Haley’s glossy lips. This wasn’t a friendly kiss between friends. It was a full-on, girl-on-girl French kiss.

Erin broke it after what felt like an age, smiling as she looked at the stunned expressions on our faces. “Believe me now?”

Lucas nodded in approval. “You kissed a lot of girls back in the day?”

“Let’s just say that Haley’s not my first,” Erin said.

I thought about her visit to the strip club. Had that been her first? Not that I had much time to dwell. Not as Erin moved over to Lucas, who had his hands full with both glasses, wrapped her arms around his neck, and drew him in for a long, deep kiss.

Erin’s kiss with Haley had been hot. Watching her kiss Lucas with so much passion was nuclear. Every atom in my body wanted to split in two. The urge to knock this other man off my wife was overwhelming.

Haley, standing opposite me, met my eyes with the same conflicted emotion I felt. Her hands were laced into a ball, clutched against her breast. Lines had formed on her forehead. She bit her lip, riveted.

Erin broke the kiss and pulled back enough to retrieve her champagne. Lucas finished his champagne in one mighty pull and set it down. Erin watched him, unwavering, getting off on the attention.

"I've been wanting to do something all night," he said.

"Oh yeah? Something inappropriate?"

"You tell me." He reached behind her neck, where her dress was tied, and pulled. The little white dress went slack, and with a tug, it slithered down her body. She was naked but for her thong and heels.

Lucas stepped back, looking over her bared breasts and flat stomach. Again, I felt the possessive draw to intervene. To shut this down. But this was Erin's night, as much as mine, and Erin preened under the attention.

"As good as you imagined?" she asked.

"You know you're hot," Lucas said. "Let's see the rest."

I flinched, expecting Erin to meet him with sass. I was shocked when she shot him a mischievous smile, hooked her thumbs in her thong, and pushed it down.

Lucas reached out, running his fingers across her pussy. She gasped as he brushed her clit and explored the bare rise where once she had hair. Lucas's grin widened. "Very nice. Bald, like the slut you are."

I cringed at the word. A) calling her a slut was one thing. Coming from Lucas felt so much more wrong.

She was wet. Even in the low light, I could see how she glistened. Lucas rubbed his fingers through the moisture, then brought them up to her lips. Erin opened her mouth automatically, sucking on his fingers. Tasting herself.

"You like sucking things, don't you?" He didn't need to say anything else. She took the hint, sinking to her knees and going to work on his belt and zipper.

Somehow, Erin pulled the action off without looking submissive. She was on her knees, she was staring up at him, she was drawing his pants down his muscled thighs, but we all knew who was serving who.

He was large, although he wasn't gigantic, like AJ, just a large cock for a large man. She wrapped her hand around it, her fingers just barely touching, and gave it a few confident strokes. She kept looking at him, challenge in that expression.

"Do it. Suck it."

Lucas was ordering, but Erin was the one in control. She paused for one dramatic beat, as if to say, *On my time, baby*. Then leaned in and ran her tongue up the side of his shaft.

"Like that?" Erin asked, all sweet and innocent. "Or is this more like what you were thinking?"

She closed her mouth over his shaft, swallowing him with more aggression than she normally showed for blowjobs. That aggression didn't cease with the initial suck, either. She took him hard, filling the room with the slurpy sounds of her wet blow. That sound was almost as hot as watching what she was doing, teasing and tormenting me with each throaty smack. She used both hands to twist and jerk what she couldn't take into her mouth.

I touched myself through my pants, unable to help it. I'd received countless blowjobs from Erin over the years, but watching her administer this one to another man just a few feet away was probably the most intense.

Lucas ran his hands through her hair, guiding her faster, deeper. Erin hated it when I did that, but she didn't protest now. If anything, she met the challenge like gusto. She took her hands off his dick completely, bracing herself on his buttocks as he fucked her face, her mouth, her throat. The harder he fucked her, the more enthusiastic she got, until at last he couldn't seem to take it.

"Jesus Christ, babe, I'm—fuck!"

Like a reflex, Erin pulled back until she held just the crown between her lips. Lucas thrust forward, eyes closed, face twisted in a grimace, and exploded inside her mouth. She took it, nostrils flaring to breathe as she drank his come. She sucked him until he had nothing left to give—until she'd swallowed every drop.

"You're not a one-and-done kind of guy, are you, Lucas? I sure hope not." Erin rose, giving the other man's softening cock a squeeze before padding over to me. She reached out and offered my hand. "Let's check out the bed. Entertain me while we wait for him?"

I should have felt emasculated. After all, she was reducing me to a fluffer role in this reality-meets-porn scenario. But the truth was, I loved that that's the role I had. It was Lucas who'd been written off, a guy who couldn't keep up with Erin's sexual appetite.

We moved into the bedroom, where the large king-sized bed waited. She sank back into the mountain of pillows and opened her legs for me. I drank in the intoxicating sight of her pussy. She was soaking. For him. For the promise of Lucas's cock sinking into those pristine lips.

She hooked my head with a leg and pulled me against her cunt. I fell into my role—the one I'd trained for all these months. I knew every nuance of her sex. I knew every fold, every nerve ending, every trick there was to drive her to the edge of release, then hold her there.

"Yes," she gasped, squirming at my touch. I listened to her breathing, and dialed back my onslaught, working the edges of her clit without touching it directly. I introduced my fingers, starting with two, then quickly building to three. She writhed as I stroked her g-spot, timing the rubs with glances along her button.

"Oh, baby, yes..." She sounded so content. So happy in that moment. I could have remained between her legs forever.

Then she gently pushed me away and the meaning of her words changed. I looked up at her, but she wasn't looking at me. Her focus was behind me. On someone else. On something else.

"That all for me?" she asked.

Lucas's voice was like gravel. "Hope you're ready for it."

Erin patted my shoulder. I felt the sting of the dismissal long enough to look up at her. Our eyes met, briefly, and I realized something—something that would have burned Lucas up if he did. She was using him to get me off as much as herself. I thought of that thing that Jo had said so long ago. *She loves what this does to you.*

It was easier to slouch away with that in mind—easier to yield my wife's sexuality to another man.

Haley was folded in an armchair in the corner, her black dress gone. She still had a strapless bra covering her perky tits, as well as her matching thong, but it nearly distracted me from the main event on the sofa. I moved to the far side of the bed, an ocean between me and Erin, yet I was close enough that I could see everything.

Lucas had stripped completely naked, his tall build more lean than AJ's. With broad shoulders and a narrow waist, I could understand why Erin was attracted to him—begrudgingly—and probably why Haley had married him. But it only served to make me hate him more.

He placed a knee on the sofa's edge, his cock jutting out and away. He kissed her first, causing my gut to churn with jealousy. Erin found his hard-on, squeezing it, pulling it closer.

"You're clean, right?" she said.

"Just got checked out last week."

I don't think I took a breath. Pink-pricks assaulted my scalp, edging in around the corners of my vision. My quick gasps couldn't fill my lungs fast enough.

Erin looked to Haley for confirmation. The blonde gave a short nod.

“What, you don’t believe me?” Lucas demanded.

“Not really,” Erin said.

“You’re such a bitch.” Lucas buried himself inside her with one solid lunge, sinking down to his balls.

“Oh, fuck!” Erin groaned.

I could see everything. Every little detail. I saw her pussy stretch around him. Saw the way his dick glistened with her juices. Saw the way her tits bounced with each hard thrust. I saw the effect Lucas had on my wife—the way she moaned for him, cried out for him, came for him within less than a minute. She was wild for his strange cock.

“Fuck me, fuck me, fuck me!” Erin rode out her first orgasm by screaming that order until she was hoarse, and Lucas took her up on the challenge. He drove into her relentlessly, working up a film of sweat. She splayed her legs as wide as they went, accepting his cock, arching her back along the reclined cushions of our sofa.

As her orgasm subsided, so did Lucas’s fucking. Breathing heavily, he melted into her, kissing her neck and behind her ears. Erin wrapped her legs around his back. She still wore those heels, spiked and leopard print. The great cat still had claws.

“That’s not all you’ve got, is it?” Erin said, her voice thick. “Am I going to have to get Tom over here to show me what a real man can do?”

My ego swelled. Lucas’s bruised, and he intended to prove to her otherwise.

“Just letting you rest, babe, but if you don’t need that...” He pulled free, flipped her over, and yanked her hips off the sofa edge. “I’ll show you what deep feels like.”

With that, he rammed into her from behind, drawing a satisfied moan from Erin.

This was different than the tender moments that Erin and I shared. Or even the raw physicality I’d witnessed between my wife and Aj. This was sport fucking, each trying

to outperform the other, and Erin was more than up for the challenge.

“Yeah, like that!” she commanded. Reaching between her legs, she fondled Lucas’s balls, stroking their combined fluids over the swinging sac. She’d never done that with me—another trick learned from her personal trainer?

Lucas took the gloves off, too. He’d already come once. He was in it to last. He squeezed her ass, slapping it. Eliciting an approving squeal.

“Take it. Take it, you slut! Tell me you want it!”

Erin squeezed out the retort, strained yet still with a bite. “I want you to stop talking and fuck me.”

I was so hard. So ready to pull out and touch myself. Modesty, as irrational as that was, prevented me. I clung to it, like if I could keep my pants on, I could pretend I wasn’t the pervert getting off on this. Buzzing from this. Buzzing so strong it was a hum on my ears.

Hum. Buzz. I looked across at Haley and realized that the sound wasn’t imagined. Her bra was gone, her sexy little breasts as pale and delicate as the rest of her. She still wore her panties, but she’d pulled them aside to run a tiny, silver vibrator across her clit.

That was all the encouragement I needed. I pulled off my shirt, realizing how sweaty the display had made me. My pants came next, the clink of my belt lost on Erin and Lucas, but not Haley. She looked at me, then at my cock.

I could have gone to her. Could have so easily replaced her hand and vibrator with myself. But that wasn’t the way it was between me and Erin. Twisted, I knew. After all, Erin was busy getting fucked by a man I was gradually coming to view as my nemesis, and I couldn’t fuck his very willing wife.

Thing was, no part of me resented it. Fucking Haley would have been fun, but the crazy game that my wife and I had was ten times as exciting.

“Harder, Lucas! Fuck me harder!”

Erin's cry cleared out my thoughts and refocused me on the couple on the couch. Lucas was still fucking her doggy-style, his hand clutching her ass cheek, red from his spanking. With his free hand, he grabbed a fistful of dark hair and pulled back, drawing a scream.

I tensed, ready to intervene before I realized that Erin was coming again.

"You like it rough, don't you? You like being treated like a dirty slut?"

He drew out of her, once again flipping her onto her back. She'd barely recovered from her orgasm when he grabbed her by the back of neck and guided her mouth onto his cock. It glistened with her own excitement, but that didn't seem to put her off. She dove onto the rigid column, sucking with enthusiasm.

"Fuck, you're good at that. You're going to have to teach Hails how to deep throat. Ah!"

He was right. She had him in her throat. She'd never done that with me. She'd come close, but I wasn't large enough to completely necessitate it. Watching her now, though, she had Lucas all the way down to his trimmed pubes and his cock firmly lodged in her throat.

Erin bobbed her head in short, rapid strokes, holding him against her with one hand on his ass. The other drifted down between her legs, where she circled and slapped her clit harder than I'd feel comfortable.

It was so lewd. So fucking obscene. She was a slut—a slut for Lucas and his towering manhood.

Erin drew away from Lucas, catching her breath. "Does that make you feel like a man? Feeling it in my throat?"

Her question landed like a lash. Lucas bristled.

"You know I'm a man, baby. You're going to be craving this cock, won't you? You're always welcome to come on over whenever you need a fix."

Erin leaned back, pulling on his cock. Her eyes never left his, even as she set him once again against her pussy.

“More like the other way around. And Lucas...” She shifted her hips upward, welcoming him back into her without resistance. “The next time you want a piece of me, you’re going to have to beg.”

“We’ll see about that.” He lifted Erin’s legs over his shoulders, folding her in half as he pounded her.

I watched her face as he took her. The competitive spirit raging through her wanted to deny the pleasure Lucas was giving her, but she couldn’t help herself. She arched up into him, linking her ankles behind his head and let herself get fucked.

“Fuck me, you asshole!” she cried. “Harder! Harder!”

She clutched the pillows, dislodging them from beneath them. Lucas was red-faced and panting. He was close. Close to coming inside my wife.

I watched it all go down, my own dick in hand, pumping enough to keep me at the edge of my orgasm. I hated how turned on I was. Hated how into the sex Erin was—how into it that I was.

“Take it! Take it, you slut!” Lucas shouted.

“Shut up and come already!”

That’s when I realized that he’d never put a condom on. That he was fucking her bareback and unprotected. My stomach squeezed.

Lucas bellowed something angry and unintelligible. He crashed one last time into her, teeth grinding, body tensing as he unloaded his sperm into my wife’s pussy.

It was like being struck by lightning. All synapses seized. I don’t know how I didn’t come, but somehow I didn’t. I weathered the intensity of the moment, white hot and sizzling as it was. Erin didn’t. She came with Lucas, screaming loud enough that I wondered if someone would complain to the hotel. Screaming for another man’s cock.

Lucas withdrew from her, looming large over her sweaty body, his dick still semi-engorged and swinging wetly. He was haggard and heaving, yet satisfied. Erin slumped back

into the pillow, satisfied, and slowly opened her eyes. They were full of challenge.

“That all you have for me?”

I smiled to myself. She’d won this round. Lucas couldn’t go another round even if he wanted to—and he definitely looked like he wanted to, even if just to spar with my wife again.

Instead, he turned to me. “You think Tom’s hungry for a creampie?”

I tensed, my fists clenching as the rage inside me finally boiled over, but before I could say anything, I caught movement out of the corner of my eye. When I refocused, my eyes shot open. Haley was out of the armchair, finally completely naked.

She was gorgeous. Daintier than Erin, with slimmer hips and smaller breasts. Her skin was pale, her smile as quiet as her personality, and her blues eyes alive and horny. She had a narrow landing strip of dark blond hair, the same shade as her eyebrows, and an outie pussy like a blossoming flower.

She moved with enough sway in her slim hips to mesmerize all three of us, placing a hand on Lucas’s shoulder. “I don’t think Tom’s into that, but you know I am.”

Lucas grinned. The tension in the air lingered for about a microsecond. Then Haley looked at Erin—or more specifically, at Erin’s cleanly shaved pussy.

Erin’s eyes went wide. My eyes went wide. We looked at each other, full of what-the-fuck surprise. Erin had never been with another woman. She’d even gone as far as saying that she’d never be with another woman. Now, we watched in stunned silence as Haley crawled between her legs and kissed her smooth mound.

“Oh my God!” Erin’s cry split the air. She rocked back as Haley demonstrated that you never say never.

Lucas grinned at me. “Haley’s always cleaning up after my messes,” he said. He started to harden again.

I still hated him. I still wanted to smash his face in. But for a moment, I was too stunned by what I was seeing—especially when he sat back and gave me an unobstructed view to Erin's first girl-on-girl experience. Any hesitation or anxiety she may have felt was completely gone. She laced her fingers through Haley's hair as her friend ate Lucas's come from her pussy. Once again, Erin was right up to the edge of orgasm, her toes pointed out, one stiletto resting on Haley's back.

Haley sensed it, backing off enough to draw a protest from my wife. "Please, don't stop." Her voice nearly broke with desperation.

Haley teased Erin, running a thumb across her pussy as she sat up on her knees. "Okay."

With their eyes locked on one another, Haley flicked her tongue across Erin's clit. Erin tensed, groaning, her eyes fluttering shut. Haley added her fingers to the mix, twisting them, coating them in Erin's wetness.

Lucas slid up behind Haley, grabbed her narrow hips, and positioned her right up against his cock. Without preface, he drove himself into his wife's pussy. Her moan rippled over Erin's sex, eliciting a moan of Erin's own.

I could have sat watching that forever, but when Erin crooked her finger in my direction, I obeyed. I crawled over to her, brushing her damp hair off her forehead. I'd never seen her so drunk on sex.

I kissed her between her gasps, tweaking her nipples. Her skin felt like fire under my palm. Her heart hammered against her ribs.

She broke the kiss. Looked up at me.

"I want to suck you," she said. How crazy was this? I was the one swinging my leg over Erin's head and lowering myself onto her face, and she was the one in complete control. She circled her fingers around my cock and swallowed the tip, teasing me. Her moans hummed about

my length. I'd been holding out for too long. At this rate, I wasn't going to last.

Erin came first. Her orgasm hit her hard enough that she couldn't maintain her mouth on me. I bounced free as she fought to quiet her explosive orgasm.

It was the sight of Haley looking up at Erin, her chin glistening, that did me in. I exploded before I could stop myself. She collected me into her mouth as swiftly as her sex addled brain could, but not before catching a couple blasts of come across her pretty face.

I slumped against the sofa as Erin relaxed beside me. My blood cooled with the release, but the scene did not.

Haley kissed up Erin's stomach, fondling her breasts as Lucas sat back and watched. Erin's breath caught as the other woman swirled her tongue around her nipples. The blonde dragged her own breasts along Erin's body, making no mistake that this was a woman playing around with her. She pushed her knee against Erin's sex with her own riding Erin's thigh and she locked eyes with my wife.

Haley said "You've got a little something right here." She wiped a splatter of come from the bridge of Erin's nose and sucked it into her mouth, savoring the taste.

I groaned as their lips met, going from sweet to passionate in a matter of a few seconds. Unlike the kiss they'd shared earlier in the night, this one wasn't about teasing or titillation. This one was fueled with raw, genuine lust. Erin's hand went into Haley's hair as their tongues danced and their bodies undulated.

Haley drew back at last. Erin smiled up at her, brushing blond hair from the other woman's face. "That was fun."

"Definitely."

They kissed again, and for one blissful moment, I sank into the mattress and watched these two beautiful women melt into one another. It was soft where everything else on the night was hard. It was sensual where Lucas had been harsh. I could have watched that forever.

But then Lucas imposed himself on the scene. Again. And this time, I wasn't riding high on my own excitement. This time, as he moved in between the women, his cock in hand, it felt like an ambush. I opened my mouth to warn them, to stop this. I wasn't fast enough. Lucas pressed his cock against Erin's pussy and drove home.

Erin moaned, breaking the kiss, losing focus. She tipped her head back, shutting her eyes hard, clenching her teeth. Haley went to work on her neck, kissing her, licking her, driving her wild.

I watched Erin. I *studied* every short breath, every gasp. Another orgasm was building—another swell on this stormy sea was on the way. She wasn't just into it. She wanted more. She wanted to be consumed by this couple, by this strange cock and the even stranger touch of a woman.

Without the heat and buzz of anticipation anymore, I felt myself drifting apart from her, drifting away with each cry, with each drive of Lucas's cock.

"You like that, don't you?" Lucas demanded. The softness, the sensuality, it was all gone. Even the sense of competitiveness was gone. Erin was an exposed nerve, enraptured by an orgasm that wouldn't stop.

"Ah!" she groaned.

"You like my cock," Lucas repeated.

"Yes!"

Betrayal felt like acid, corroding everything that I'd once thought pure—even Haley as she pushed Erin onto her back and crawled up over Erin's face. Watching Haley position her pussy over Erin's mouth, watching Erin run her tongue along another woman's pussy for the first time in her life, should have been nuclear. It should have blown my mind. Instead, I looked down at my wife and barely recognized this woman—and for the first time since this all began, I didn't like it.

Lucas fucked Erin harder, goading her. "That's it, baby. Explore your inner lesbian."

Here it was, my ultimate fantasy—my wife with another woman—tainted by Lucas Hughes. He took something I'd been dreaming of and made it feel hollow.

I willed Erin to look at me. To snap out of it. To remember me as she debauched herself between these two. But she didn't. She kept on licking this other woman, swirling her tongue this time, teasing it up to Haley's clit.

"That's good." Haley gasped as Erin flicked her clitoris. "Yes, yes." She pinched her nipples, swirling the pale caps as her breathing grew shallow.

"Cock and pussy," Lucas said. "Haley loves the combination. I bet you do, too. Don't you?"

Erin moaned—whether in response to Lucas's question or not, I didn't know. I read it as much, though, another dagger stabbing through me. Lucas fucked her faster, harder. Haley bucked on Erin's face, raking her fingers through her long, blond hair. The threesome built and built, pushing me further and further away. I wasn't a part of this. I was on the outside, watching a porn starring my wife, and feeling all the raw betrayal that came with that. This must have been what Sean felt when he'd come home to his wife with her lover. This is that moment I'd been dreading would come all along.

"Fuck, baby, you ready?" Lucas demanded. His body glistened with sweat. His hips were a blur.

Erin's latched her lips around Haley's pussy, sucking, triggering her female lover's orgasm. Haley craned and swooned over Erin, a reed blowing in the wind. Her scream filled my ears.

Lucas joined his wife, ramming one last time inside Erin and exploding. He groaned, breathing loud and louder. A droplet of sweat fell from his nose onto Erin's soft, unblemished torso. He pulled out, unable to fully catch his breath.

"Fuck, yeah!"

Haley swiveled around, forming a sixty-nine with Erin—*forming a sixty-nine with Erin!* It was unbelievable. It was insane. It was the hottest thing that I'd ever seen.
And still I got up and walked out.

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THIRTEEN

The sitting room felt empty. Cold. I grabbed my pants and shirt, pulling them on. I had no plan. I had no destination. All I knew is that I needed to get out. Get away. I couldn't be a part of that anymore. I couldn't handle the destination that this journey had finally led us to. If it had just been Haley... maybe. Yes. But Lucas was too much.

And fuck, Erin should have *known* that.

With my coat in my hands, I left, slamming the door. If they hadn't noticed that I'd left yet, that should have done it.

The room that Erin and I had booked was five floors down. I took the stairs, needing to feel something mindless and physical. I took the stairs slowly, my spirit falling with each flight. I was adrift. I looked over the stairwell, where the flights spiraled down and down. There was something analogous there.

How had we let it get to this point? With each experience, we kept pushing and pushing until we nearly broke ourselves—broke our marriage. Annapolis led to the boathouse led to anal sex and threesomes and Lucas and Haley Hughes. The pot had been set to boil, we just never realized it until now.

Kids. We have children, a boy and a girl in the very first stages of life. How could we risk them? We'd played with fire and they were the ones who would have ultimately burned.

For the first time since this whole thing had started, I felt...angry. Angry at Lucas. Angry at myself for letting it get this far. Angry at Erin.

Angry at *Erin*.

But at the same time, I knew that we both let ourselves get to this point. Lucas was too far, Erin should have known

that, but I should have said something, too. What did that say about me?

Cuckold. Was that what I was? Was that what I secretly wanted to be? All I needed to do was think about Lucas looking at me, asking if I wanted to clean up the mess he'd left inside my wife, and I knew that I wasn't. Not fully.

Yet there were aspects that I did get off on. Most of Erin's teases, even the borderline cruel ones, were hot. That she kept me guessing was also a turn on. That she'd confessed her dirtiest fantasies to AJ was profoundly erotic because she had those fantasies at all.

As I descended the stairs, alone with my thoughts, I grew hard again. But enough was enough. Just because it was hot didn't mean it was a good idea. Our life was good, and here we were, doing our damndest to risk it all.

I arrived at the sixth floor with no clear plan. I paused at the elevators, seriously considering going back up and retrieving Erin. But that just felt...pathetic.

As I turned away, the elevator chimed. I held my breath and my hope, prepared to be disappointed when a stranger stepped out. The doors opened and there she stood, looking small and scared, wearing just a hotel robe. Erin, my love, my wife.

She hurled herself out of the elevator before the doors had even fully opened, throwing her arms around me and pressing her head to my chest. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry," she kept repeating. "I'm sorry."

I folded her into my arms, my comforting instincts kicking in. The anger I'd felt walking down the stairs was still there, a discordant tone in the background, but the need to reconnect came stronger.

"Come on, let's get to our room," I said.

*

"I'm sorry I brought Lucas into..." Erin stared down at her hands. We were sitting on the edge of the bed, the room illuminated by nothing but the bedside lamp.

"Into our bed?" I said, an edge to my voice.

Eri winced. "I thought..."

"Are you sure you did?" I asked. The question came tumbling out, harsh and ugly.

Erin's face tightened. She looked up at me defiantly, fire flickering across her face before it was gone again, just like that. When she replied, she was smoke again, wispy and exhausted. "I did. Or thought that I did."

The fire died in me, too. Neither of us had thought much about the consequences. "But?"

"I went too far," she said. "I...pushed things too much."

"Why? How?"

"I got...caught up in this fantasy. I guess I liked making you jealous, and I kept one-upping myself."

I nodded.

She slipped her hand into mine and leaned against me. "Lucas was too far. I should have realized that, but I was..."

"Too caught up," I finished for her. I could see how something like that could happen. We had momentum. I hadn't objected to a thing—not with AJ initially, not when she'd begun to flirt with other men, to go out for drinks with them. Not even earlier in the night, when I had every opportunity to shut it down. We all knew where the night was headed, even if it wasn't planned. Erin could have interpreted my silence as compliance... Could have? Or wanted to.

"I never meant to hurt you." Erin's voice was small beside me, as delicate as a bubble in that moment before it popped. Thing was, with that statement, I realized how much that she had.

"You slept with a man that I told you I didn't like."

She flinched, but didn't stay quiet. "It was all meant to be a tease. For us. You didn't like him, but you also..." She

hesitated, looking up at me through her dark bangs. "You also got excited."

I sighed. "I did. But...I guess some things really should remain fantasies."

Erin nodded. "I know that. Now, anyway."

We were silent again, each of us gathering our thoughts. This time, I spoke first. "Tell me honestly, Erin. Tonight wasn't just about the effect that Lucas had on me, was it? And it wasn't just about getting caught up in the moment."

She pushed her hair out of her face and bit her lip. "No, it wasn't just that."

I nodded. "You've always been attracted to Lucas, haven't you?"

Erin took a deep breath. "Yes, but I never, *ever* would have done anything if we weren't playing this game," she said, a touch defensive.

My response came with more bite than I intended. "Are we still playing a game?"

"Always. Nothing is real but what's between you and me."

"So you'd give it all up if I asked?"

"I would." Without hesitation.

"Even AJ?"

Erin laughed. "How could you even ask that? I'd give it up in a heartbeat. You've already been so..." She paused to stare at me. "*So magnanim—*"

"No. Stop." The safe word. She was about to use the safe word. For me. With me.

Erin blinked. "No?"

I blew out a heavy breath and scratched the back of my neck. "Look, tonight was too far. But... So this is confusing for me, because sometimes, I like the tease. I like being kept on my toes. I like this new...you."

"New me?" she asked, her head tilting a little.

"You're, I don't know, more forceful. More dominant. It's sexy to watch. I've never wanted to fight a man more than I

want to fight Lucas right now, and yet, thinking back to earlier, I get excited and confused.” I shook my head. “It’s all fucked up.”

Erin looked like she was composing her thoughts.

I went on before she could respond. “Don’t read anything into that. I still don’t like Lucas, and if I never saw him again—if *we* never saw him again—then it would be too soon.”

Erin turned to me, kissing me softly. She whispered, “Don’t worry, honey. I swear to you, I’m through with Lucas. I’m through with everything but you.”

“I know.” And I did.

“But Tom, you need to start being honest with me, too. I can’t read your mind, as much as I try. If something’s bothering you, then you need to tell me.”

I nodded. “I know. I *know*.”

She pushed me onto my back gently and made quick work of my jeans. She was naked beneath her robe, of course, and when she straddled me, she was still moist enough to sink into.

Part of that was Lucas, and despite all that I’d said, a part of me found that hot.

We groaned together, once again reunited.

“I’ll break it off with AJ tomorrow. We’ll get back to you and me.”

“Is that what you really want?”

She looked down at me. “It’s probably the safest route for us.”

That wasn’t an answer. Not a good one. Not a sustainable one. “There’s safe, and there’s *safe*.”

“So what are you saying, Tom? No more games. No more confusion.”

“I’m not saying that you need it, but I think that part of what’s happening here is that you’re exploring this new side of yourself. And that’s awesome. And exciting—for both of us. And I don’t think that we’re ready to stop. Either of us.”

Erin bit her lip. "But tonight. Lucas..."

"...was too far. Yes." I felt sweat build on my brow at the insanity I was about to say. "But maybe it's more of a teaching moment than a reason to stop."

"If you ever feel like things are going too far, you need to tell me."

"I will. But the same goes for you," I said. "We need to get better at this communication thing."

"So what comes next?" she asked.

"AJ told me he thinks you've got a wild side." I'd been carrying around that conversation for so long that when I finally said it to Erin, it felt cathartic. Why had it taken so long?

"He...I..." Erin blushed.

"It's okay, I'm not upset." I felt more embarrassed for Erin, like I'd confessed to reading her diary. But we needed to talk about this. "He explained it to me. I get it."

"Explained?"

"That some things are easier to talk to him about. Like, you're worried that I'd respect you less if you told me about them."

"Oh, Tom. That's not it."

"It's not? Maybe a little?"

"Maybe a little." Erin looked bashful. "But it's more like I was afraid to tell you."

"You shouldn't be, you know."

"I know that. Now." She kissed me, squeezed me, nuzzled my nose. "I'm still going to take a break from AJ, though. From this game."

She didn't have to, but I was happy that she was, if only for a little while.

"A break. That's a good idea. And when you're ready to start things back up with him..."

"...you'll be the first to know."

"Where did I find you?" she asked.

"It's funny. I was wondering the same thing."

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FOURTEEN

Despite our agreement to focus on ourselves, things still felt out of control in the week following the Birthday Incident. After all, we'd included others—people in our social circle, people we'd see and have to interact with. People we couldn't run away from.

I felt reckless. On my drive out of our neighborhood, I'd see people I knew—families I barbecued with—and cringe at their imagined judgment. I drove by the Hughes's large home and didn't even want to think about the inevitable confrontation that was to come. Lucas wasn't the kind of guy who'd be able to let something like that go.

At work, things were good. I had my first review at work as the regional manager. Apparently they'd done a 360 review with the regional directors, and they all spoke highly of my leadership—even Brian Benoit. That was a pleasant surprise.

We got the kids and the household ready for Halloween. We carved pumpkins. We put fake cobwebs up on the windows and installed a robotic spider above the front door. Martin changed his mind about what he wanted to be—again—and Erin had to go scrambling to assemble a skeleton costume with what was left in the stores.

I studied Erin through it all, but she was...Erin. At night, she organized crafts for the kids to do the next day. When Mary threw her two-year-old tantrums, she spoke to them in her most patient of voices—with only a sighed, *Goodness gracious* for protest. She sang to Mary when that didn't work.

When she caught me looking, she'd return a smile so bright I felt guilty for thinking the things that I did.

Of course, those things had happened. And there were consequences to those things. And like that, the feeling of

recklessness was back.

Tuesday night, when Erin didn't duck out early to hit the gym, it felt strange. Not strange bad, but just...different. As she got ready for bed, I collected her in my arms. "You don't have to stop seeing him, you know."

"I know." And she went on getting ready for bed.

*

Halloween arrived on a Saturday night. As we dressed up the kids, I thought about what the scene in the city must have been like. Halloween for adults—at least the young and single ones—was often an excuse to dress in something slutty and party. That had never been my experience, nor Erin's when she was younger, but I couldn't help but wonder if this new Erin would have been tempted. If AJ had invited her out to a house party, would she have gone as a sexy witch?

Instead, she dressed up as a regular witch, with long, black robes and a pointed hat over black jeans and a black sweater. "Don't think witches wore Chucks," I said as she put on her black Converse sneakers.

"Well, they would if they had to chaperone a bunch of kids around the neighborhood," Erin said. "Now go up and get dressed. We need to go."

Our neighbors were hosting a potluck, and we'd made a tradition of heading over there before going out trick-or-treating. Everyone would be there. The Hughes would be there. I sighed and went upstairs to put on my costume—the warm robes of a Jedi Knight.

When I came downstairs, Erin sidled up to me. "You can stay if you want. I can tell them that you're not feeling well."

That was enough to snap me out of it. I'd have to deal with Lucas eventually. Might as well get it over with. "Nah, let's do this."

When we walked up, the sun was beginning to set and the shrill cry of children playing filled the dusk. The Hughes were already there when we walked up, but so was most of the neighborhood. Lucas was dressed as a gladiator. Haley's costume was an angel and, although she was always cute, the long, white robes were hardly sexy. Still, I couldn't help but look at her wings and halo and think about how she'd gone down on Erin last week.

"Hey, guys," Erin said. "How have you been?"

"Good," Haley said.

"Tom," Lucas said with a nod at me. We shook hands, as you do. I met his eyes, forcing myself not to look away. He gave a short smirk, tightened his grip, then released my hand. He looked around. "What a waste of an opportunity," he said.

"How's that?" I asked.

Haley answered for him. "He's complaining that I didn't borrow Erin's white dress for this costume."

"Of course he is," Erin said. "Lucas is stuck trying to relive his early twenties."

"No trying about last weekend," he said through gritted teeth.

"That was just fun. This," Erin said, gesturing to the families, "is what's real and what counts."

We moved on, mingling with those families once again. Erin whispered, "I can't believe I ever thought he was attractive. Now I feel like a trophy on his wall."

"Temporary bout of insanity," I said. "But he served his purpose." I could still feel the coils of confused arousal, even in memory.

"He did." She kissed my cheek. "To remind me of what I have to lose."

I went back to the house after that to hand out candy at our door as Erin and Haley took the kids in a circuit down the street. It was an idyllic life we had here. We'd talked about moving, now that we could afford more, but I couldn't

imagine leaving it all now—even with Lucas living a couple streets down. Running from problems would get me nowhere but more problems. If he did cause more, I could deal with that.

Erin came back with Mary after about a half hour, the toddler already half-asleep. “I’ll take her up,” Erin mouthed. Another group of trick-or-treaters arrived.

Erin joined me once our daughter was down, still dressed in her witch’s costume. “It was nice to see Haley tonight,” she said. We sat in the living room, drinking wine and occasionally answering the door to hand out candy. “And it’s nice to see Martin and Andy together.”

“So things aren’t weird between you two?” I asked.

Erin blushed. “Well, not weird, exactly.”

“But you do think about it when you look at her.”

“Um...yeah. How could I not?”

“Tempted to repeat?” I asked, secretly hoping that she’d say yes.

Erin laughed. “No, not tempted. I mean, it was fun, but I’m writing it off as temporary, alcohol and lust-fueled, insanity.”

“Like Lucas.”

Erin shook her head. “No, not quite. After all, I still really like Haley.”

The doorbell rang.

“Trick or treat!”

*

The next week, when I met up with AJ, I was surprised when he announced that this would be our last session.

“Remember that client I was talking about a couple months ago?”

“Yeah.”

“Well, I just signed on with him. It’s gonna take me out of the area a bunch as the dude travels, so...this is it.”

“Just like that, huh?” I said with a smile. “Congrats, man.”

“Moving up in the world, brother. This guy’s connected. Should get me a lot more work if I don’t fuck it up.”

“Sounds like a great opportunity,” I said.

We worked out for one final time, AJ making sure I fully understood my routines. I only half paid attention. I had Erin on the brain. She’d said that she hadn’t seen AJ since the birthday weekend, and she definitely hadn’t been working out on Tuesdays and Thursdays, but in the past, she’d met up with him while the kids were in school. Had she done that in the last couple weeks without telling me?

The idea that she’d lie to me and sneak around behind my back was a troubling one, but it also sent a shiver of excitement up my spine. Sexuality, I realized, was such a mysterious thing. I knew that if I found out she’d cheated on me like that, I wouldn’t be able to get over it...yet it was erotic to think about regardless.

“I bet your married friend is broken up about the new job,” I said casually. My heartbeat hammered in my ears.

“Nah, she’s happy for me.”

Thunk. So she’d heard. So they’d been talking since.

“So you guys are still seeing each other?” I’m not sure how I kept my voice steady. My hands were shaking at my side. My heart practically crawled up my throat.

“Actually, no. She broke things off a couple weeks ago. Said she needed to focus on her family.” He seemed...down?

“Ah.”

He shrugged. “It happens. And it’s for the best. Just wish it could have lasted longer.”

“You like her.”

AJ glanced at me, and for a second, I thought I saw his macho facade melt away. For a second, I thought I saw true emotion in his hard face. Then the mask was back with a wide grin. “Sure, what’s not to like? She’s hot. She’s got a

filthy mind. And she's willing to do whatever I tell her. I had so much planned, man. So much."

"Well, you're not totally moving out of the area, are you? Who knows, maybe she'll look you up, once she sorts out things at home."

"Here's hoping."

*

"Aj just quit on me," I told Erin later that night, as we settled down in front of the television.

"Oh yeah?" She looked up at me knowingly. "Why's that?"

"I think you know."

"I may." I'd almost forgotten how much I loved the coy side of Erin.

"So you two have talked?"

"Just texts," she said. Her smile broadened until her dimples came out. "And maybe a pic or two."

"Appropriate ones?"

"Mmm..." She pulled out her phone and thumbed through it. "You tell me."

When she handed it to me, I sucked in a deep breath. The photo was of Erin posing in the bathroom mirror, completely naked. Her hair was still wet from the recent shower, slicked back, and her hip jutted to one side. I read the text immediately below it.

-Yes, still nice and smooth...

"Are you mad?" she asked, reaching between my legs.

She found the beginnings of my erection. I said, "Does it feel like I'm mad?"

"Well, you like the idea, but that doesn't rule out being upset about it."

"You haven't seen him since, have you?" I asked, fully knowing the answer.

"You know I haven't. I bet you even asked Aj about it."

"I did."

She lowered her head to my lap as she unzipped my pants. "You still don't trust me?"

"No, I do."

"Or were you hoping you'd learn something else?"

That hit closer to home than I cared to admit. "It just came up."

She fished my cock out and wrapped her hand around it. "I see." Dipping low, she took the tip between her lips, swirling her tongue along the crown. I groaned. "Anything else...just come up?"

It was hard to focus as Erin began to bob in my lap. She'd perfected her technique in the last half of a year, working me with her hand, mouth, and tongue in perfect harmony. "He seemed...sad that he wouldn't...get to see you anymore."

Erin didn't say anything, just kept blowing me, but she did seem to suck a little harder. Was she thinking about him?

"He's not moving away, you know."

"Mmm hmm," she replied, sending delightful vibrations along my cock.

I was careful to pick through what I said next. "And you know that we never said the safe word..."

Erin pulled her mouth off me, but kept her hand going. "What are you saying, Tom?"

"I'm not saying anything. Just pointing out that you're still free. To play."

Erin grinned. "Noted."

When she returned to the blowjob, I didn't last long. I closed my eyes and imagined her on AJ's cock, not mine, and when I exploded down her throat, I was pretty sure that I wasn't the only one imagining him.

FIFTEEN

We entered the holiday time warp after that. Thanksgiving came on fast, and before we knew it, we were cleaning up the ruin of our house after both sets of grandparents descended for Turkey Day and football.

After that, we got a Christmas tree and strung up the lights. As always, Erin was organized about the Christmas gift lists. Erin usually handled everyone but herself, including my infamously picky mother, and had most of the list taken care of by the first week in December. That left me to take care of Erin's gift, and this year I was determined not to put it off to the last second.

"So Tom, when's your holiday party again?" Erin asked casually one Saturday morning.

"Friday before the week of Christmas. Kind of late, but it was the best we could get." That's when I noticed her smile. She knew when my party was. She was asking for another reason. "Why?"

"Sounds good. Then you're free to watch the kids this upcoming Friday?"

"Sure." Then I asked again: "Why?"

"Well, AJ is in town. He was wondering if I wanted to get together."

I was waiting for this moment to arrive. "And what did you tell him?"

"That I needed to make sure that I didn't have any... conflicts." She raised her eyebrows. "Do I?"

"Always," I said with a grin. "But none that should hold you back."

Erin put her arms around me. "Good, because you know how I get with AJ." She kissed me. "I don't hold back anything."

*

The week leading up to her meet-up with AJ was tortuous in all the right ways. At work on Monday, I received a text from Erin.

-which do you prefer?

It was followed by two photos, each of her posed with the phone positioned in front of her face. In one, she wore a pale pink bra and panty set that I was fairly certain was new. In the second, she was completely naked.

-so?

As much as I loved her naked and natural, I loved the tease of the lingerie.

-tough choice, but first.

When I got home that evening, Erin was her usual self, dressed down in a plain white t-shirt and jeans. No mention was made of the texts.

Later, in bed, when I brought them up, she just smiled and said, "Does it make you horny thinking about it?"

"Of course."

"Me too." She laughed breathily, drawing me in for a kiss. "Think AJ will approve?"

"He's an idiot if he doesn't."

"I just shaved. Want to check if I missed anything?" She didn't wait for my response. She just pushed me down her body.

Of course, the most challenging part wasn't just the teasing from Erin, but an order from AJ.

"No sex?" I asked as we snuggled in bed after our shower.

"No sex. That's what he said. He's punishing me for the break up. Or whatever it was."

"You know, we could just...lie, right?"

“We could,” Erin said. “But this is sexier, don’t you think?”

“Yeah, it kind of is.” I ran my hand along her body. She wore a satin nightgown that felt smooth beneath my palm. I stroked the hem, brushing my fingertips across her bare, hot skin.

Erin looked into my eyes, began to say something, then stopped and looked away. Her cheeks were flushed.

“What?” I asked.

She began speaking without looking at me. “He...he told me that he wanted me to prepare for Friday.”

“Prepare how?” I felt pressure begin to build.

She reached into the nightstand and pulled something out, handing it to me. At last, she looked at me. She watched me as I studied the strange object. At first I didn’t have any clue what it was. It looked like a black chess piece—a squat bishop. One end was shaped like a rounded off cone, the other was wide and flat. I looked up at her. She was bright red.

“What is it?”

“A butt plug,” Erin said. She looked like she wanted to look away again, but resisted. She handed me something else—a tube of lube. “Could you...could you put it in me?”

I took a sharp breath, the sex toy in my hand taking on an entirely new meaning. We hadn’t had anal sex since a couple weeks back, after she’d done it with AJ. We hadn’t even talked about it. I looked at her. She was nervous, but beneath that, excited. She wanted more.

“Okay,” I said, drifting down between her legs. Hiking the negligee up her thighs, I brushed my hand across her smooth sex. She sighed somewhere above me, relaxing onto her back and opening her legs.

I slathered her asshole with the clear lubricant with one hand as I rubbed her clit with the other. Her pussy was practically dripping. Was she thinking about anal sex with AJ? Did it get her this excited?

I took hold of the squat dildo, my hands shaking. Taking a rattling breath, I ran its stubby nose along her clit, drawing a gasp from her. I looked up, checking her expression, and saw rapture on her face.

Down I dragged the plug, across her swollen, puffy lips, down the short bridge of her perineum to the puckered opening of her asshole. She gasped as I pressed it against that tight opening. I hesitated, checking her face again.

"Do it," she said with a tight nod.

I pressed the dildo harder, its wide head spreading her anus. Her body tightened over me as a soft, high-pitched keen leaked from between her clenched teeth. Her brow furrowed. She squeezed her eyes shut. Still I pressed until the fattest part of the plug opened her wide.

And then it was home, lodged up to the wide, flat base.

"There," I said. I was sweating for her, my heart racing despite the lack of exertion on my part. "It's in."

"Are you sure? Feels like it's not in all the way. Feels so... full."

When I made sure it was pressed to the base, she squirmed and moaned.

"Yeah, that's as far as it goes."

"Oh my...Tom, it's so..."

"Uncomfortable?"

Her laugh was strained. "Yeah, that. But also...God, I think I'm in love with how hot it makes me." Her hands traveled down her body, one checking on the butt plug as the other started rubbing her pussy. "I wish you could fuck me. Right now."

My cock strained. I wished I could, too. "I can, you know."

Erin looked down at me, her resolve tenuous. If I insisted, she probably would have given in. I didn't, and she shook her head at last. "AJ would punish me."

My cock strained even more at that, despite the protests that my ego made.

"Then let me help with this," I said. I dipped between her legs and ran my tongue along her slit. Her fingers moved into my hair, encouraging me as I ate her.

"Yes, honey. Yes. Just like that. Eat me as I get used to feeling a thick cock in my ass."

*

By Friday, we were bouncing off the walls. My balls felt like a pair of bowling balls, ready to tear through my pants. I used the butt plug on Erin Thursday night as well, and as I put it in, all I could think about was what Erin would do the next night with Aj. I'd thought that even with the month long break, I would have been fine, but the sex denial made everything harder. I was a walking hard-on.

Friday, we put the kids to bed together, like it was any old night, then Erin went upstairs to get ready. I busied myself on the computer, but didn't see any of it.

Erin came downstairs wearing a pair of jeans and a blouse like she was just running out to the store. The jeans were tight, of course, and the loose blouse had enough buttons undone that it made it risky to bend over, but it was nothing like her catwalk look last week. She was the sexy girl next door—and if truth be told, it was the look I preferred every time.

"How do I look?" she asked.

"Great." Her ass in particular.

She smiled, grabbing a scarf from the front closet and wrapping it around her neck. Her hair was loose, shimmering in the light of the front hall.

"So where are you going tonight?"

"I don't know. Aj says he's got a surprise for me."

I thought about the butt plug and figured I knew at least part of what the surprise was.

"Are you excited?"

She bounced on the balls of her feet. "So excited." She scrunched up her face. "That's bad, isn't it?"

"No, it's perfect." I hugged her, kissing her deeply. "Have fun. Can't wait to hear about it later."

She stepped back and zipped up her coat. "Don't wait up. Love you."

"Love you, too."

I felt buzzed as she walked out the door to meet up with another man for some debaucherous sex. Sleep would be hard to come by tonight.

*

I woke to the sound of the front door shutting. How something so faint could wake me was a testament to how shitty my sleep had been. I hadn't received any texts from Erin. No phone calls. Nothing at all but the queasy stirring in my gut.

I was worried for her. And excited. And nervous. And about a million other conflicting emotions that amounted to...well, really bad sleep.

When the door closed, I could practically feel the air inside the house shift. By the time she made it up the stairs, I was wide awake.

The woman who stepped into the bedroom wasn't the woman I'd expected. She'd been exhausted yet satisfied after Annapolis, like she'd just come back from a huge meal. After the boat house incident, I'd been asleep when she came home, but her attitude was much the same in the morning—exhausted, yet satisfied. The woman who stood in the doorway, her heels in her hand and her leather jacket long gone, looked the way I imagined she had after her triathlon. Haggard couldn't even begin to describe her.

I bolted out of bed as she moved into the room, unsteady on her legs. When I put my arms around her, she collapsed into me.

“What’s wrong, Erin? Did he hurt you?” Adrenaline surged through my veins as my imagination went to horrible, unspeakable places. If AJ had hurt her, I’d...kill him? Would I?

“No, he didn’t hurt me.” Erin’s laugh was almost a sigh. “Well, not the way you’re probably thinking, anyway.”

“What happened?”

She shook her head. “I have never been so thoroughly fucked in my life. This must be what it feels like to be hit by a train.”

“A train?” Was that just an unfortunate metaphor, or had AJ arranged for her to be fucked by a room full of men? And how messed up was it that I had no clue what the answer was?

Erin caught on a moment later, her smile brightening. This time, her laugh had more energy behind it. “Well, not a train. But there was another guy there.”

I think my eyes nearly popped out of my head. “What?”

“Yeah, I know. Like I said, intense.” I laid her into bed. She smelled good, freshly soaped and shampooed. She said, “I fell asleep in the cab.”

“Was it good? Did you have fun?”

She shut her eyes, smiling as she answered. “So much fun.”

I covered her up. I wanted to get the story. I wanted the reclamation sex. Now that she was home, I was keyed up and wide awake. But she needed rest, and I knew that if I waited, the story would be that much sweeter.

“Get some rest,” I said, pulling the comforter over her.

“Thank you, honey,” Erin said, her eyes already closed. “Tomorrow, I’ll tell you everything...”

And she was asleep.

I watched her for the longest time. Her face looked so smooth, so peaceful. I brushed her hair away from her face and traced her lips with my thumb. She smiled, crinkled her nose, but didn’t wake.

My hand drifted down her body, smoothing the blanket over her shoulder and the curve down to her waist. She shifted, turning onto her stomach and bringing her hands up out of the blanket. That's when I noticed the marks on her wrists. Marks that could only be made with some kind of restraints. My chest tightened.

So much fun...

She'd had sex with two guys?

I couldn't wait until tomorrow.

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SIXTEEN

Saturday played out like any other. I got up, made waffles with the kids, took them to the farmers' market. It was cold enough that we skipped the playground and headed downtown to the National History Museum, but things were...normal.

Only they weren't. Erin stayed home to rest—my idea, but something she was grateful for. I kept the kids occupied until lunch, when we returned and she looked fresh and bright once again. She fixed us lunch, then put Mary down for a nap as Martin and I went to work on a new Lego set I'd been suckered into buying at the museum.

Through it all, Erin kept smiling at me, a glint in her eye that promised things to come.

"You feel better?" I asked when Mary was napping.

"So much better. Thanks, honey, I needed that."

"And you're going to make it up to me."

Again, that smile. Again, that glint. "You have no idea."

I took Martin to the playground after all, bundling him up so he could run around and expend some energy. Erin and Mary joined us at the tail end, and soon the brisk playground was filled with their laughter.

I wrapped my arm around Erin, hugging her close as we watched our children play. "We've got a good life here," I said.

"For sure." She leaned her head on my shoulder. Her dark hair spilled out from beneath her white, knit hat, and the cool air had turned her cheeks red. "I still can't believe how lucky I am to have you."

"Funny, I was thinking the same thing." Then, because I couldn't help myself, I added, "And I can't wait to hear about last night."

She turned to me. The cold drew out her cheeks, particularly when she smiled. “Oh, I don’t plan on telling you a thing.”

Something moved inside me—anger, excitement, confusion. “That’s not what we agreed on.”

“Don’t worry, I have something better.” She grabbed the lapels of my coat, our breath clouding between us. “I’ve got a video of it.”

I kicked my lips. “A video?”

“Uh huh. Of every, filthy little detail.” How did she utter those words and look so angelic? “You once said you like the idea of me as a pornstar.”

“I don’t think that’s exactly what I said.”

She raised her brows. “So you don’t like that idea?”

“Well, I didn’t say that either.”

“Good, because tonight, you’ll see just how dirty I can get.”

*

After that, time seemed to move entirely too slow to bear yet entirely too fast to remember. I cooked... something. We read the kids a bunch of books. We put them to bed. But I seemed to move from that conversation at the playground to suddenly sitting in our basement in front of a television screen as Erin “got ready.” I held the remote.

“Go downstairs and press play. I’ll join you shortly.”

I held the remote gingerly, like it was a detonator or something. My heart rattled in my chest. What would I see there? How would I react? Would this be Birthday Night all over? I was still rattled by that night, by the force of my reaction.

There was also Erin’s final warning before I headed down here: “I did things that I’ve never done before, and I loved every moment of it. You’ll see. Just remember, I love you more, and I really love that I get to share this with you.”

“Like what?” I’d asked. She just shook her head and told me to find out myself.

So here I was, naked, as I was told, a blanket covering me as I lounged on the chaise portion of our sectional, and buzzing like I’d consumed too much caffeine on an empty stomach.

At last, I reached for the remote and hit play, quick draw style, like I was in a duel with the television.

It came to life, blank at first, then muffling, then full of bright, HD color.

It was AJ’s face filling the screen at first. He had the remains of a week-old beard dappling his hard face, a black baseball hat backwards, and...a camera strapped around it. A GoPro. When he nodded, the frame of the video bounced. I was getting his view. I was about to see what AJ saw.

“Not bad,” he said. “Little heavy.”

He turned, and there at his side was a black man I vaguely recognized. He had an open, charismatic quality about him—attractive, even I could admit, with short cropped hair and a tight goatee around his smile. His laugh came easily as he regarded AJ, but he held up his hand, blocking his face.

“Watch the face, man. Can’t let this get leaked.” His voice was deep and resonant. It stirred a memory. I *knew* him. But where?

AJ said, *“Relax. This shit’ll do more damage for the couple than to you. After that fappening celebrity leak shit last year, it’s practically cliché.”*

“Maybe,” the black man said, not totally convinced. “But I’ve got an image to maintain. My sponsors think of me as a wholesome, stand-up guy.”

AJ looked away, and for the first time, I realized that they were standing inside the men’s lockers at City Fitness.

“Don’t worry, Lamar,” AJ said, heading toward the exit. *“I’m not planning on gazing lovingly into that pretty face of yours.”*

“Lamar...Williamson?”

“The two-time gold medalist. *Time’s* Fastest Man Alive.

I jumped at Erin’s voice.

“Scared you?” she asked. She moved into the room wearing a short, black negligee, sheer enough that I could see her tiny panties. Her eyes moved to the screen and she gasped. “This is going to be...strange to watch.”

I followed her eyes. AJ and his POV camera had moved out of the locker room and into the gym. It was the downtown facility, the one I used to frequent a lot more at lunch before my promotion. The lights were low, casting a sinister glow across weight machines of the first floor. There weren’t any windows out to the street on this level, but even I felt exposed. AJ looked around, towards the open ceiling and the stairs up to the treadmills. It was even darker up there. The gym was closed.

None of it was the focus of our collective attention, though. It merely set the scene. Erin on video, stripped down to her pink bra and thong, was tied to the cross-over machine. She was posed with her arms out wide, her wrists in restraints attached to the cables that would normally be used to do butterflies. She was splayed out like she was on a rack. She had a ball-gag in her mouth and a blindfold over her eyes.

She looked up when she heard AJ enter. If she was scared, she didn’t show it. She just stood there, silent, expectant.

Beside me, the live Erin snuggled close. She whispered, “We went out for drinks first. And some light snacks. Lamar is very funny. Charming.”

Something moved inside my chest. My cock grew. I watched as they approached my bound wife.

“*Look at this fucking body,*” AJ said. He reached out, his arm appearing in perfect perspective, and ran his hand up her side and over her breast. Erin shifted, thrusting her

chest into his touch. *"Oh, someone's ready. You ready, my little slut?"*

Erin on film nodded her head. Erin beside me fidgeted.

"He calls you that a lot," I said.

I glanced at her, surprised to see her blushing. "Well, I kind of am. For him, anyway."

I said, "Because it turns you on."

"You know it does."

"How do you feel, watching it?"

On the television, AJ skimmed his hand down her flat stomach and pushed it inside her thong. *"Nice and wet,"* he said.

"A little embarrassed," she said.

"What else?" I asked.

"Dirty... Bad."

"Wet?" I asked.

"See for yourself." She took my hand and pulled it between her legs. I could feel the heat radiating off of her sex.

I watched AJ's fingers move inside of Erin's panties on the screen and her moan escaped around the ball-gag. I pulled her panties aside, finding her smooth pussy damp and slippery.

On screen, AJ's left hand moved into Erin's hair. He pulled her head back. *"Have you ever fantasized about being with a black man?"*

The woman on screen nodded, her forehead creasing.

I looked at Erin. "Really?"

She looked sheepish. "Maybe."

"Have you been thinking about it tonight?" AJ asked.

Again, the nod.

AJ moved around my wife's body, and suddenly there was Lamar, world athlete, naked and approaching my wife. If AJ was trying to maintain the man's anonymity, he was doing a terrible job of it, because his face was plain, his eyes dark and hungry.

Erin, beside me, groaned. "I didn't see this part," she said. "He looks like he's going to eat me alive."

"You have that effect on guys," I said vacantly, my attention on this new man in Erin's life. I couldn't not look at what he was packing, especially when the man reached down and took his cock into his hand. He was huge, bigger than AJ, longer and thicker and more intimidating.

Erin, in real life, moved into my lap. She didn't even bother removing her panties. She just pushed them aside, reached back, and lowered herself smoothly onto my erection. We sighed together, both focused on the scene in front of us.

The camera swung down as AJ kissed Erin's neck.

"*You like big cocks, don't you?*" AJ asked. His fingers kept working her pussy beneath her panties, and at this angle, I could see her shaved mound where her thong pulled away. "*Want to suck it?*"

Erin nodded. AJ pulled back and worked the straps of the ball gag off. On screen, she sucked in air, her moan cutting through the stillness of the empty gym.

AJ did something to the cords that threaded through the exercise machine. He placed a hand on her shoulder, running his thumb across the small iron man tattoo, before pushing her down to her knees. She went, her arms still restrained.

"*Open wide,*" AJ said, nodding at Lamar.

Lamar stepped forward and brushed the head of his cock along Erin's lips. She opened her mouth as he pressed home, nearly gagging as she discovered his girth for the first time.

Erin gasped beside me. "That's so obscene."

"It looks huge," I said.

"It was so huge." *Was*. A memory. This wasn't a fantasy we were watching. This wasn't a porn. It was real. It was history.

AJ continued to direct the action. *"That's it, baby. Show our friend how good your mouth feels."*

Erin began bobbing her head, taking more and more of the dark shaft into her mouth.

"You're so hard," she said to me.

"I can't believe that's you," I said, grabbing her hips as I began to thrust up into her.

"Gently. Gently," she sighed.

"Still sore?" Asking the question, as always, sent blood racing through me.

"So sore," Erin said between quiet moans. "You'll see why in a moment."

I tried to measure whether she felt any looser, anymore used. I think she did, although that could have been my imagination.

"Slower, honey. You feel good, just...go a little slower."

At last, Lamar spoke on the video. *"You're right, man. She's special."*

"Want to fuck her?" AJ asked.

"Hell yeah."

He didn't pull away though. Not immediately. Instead, he grabbed her head, held it still, and began to face fuck her. She gagged as he entered her throat, but didn't resist. Saliva escaped the corners of her mouth, frothing along his shaft and down her chin.

"Jesus," I groaned.

"I know, right?" Erin said. "Look at how filthy that slut is."

I chuckled. "You like it."

"Sometimes." She reached between her legs and began to play with herself. "But you haven't seen anything yet."

Back on screen, Lamar pulled out of Erin's mouth with a groan. The view shifted to AJ's hands as he loosened her restraints. AJ groaned, faltering at his task. A second later, I learned why—Erin had turned and wrapped her lips around him.

On the couch, I hugged my wife, cupping her breasts from behind. "You can't get enough of him, can you?"

Erin blushed, but didn't reply.

On screen, now that her right hand was free, she wrapped it around Lamar's saliva slick shaft as she bobbed on AJ.

"Damn, dude, this chick's insatiable," said Lamar.

AJ freed her left hand, and just like that, she was pumping AJ's cock in time with Lamar's.

After they let her go at it for a couple minutes, AJ said, "You ready to fuck her?"

Lamar's dark hand laced his fingers through Erin's hair. "Time to get fucked, baby."

Erin nodded and Lamar raised her back to her feet. AJ took her hands and restrained them in the cross-over machine once again. This time, however, with her hands behind her, she was forced to bend at the waist.

"Let's put this back in," Lamar said, stuffing the ball gag back into Erin's mouth before she could object. Her eyes went wide as he grinned. "Things could get pretty loud here."

AJ laughed. "Good call."

Lamar circled her like a predator eyeing its prey. AJ took a step back as Lamar edged around behind Erin. Bent over like that, arms behind her back, mouth stuffed with the gag, she looked so vulnerable.

Lamar's cock looked huge as he took it in his hand, long and dark and slick with her spit. Even knowing that this was a recording, I questioned whether she'd be able to accommodate that much girth.

From AJ's angle, I had the perfect angle to prove that she was. Lamar took hold on her, his dark fingers stark against her white hip, and placed his cock against her wet pussy. Erin grabbed the cables to steady herself as Lamar pressed into her, her moan leaking out the sides of her ball

gag. She shut her eyes tightly, taking him, getting used to him.

“So...what was that like?” I asked.

Erin, who’d been just as mesmerized as I was, hesitated before answering. “Uh...the same as AJ. Just bigger?”

That wasn’t exactly what I meant, and a moment later, Erin got it.

“You’re not worried that I went black and I’m not coming back, are you? I mean, I’m here now, aren’t I?”

That was exactly where my head was at, although it wasn’t so much worry as excitement. “Yes, you are.”

She teased, “But there certainly is something to be said about a big, black cock.”

Oh the video, Lamar continued to fuck her as she got used to his large member. Her toes curled under her. Her fists tightened on the cables as they worked up speed.

“He got so deep,” Erin said. “I felt like he’d burst out of my throat.”

“That’s so hot,” I said.

“It was.”

Lamar reached out, grabbing her by the shoulders and pulling her back as he banged her. Her muffled cries grew louder and louder as her orgasm built. Lamar grabbed her by the hair, yanking back. She crested, her body going off in a violent, euphoric wave.

“You like it rough,” I said. Not a question. More a comment.

Erin nodded.

Lamar stepped away from her, his cock still obscenely rigid. AJ released her hands and she practically collapsed to the mat.

“Yeah, my legs were so weak after that.” We watched as they led her over to another machine—a bench press with its barbell still in place, laden with more weight than I’d be able to lift. Two leather wrist restraints dangled from it.

"With the blindfold still on, I had no idea where they were taking me, or what came next."

"How did that make you feel?"

"Scared. Excited. Completely submissive."

"You like being submissive for AJ," I said. It wasn't a question.

"*Ready?*" AJ asked Lamar. For a brief moment, the camera swung over to the naked track star, his black body all muscle.

Erin, in my lap, said, "Mmm, wish I could have seen that."

"*Yeah, man. She going to be able to take it?*" Lamar replied.

The camera didn't dwell on Lamar, though, as AJ was far more preoccupied with Erin than the track star. He swept the camera along her backside, lingering on her heart-shaped ass. He reached out and grabbed it, squeezing the meaty flesh.

"*She's going to love it,*" he said. He slapped it. He took her by the hand over to the bench, where he laid back. From off the floor, he produced a bottle of lube. "*Did you prepare for me this week, like I told you to?*"

"Yes," Erin said.

"Prepare?" I asked her.

"You know... You helped me with it."

The butt plug. I groaned.

AJ took her hand and guided her into a straddle over him, facing away. "*Then this should be easy.*"

With the camera focused on AJ's greased cock and Erin's ass, I watched, enraptured, as he placed his bulbous cockhead popped into her asshole. It went in easier than I was expecting. Erin cried out—here, there, I wasn't sure. I was so focused on the sight of Erin's backside taking AJ's thickness inch by slow inch.

"*That's it, baby. Tell me you like that,*" AJ said.

Erin practically growled. "*I fucking love it.*"

"That's my girl. That's my slut." He looked up at Lamar, who was watching them hungrily, slowly pumping his enormous cock. *"Maybe one day I'll share this, but for now, it's all mine. Isn't that right, slut?"*

"Yes. All...yours..."

"Now, ready for the main event?" AJ asked.

In my lap, Erin was holding her breath, anticipation gripping her like a coiled spring.

AJ took Erin's hands and pulled them into the restraints of the bar. The position forced her to lean back and put all her weight onto the bar. *"Put your feet up on my knees,"* AJ ordered. She did as she was told, and the position left her splayed and open, her shaved pussy exposed and ready as AJ's cock pressed into her ass.

"What gets you more excited, feeling your first black cock, or feeling two cocks in you at once?"

Lamar stepped forward, pressing a knee onto the bench as he directed his cock along Erin's smooth pussy.

"I couldn't see any of this. And I had no idea how...huge he was. Until he—"

"Oh—OH!" Erin's moan off the screen completed her statement. Lamar dipped forward, pressing just the tip of his cock into her pussy. She arched back, thrusting her chest to the ceiling. *"Oh, so...so...so full..."*

"I can't believe I did that," Erin said hoarsely.

"I can't, either."

"It was so...intense. Like, total sensory overload. I've never felt so completely stuffed in my life."

On screen, the two men began fucking Erin in unison. Even the built-in stabilization of the GoPro was taxed as AJ grabbed Erin's hips and rammed up into her ass. The screen blurred, streaking dizzily through views of Erin's shoulder blades, her gritting teeth, and the long sweep of her body, where Lamar plundered his black shaft into her wet and white pussy.

"Fuck me," Erin moaned, reality echoing the video echoing reality. *"Fuck me!"*

I pulled Erin close, lifting my lips to her ear. She smelled good. Fresh. Familiar. "You're so sexy."

"So...full!" she screamed on the television.

"I love you, Tom."

"You close, slut? You ready to feel it deep in your ass?"

"I love you, too, Erin."

"Oh, my god!" the recorded Erin screamed.

"I'm coming! I'm—uh!"

My balls seized. My vision listed with the camera. "I'm coming!" I groaned.

"Oh my...oh my—"

Erin's scream was cut off as Lamar, above them, boomed a loud, "Fuck yeah!"

Her rammed into her, threw his head back, and gave into his own climax.

Erin in my arms lurched back, rocking her shoulders into my chest even as she ground her hips into mine. I felt the tickle of fingers as her body ignited in orgasm. It was all I needed. I exploded with the world around me.

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SEVENTEEN

It felt like hours later when we finally came down from our highs. The video had ended, the television now black.

"Wow," I managed to say at last.

Erin crawled off of me and curled up at my side. Neither of us bothered with the blanket. Neither of us needed it, welcoming the cold of the basement in November.

"Yeah, that's for sure. Watching it was like reliving it."

"Looked intense," I said.

"Oh, it was definitely intense." She kissed my neck. "The second time was easier."

I could feel my eyes go wide. Erin giggled. I said, "Really?"

"Yeah. Sorry, that one wasn't filmed. It just kind of happened...in the locker room shower as we were cleaning up."

Briefly, I watched her go to another place, returning to the scene again, being double teamed and loving it. It was a place that I could never take her, and that burned me up and turned me on. I wasn't angry. If I was upset about anything, it was that I didn't get to see that, too.

"Something about you and showers," I said.

She took my head in her hands. "Maybe. Probably more about the two, hard cocks that kept brushing up against my soapy body." She kissed me softly. "I'm just a sucker for that kind of thing."

"Sucker, huh?"

Apparently Erin hadn't meant it as a double entendre and started laughing when she realized what she'd said. "Well, there was some of that, too."

We kissed, sharing a soft, intimate moment that turned wilder, edgier. Even after the ravishing that I'd watched on camera, she'd gone for more. In my head, she'd instigated

it. I was afraid to ask if she had—what would she think of me for getting turned on by that? How would I feel if I was wrong?

But we had a deal, and I wasn't going to bottle it up any more.

"Did you ask for it again?" I asked.

Erin looked up at me with the most devilish of eyes. "Are you asking me if I was the one who wanted get DPed by two of the largest cocks I've ever seen?"

My wife using the term DP alone would have been enough to get me hard again. It was unnecessary. I was already ready for her.

Erin climbed into my lap, facing me this time, so we could stare at one another as she confessed her sexy sins.

"I told them how amazing it had felt to have them both inside me, and how it would be such a shame to pass up such beautiful erections."

"Oh, Erin..."

Her smile was wide, too innocent to be innocent. "Wish you could have seen it. They held me between them as they fucked me. I never realized how much those rooms echo, either. I'm surprised no one heard."

I wanted to tell her again that I loved her, that I wanted her. But the twisted images of Erin sandwiched between her lovers took over. I saw her moaning, hair wet, her eyes squeezed shut. I rode it out, thrusting harder and harder until I was once again grinding my teeth as I spilled my excitement deep into her.

"I love you, Tom," she said at last as our breathing returned to normal. "And I don't need anything else but you."

I thought about what AJ had said in what felt like another lifetime, about Erin being able to explore a side of herself with AJ that she never could with me. I said at last, "There's need, and there's want. And I'm not sure that I can give you everything that you really want."

Erin pulled back, her brow furrowed in a question.

I pressed on before she could voice it. "And I'm not sure that I want to, either. What we have is one thing, and it's amazing. What you have with AJ—what I just watched you do and what I imagine you did after—that's another. Make sense?"

"Yes. It does." When she agreed, it was like watching her let go of something stressful. She relaxed, lines in her face that I hadn't noticed vanished. She suddenly looked like the young woman I'd first met.

"I don't need to compete with guys like AJ. On some levels, I just can't."

Erin finished for me. "But on most, it's not even close." She nuzzled my nose. "I'd never trust AJ to do grocery shopping."

I laughed, and tried to do my best, Jersey Shore accent: "The G in GNC is for groceries, right?"

Erin covered her mouth, laughing more. It was good. Cathartic.

"One more important thing," I said.

Erin picked up on my seriousness and got quiet. "Yes?"

"If you ever develop feelings...for anyone else—even AJ —"

"It'll never happen."

"Sure, but if you did, we need to talk about it. Right away."

Erin nodded, wide-eyed and sincere. "Of course. I promise, Tom." She hugged me, long and tight. "So I take this to mean that you don't mind me seeing AJ when he's in town?"

Even with our new understanding, my chest tightened at the prospect. My cock stirred. "As long as I get to hear all about it."

She bit her lip, color springing to her cheeks. "You know, Lamar mentioned getting together again, too. How would you feel if I saw him from time to time?"

"Just him?"

She nodded.

"Love the idea."

Erin kissed me. "You know, there is one other fantasy that I have." Her voice was measured enough that I tensed.

"What's that?" I asked.

Erin took a deep breath. "Well, I know you have a thing for Jo—"

"No—"

"No lies, remember?" she teased.

"I just mean, it's not, you know, anything serious. More like a celebrity crush, like with Scarlett Johansson or something."

"Yeah, she's pretty hot," Erin agreed.

Did my wife just call another woman hot?

She went on. "But Jo's also not a celebrity. And I know for a fact that she's got a thing for you, too."

"Erin, this isn't necessary. I really don't need anyone else but you."

"This isn't about need," she said with a flushed smile. "It's about want."

The blush gave her away. "Whose want? Yours or mine?"

"Yes." She kissed me. "Yours and mine."

"Ours."

Was the future certain? No. Would there be challenges ahead? Of course.

But we were in this together, a team, a single unit that could take on anything, and there were so many new and exciting adventures ahead.

I said, "Well, I was having a hard time thinking of what to get you for Christmas..."